TEDDY ROOK BOOK · VOCABULARY LADDER

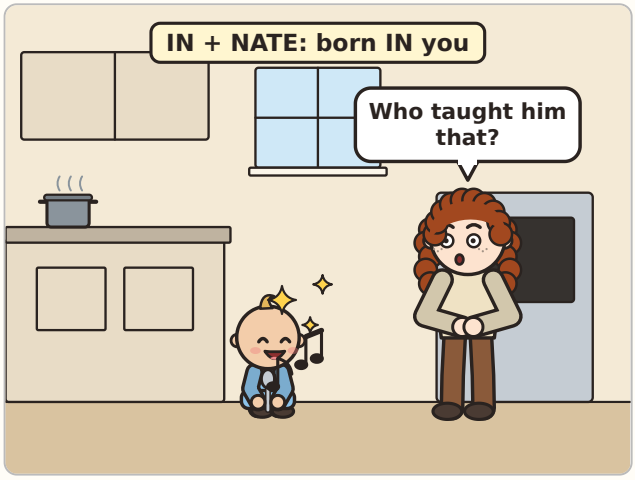
1,000 Words, Pictured

Volume 4 of 4 · Topics 76–100

Each card gives a word, how to say it (the capital letters are stressed), its meaning, a memory hook with a picture, an example and its Greek or Latin parts. To learn a word: say the hook out loud, picture the scene, then cover the card and try to recall the meaning. Come back to it tomorrow and again next week.

76. Inborn and Acquired
77. Waiting and Hurrying
78. Coaxing and Forcing
79. Insiders and Outsiders
80. Too Much
81. Flocks, Peace and Pleasing: greg, pac and plac
82. Spenders and Savers
83. Tricks and Schemes
84. Slippery Speech
85. Regret and Shame
86. Obvious and Seeming
87. Luck and Chance
88. Destroying
89. Secret and Hidden
90. Showy and Plain
91. All, Both, Good and Over: omni, pan, ambi, eu and hyper
92. Flatterers and the Bold
93. Leanings and Likings
94. Rare Words for Praise and Blame
95. Not What They Seem
96. Deep and Shallow Thinking
97. Old and New
98. Taking and Giving Up
99. Rebels and Factions
100. Harmful and Wholesome

innate ih-**NAYT** *adjective*



MEANING present from birth; natural rather than learned

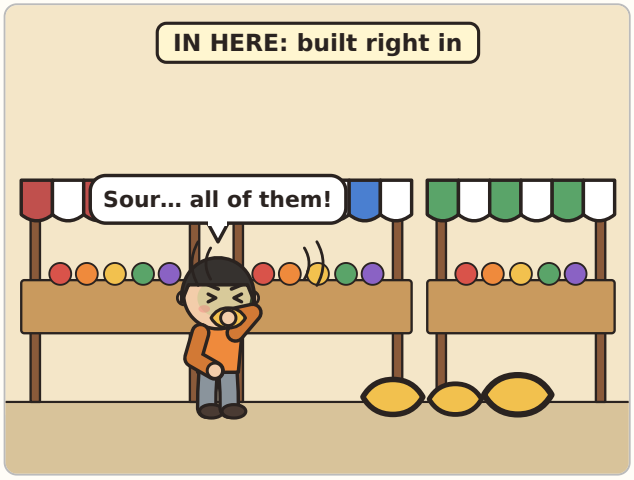
MEMORY HOOK **IN + NATE (born): born IN you.** Before he can even talk, Theo taps a perfect beat on his high chair with two spoons; nobody taught him: his sense of rhythm is **innate**.

Some people seem to have an **innate** *sense of direction.*

PARTS **in-** in + **nat** born

SIMILAR inborn, natural, native, congenital
OPPOSITE acquired, learned

inherent in-**HEER**-unt *adjective*



MEANING existing as a natural, permanent part of something

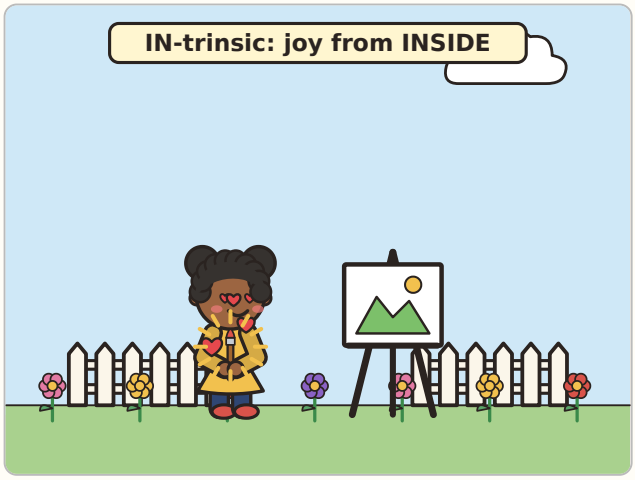
MEMORY HOOK **IN HERE: built right in.** Every lemon, big or small, is sour; the sourness is in here, part of what a lemon is: it is **inherent**.

A little mess is **inherent** *in finger painting.*

PARTS **in-** in + **her** stick + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR built-in, essential, intrinsic, basic
OPPOSITE extrinsic, external, added

intrinsic in-**TRIN**-zik *adjective*



MEANING belonging to the basic nature of a thing; coming from within

MEMORY HOOK **IN-trinsic: the joy comes from INSIDE.** Zoe paints all afternoon with no prize and no audience, just for the happiness it gives her: her reason is **intrinsic**.

Zoe practices piano for the **intrinsic** *joy of making music.*

PARTS **intr** within + **-ic** having to do with

SIMILAR inherent, essential, built-in, basic
OPPOSITE extrinsic, external

extrinsic ek-**STRIN**-zik *adjective*



MEANING coming from outside; not part of the thing itself

MEMORY HOOK **EX-trinsic: the reward comes from OUTSIDE.** Pip paints only because Victor is holding out a shiny medal for the winner; take the medal away and he stops. His reason is **extrinsic**.

Prizes and grades are **extrinsic** *rewards.*

PARTS **extr** outside + **-ic** having to do with

SIMILAR external, outside, outward
OPPOSITE intrinsic, inherent

instinctive in-**STINK**-tiv *adjective*



MEANING done naturally, without learning or thinking

MEMORY HOOK **in an INSTANT, no lessons needed.** The baby turtles hatch on the beach and, in an instant, head straight for the sea; no one shows them the way: the move is **instinctive**.

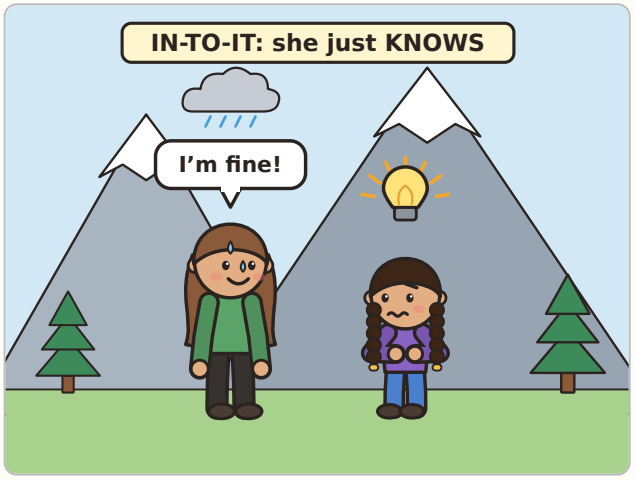
Pulling your hand back from a hot pan is **instinctive**.

PARTS **in-** on + **stinct** urge, spur on + **-ive** tending to, doing

SIMILAR automatic, reflexive, innate, unlearned

OPPOSITE learned, deliberate

intuitive in-**TOO**-ih-tiv *adjective*



MEANING known or understood without reasoning it out; also, easy to understand

MEMORY HOOK **IN-TO-IT: she just KNOWS.** Rosa says "I'm fine!" with a smile, but Lila can tell at once that something is wrong; she just knows, without a single clue: Lila is **intuitive**.

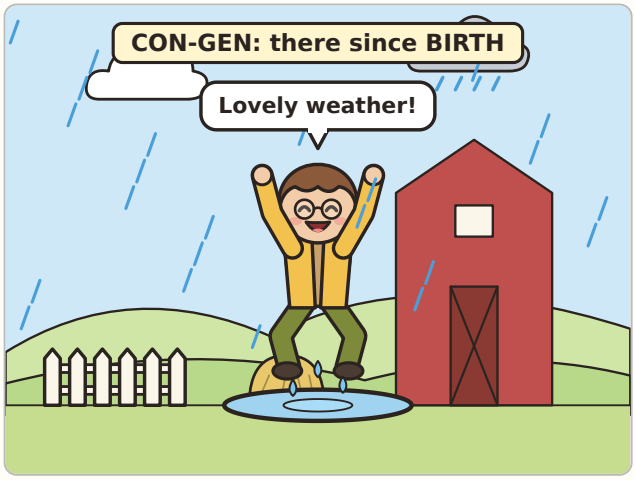
The new phone was so **intuitive** *that Grandma used it without reading the manual.*

PARTS **in-** at, on + **tuit** look, watch + **-ive** tending to, doing

SIMILAR instinctive, perceptive, natural

OPPOSITE analytical, reasoned

congenital kun-**JEN**-ih-tul *adjective*



MEANING present from birth; also, being so by nature, as if born that way

MEMORY HOOK **CON-GEN: there WITH him since BIRTH.** Felix has smiled at rainy days since he was a baby, and he still splashes in puddles, grinning: his cheerfulness is **congenital**.

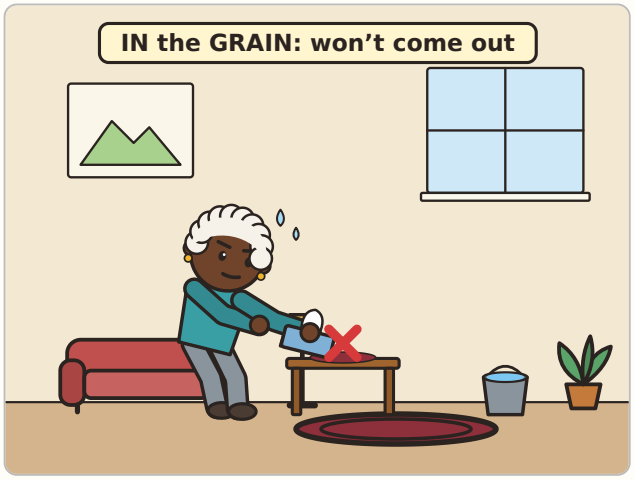
Uncle Felix is a **congenital** *optimist who smiles even in a rainstorm.*

PARTS **con-** with + **gen** birth + **-al** having to do with

SIMILAR inborn, innate, natural, born

OPPOSITE acquired

ingrained in-**GRAYND** *adjective*



MEANING firmly fixed by long habit; deep-seated

MEMORY HOOK **IN the GRAIN: it won't come out.** Nana Lou scrubs and scrubs, but the old jam stain has soaked deep into the wood grain and won't come out. Like an old habit, it is **ingrained**.

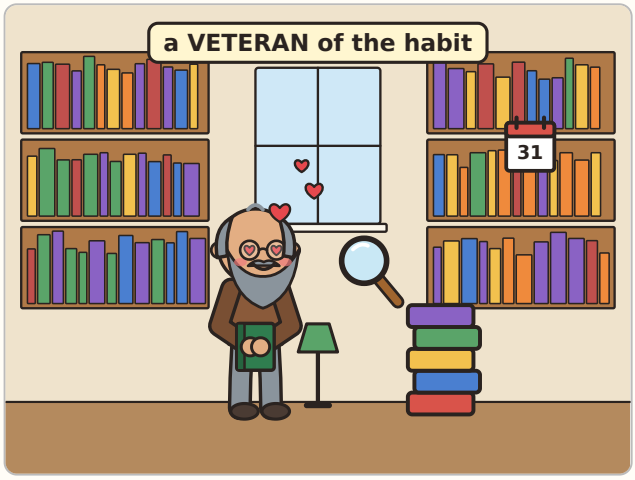
Saying "please" and "thank you" was **ingrained** *in us from an early age.*

PARTS **in-** in + **grain** the grain of wood or cloth

SIMILAR deep-rooted, entrenched, fixed, deep-seated

OPPOSITE shallow, superficial

inveterate in-**VET**-er-it *adjective*



MEANING having a habit so long-standing that it is unlikely to change

MEMORY HOOK **in-VETER-ate: a VETERan of the habit.** Professor Edwin has collected stamps every week for sixty years, a true veteran of the hobby: he is an **inveterate** collector.

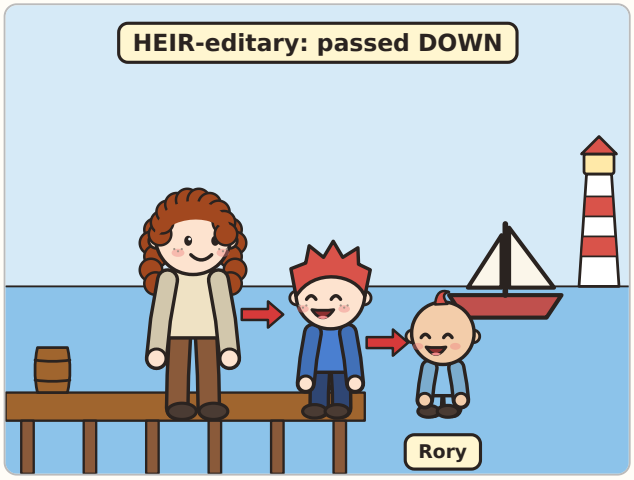
My aunt is an **inveterate** *traveler who has visited forty countries.*

PARTS **in-** in + **veter** old + **-ate** having the quality of

SIMILAR habitual, confirmed, chronic, hardened

OPPOSITE occasional, casual

hereditary huh-**RED**-ih-tair-ee *adjective*



MEANING passed down from parents to children

MEMORY HOOK **HEIR-editary: passed DOWN to the HEIR.** Nell, her son Pip and baby Rory all have the same bright red hair, handed down from parent to child: it is **hereditary**.

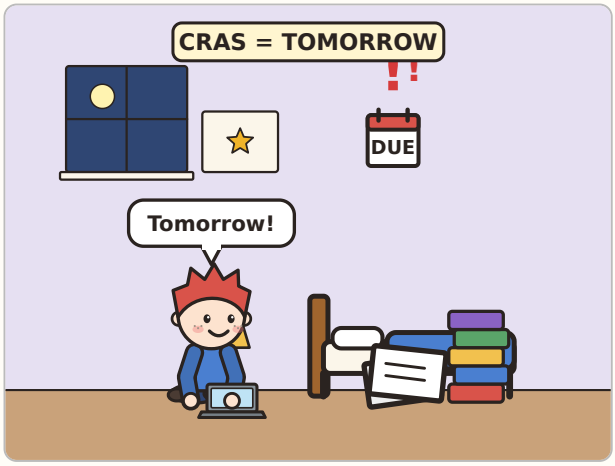
In the old kingdom, the title of duke was **hereditary**, *passing from parent to eldest child.*

PARTS **hered** heir + **-ary** having to do with

SIMILAR inherited, genetic, passed down

OPPOSITE acquired

procrastinate proh-**KRAS**-tuh-nayt *verb*



MEANING to keep putting off something one should do

MEMORY HOOK **CRAS = TOMORROW: always tomorrow.** The homework pile grows taller, but Pip keeps playing and saying, “Tomorrow!” He pushes everything to tomorrow: he **procrastinates**.

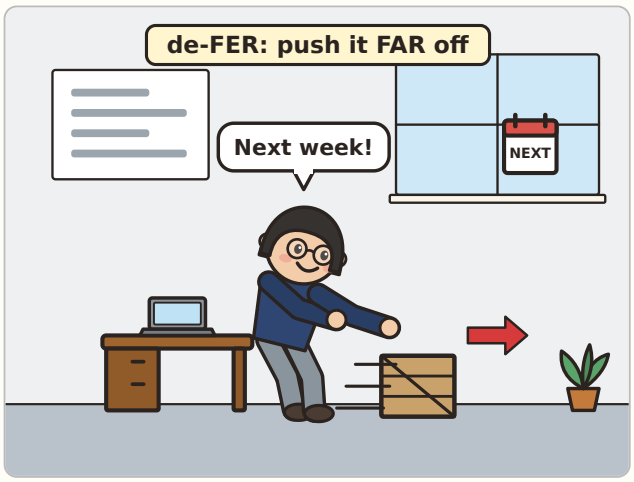
If you **procrastinate** *on your science project, you’ll be gluing it together at midnight.*

PARTS **pro-** forward + **crastin** of tomorrow + **-ate** to make, to act on

SIMILAR delay, stall, put off, dawdle

OPPOSITE hurry, act promptly

defer dih-**FUR** *verb*



MEANING to put off until later; also, to give way to another’s judgment

MEMORY HOOK **de-FER: carry it FAR off, to later.** Too busy today, Ada pushes the big cleanup box far off down the hall and writes “next week” on the calendar: she **defers** it.

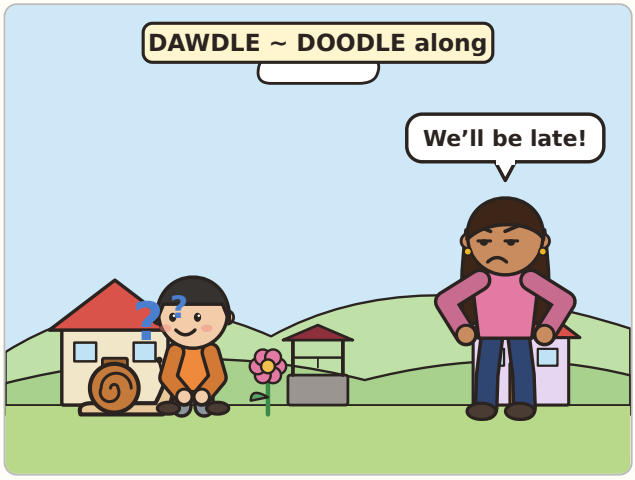
The club agreed to **defer** *the vote until everyone could attend.*

PARTS **de-** away, down + **fer** carry

SIMILAR postpone, put off, delay, yield

OPPOSITE advance, expedite

dawdle **DAW**-dul *verb*



MEANING to waste time; to move slowly and idly

MEMORY HOOK **DAWDLE ~ DOODLE: doodling along.** On the way to school, Kai stops to poke every puddle, smell every flower and count every snail while Mom waits up ahead: he **dawdles**.

Don't **dawdle***; the bus leaves in five minutes!*

SIMILAR dally, loiter, linger, dilly-dally
OPPOSITE hurry, hasten, rush

linger **LING**-ger *verb*



MEANING to stay longer than needed; to be slow to leave

MEMORY HOOK **LINGER = stays LONGER.** The party ended at nine, but Uncle Omar stays at the door telling one more story, then another, longer and longer: he **lingers**.

The smell of fresh bread **lingered** *in the kitchen all afternoon.*

SIMILAR stay, remain, loiter, dawdle
OPPOSITE leave, hurry

dilatory **DIL**-uh-tor-ee *adjective*



MEANING slow to act; causing delay

MEMORY HOOK **DILLY-DALLY-tory: slow to act.** The waiter strolls, stops to read the paper, then dilly-dallies some more while the hungry diners watch the clock: he is **dilatory**.

The **dilatory** *repair crew took three months to fix one pothole.*

SIMILAR slow, tardy, sluggish, delaying
OPPOSITE prompt, quick, punctual

belated bih-**LAY**-tid *adjective*



MEANING coming late; overdue

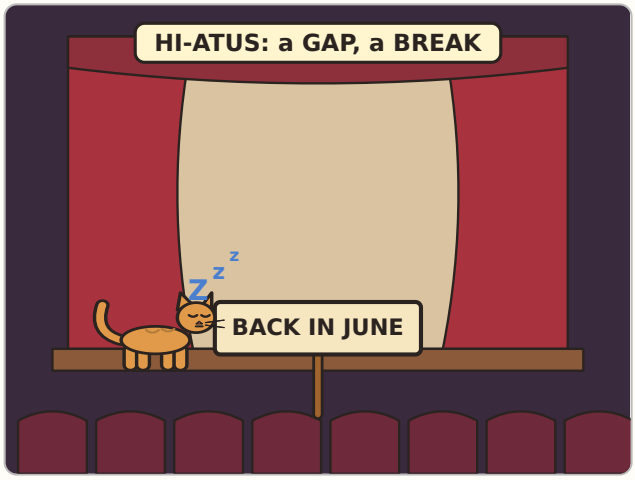
MEMORY HOOK **BE-LATE-d: LATE, but here at last.** A week after Zoe's birthday, Pip runs up with a card: "Happy birthday… last week!" His wishes are **belated**.

Grandpa sent me a **belated** *birthday card with an apology for being late.*

PARTS **be-** made, thoroughly + **late** late

SIMILAR late, overdue, tardy
OPPOSITE early, timely, prompt

hiatus hy-**AY**-tus *noun*



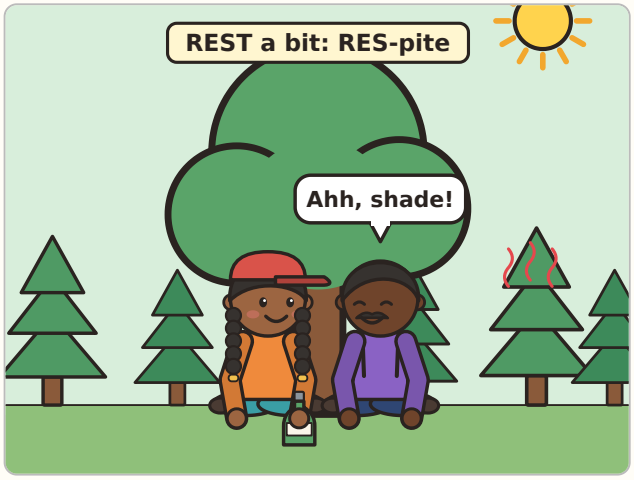
MEANING a break or pause in an activity

MEMORY HOOK **HI-ATUS: a GAP in the show.** The stage sits empty under a sign that says BACK IN JUNE, and only the theater cat is performing, by napping: the show is on **hiatus**.

The band went on **hiatus** *for a year while its members traveled.*

SIMILAR break, pause, gap, interruption
OPPOSITE continuation

respite **RES**-pit *noun*



MEANING a short rest or relief from something hard

MEMORY HOOK **REST a bit: RES-pite.** After three hot hours on the trail, the hikers flop down in the cool shade of a tree for a short rest: a welcome **respite**.

The shady oak offered a brief **respite** *from the heat.*

SIMILAR rest, break, relief, lull

hasten **HAY**-sun *verb*



MEANING to hurry; to make something happen sooner

MEMORY HOOK **make HASTE: HASTE-n.** The bus is pulling up, and Dev makes haste down the street with his backpack bouncing: he **hastens** to catch it.

We **hastened** *home when we saw the dark clouds.*

PARTS **haste** hurry + **-en** to make

SIMILAR hurry, rush, speed up, accelerate
OPPOSITE delay, slow, dawdle

precipitate prih-**SIP**-ih-tit *adjective*



MEANING done suddenly and without careful thought; hasty

MEMORY HOOK **PRE-CIPIT: rushing in HEADfirst.** One raindrop lands on Grandpa's nose, and he cancels the whole picnic at once without even looking at the sunny sky: his decision is **precipitate**.

Selling the house after one bad day was a **precipitate** *decision.*

PARTS **pre-** forward + **cipit (caput)** head + **-ate** having the quality of

SIMILAR hasty, rash, impulsive, sudden
OPPOSITE careful, deliberate, considered

coax KOHKS *verb*



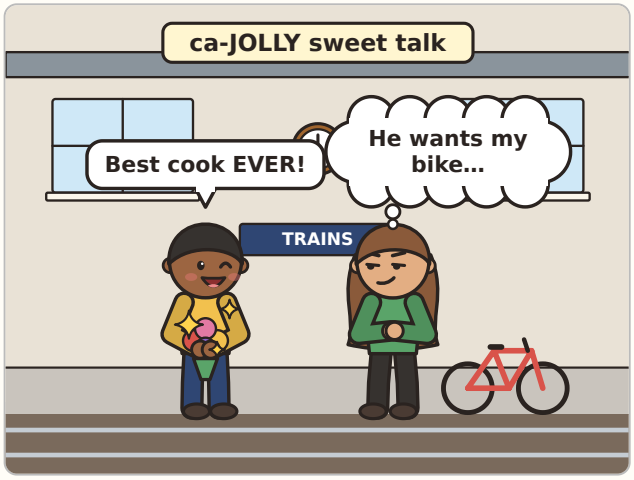
MEANING to persuade gently and patiently

MEMORY HOOK **COAX: "Come on, come on…" gently.** The kitten is stuck high in the tree, so Lila holds up a treat and speaks softly, "Come on, sweetie," until it creeps down: she **coaxes** it.

Lila **coaxed** *the frightened kitten out from under the porch with a little tuna.*

SIMILAR persuade, sweet-talk, wheedle
OPPOSITE force, compel

cajole kuh-JOHL *verb*



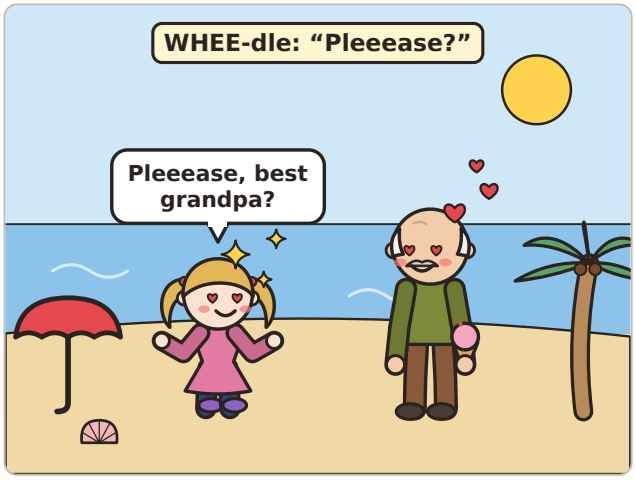
MEANING to persuade with flattery or sweet talk

MEMORY HOOK **ca-JOLLY: JOLLY sweet talk.** Dev praises his sister's cooking all week in his jolliest voice until she agrees to lend him her bike: he **cajoles** her.

Dev **cajoled** *his sister into lending him her bike by praising her cooking all week.*

SIMILAR sweet-talk, coax, wheedle, flatter
OPPOSITE force, coerce

wheedle WEE-dul *verb*



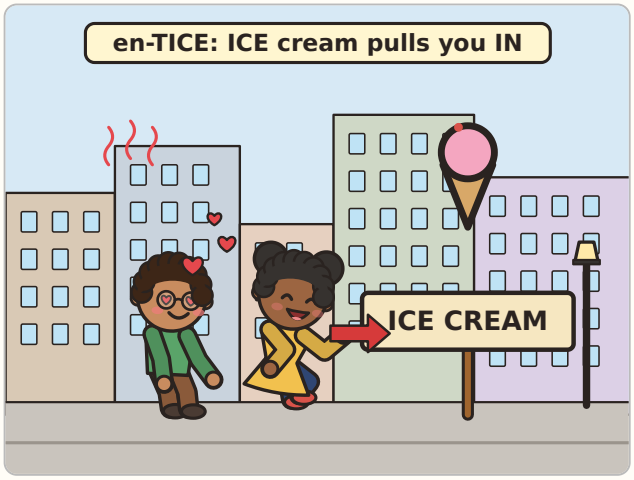
MEANING to get something by flattery or sweet talk

MEMORY HOOK **WHEE-dle: "Pleeease?".** "You're the best grandpa in the whole world," Ivy sighs. "Pleeease, may I have another ice cream?" She is trying to **wheedle** one out of him.

The puppy **wheedled** *a bite of toast from everyone at the table.*

SIMILAR cajole, coax, sweet-talk
OPPOSITE demand

entice en-TYSE *verb*



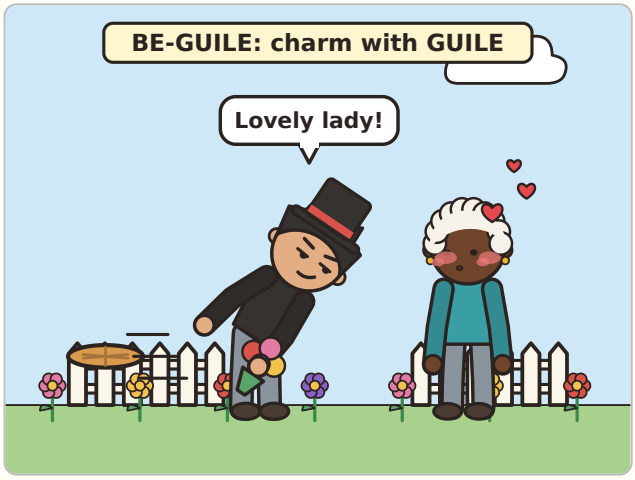
MEANING to attract or tempt by offering something pleasant

MEMORY HOOK **en-TICE: ICE cream draws you IN.** A big sign for cold ice cream hangs over the shop on a hot day, and everyone walking by turns and heads inside: the sign **entices** them.

The smell of popcorn **enticed** *us into the theater lobby.*

SIMILAR tempt, lure, attract, allure
OPPOSITE repel, deter

beguile bih-**GYLE** *verb*



MEANING to charm, sometimes in order to trick

MEMORY HOOK **BE-GUILE: charm full of GUILE (sly tricks).** Rex bows low and showers Nana Lou with flowers and compliments, and while she blushes, he slips her pie behind his back: he **beguiles** her.

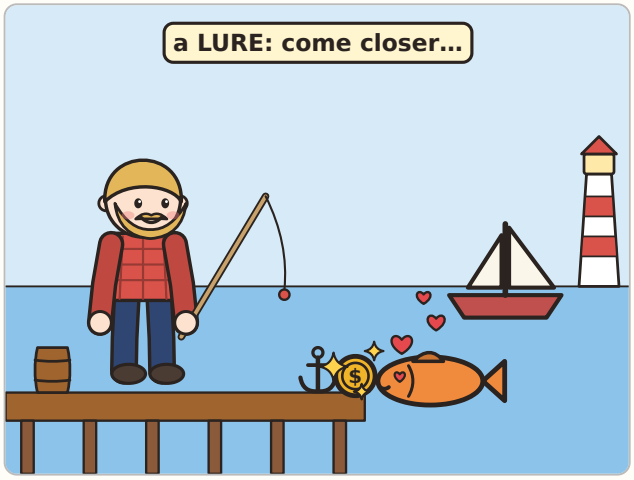
The singer's lovely voice **beguiled** *the whole audience.*

PARTS **be-** thoroughly + **guile** cunning, trickery

SIMILAR charm, enchant, captivate, deceive

OPPOSITE repel, disenchant

lure **LOOR** *verb*



MEANING to tempt someone to go somewhere or do something

MEMORY HOOK **a fishing LURE: come closer….** The shiny lure wiggles and sparkles in the water, and the curious fish swims closer and closer: the shine **lures** it in.

Bright porch lights **lure** *moths on summer nights.*

SIMILAR tempt, entice, attract, draw

OPPOSITE repel, deter

coerce koh-**URS** *verb*



MEANING to force someone to act by using threats or pressure

MEMORY HOOK **co-ERCE: co-FORCE, not asking.** Captain Rex points his finger and roars, "Scrub the deck, or no supper!" He doesn't ask; he **coerces** the crew.

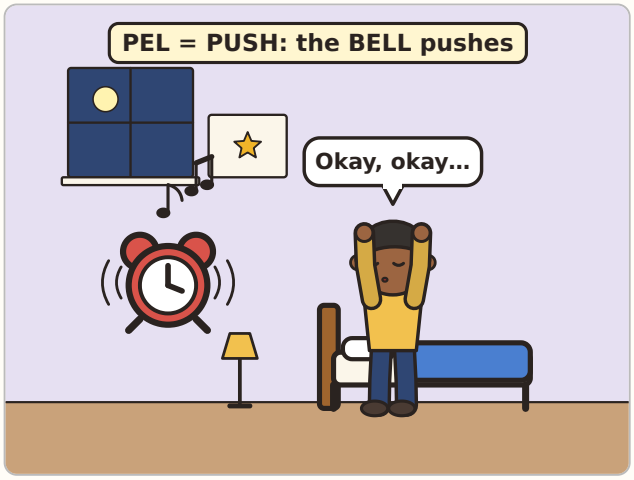
No one should be **coerced** *into joining a club.*

PARTS **co-** together, thoroughly + **erce (arc)** shut in, hold back

SIMILAR force, pressure, compel, bully

OPPOSITE coax, persuade

compel kum-**PEL** *verb*



MEANING to force or require someone to do something

MEMORY HOOK **com-PEL: the BELL pushes you up.** At six o'clock the alarm bell rings and rings, and Dev has no choice but to drag himself out of bed: the bell **compels** him.

The heavy rain **compelled** *us to cancel the game.*

PARTS **com-** together, thoroughly + **pel** drive, push

SIMILAR force, require, oblige, coerce

OPPOSITE excuse, exempt

browbeat **BROW**-beet *verb*



MEANING to bully someone with stern words and looks

MEMORY HOOK **a frowning BROW beats you DOWN.** Marcus lowers his bushy brows, glares and thunders until Sami gives up his turn at chess: Marcus **browbeats** him.

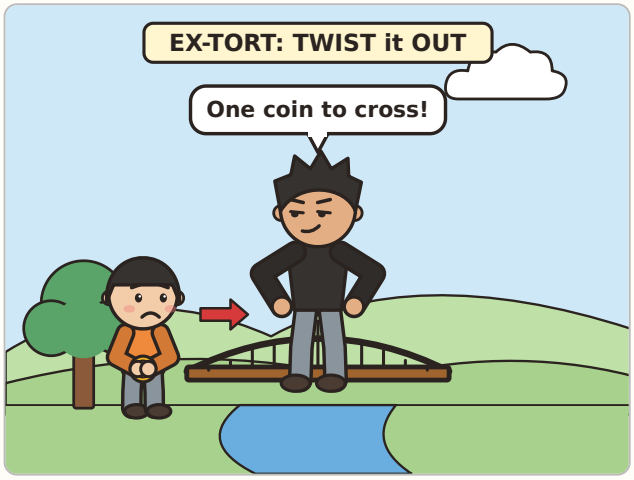
The bossy captain tried to **browbeat** *his crew into working through the night.*

PARTS **brow** forehead, frown + **beat** beat down

SIMILAR bully, intimidate, badger, hector

OPPOSITE coax, encourage

extort ik-**STORT** *verb*



MEANING to get money or something else by force or threats

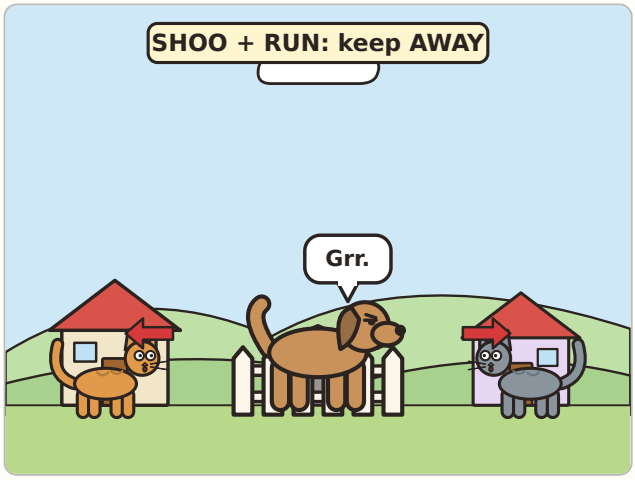
MEMORY HOOK **EX-TORT: TWIST it OUT of you.** Rex blocks the little bridge and growls that no one may cross unless they hand over a coin: he **extorts** money from every traveler.

In the old tale, the pirates **extorted** *gold from every ship that passed.*

PARTS **ex-** out + **tort** twist

SIMILAR extract, squeeze, wring, force

shun **SHUN** *verb*



MEANING to avoid on purpose, again and again

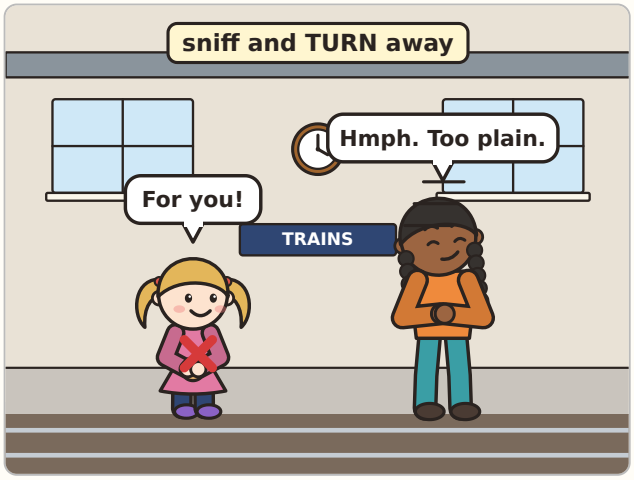
MEMORY HOOK **SHOO and RUN: keep far away.** Every cat in the neighborhood takes the long way around grumpy Rufus's yard: they **shun** it.

After the food fight, the twins **shunned** *the cafeteria for a week.*

SIMILAR avoid, steer clear of, shut out, ignore

OPPOSITE seek, welcome, embrace

spurn **SPURN** *verb*



MEANING to reject with scorn

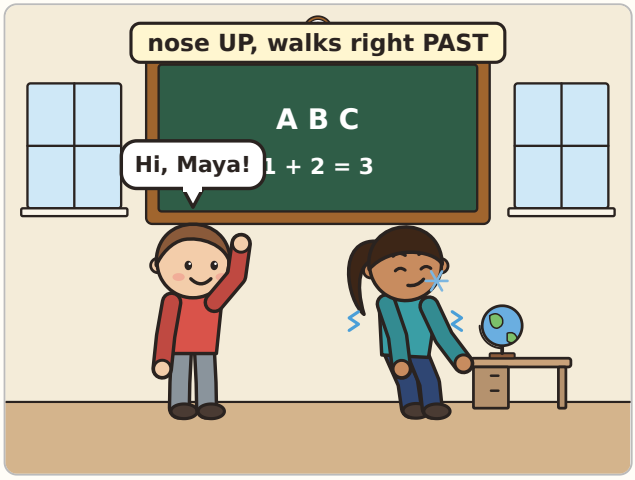
MEMORY HOOK **SP-URN: sniff and TURN away.** Ivy offers Aunt Tia a homemade cookie, but Tia sniffs, turns up her nose and turns away: "Too plain for me." She **spurns** it.

She **spurned** *his offer of help and fixed the flat tire herself.*

SIMILAR reject, rebuff, scorn, refuse

OPPOSITE accept, welcome, embrace

snub SNUB *verb*



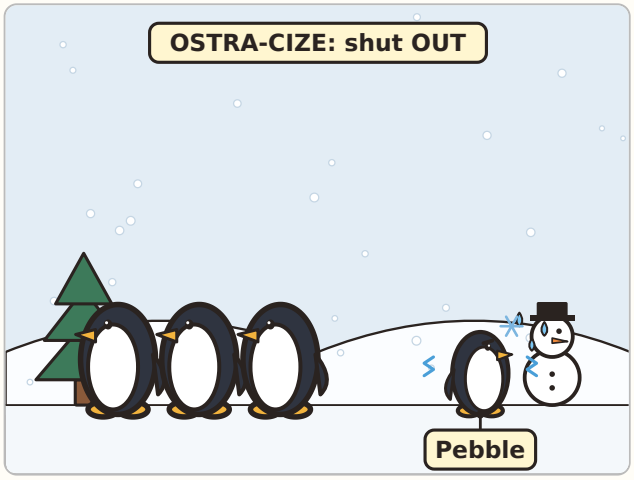
MEANING to ignore or treat coldly on purpose

MEMORY HOOK **a SNUB nose stuck in the air.** Jonah waves and calls, “Hi, Maya!” but she sticks her nose in the air and walks right past him: she **snubs** him.

Lila felt hurt when her old friend **snubbed** *her at the party.*

SIMILAR ignore, cold-shoulder, rebuff, slight
OPPOSITE greet, welcome

ostracize OS-truh-size *verb*



MEANING to shut someone out of a group

MEMORY HOOK **OSTRA-CIZE: shut OUT of the huddle.** The penguins huddle close together and turn their backs on little Pebble, who stands alone in the snow: they **ostracize** him.

No one should be **ostracized** *for liking different music.*

PARTS **ostrac** a piece of broken pottery (Greek) + **-ize** to make, to treat as

SIMILAR exclude, shun, shut out, cold-shoulder
OPPOSITE include, welcome, accept

banish BAN-ish *verb*



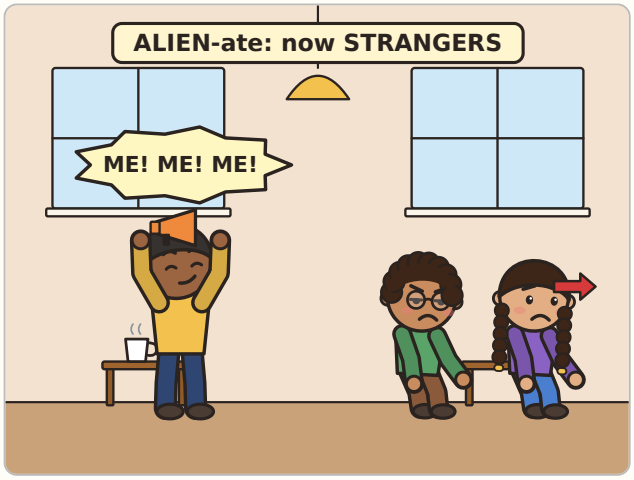
MEANING to send someone away as a punishment

MEMORY HOOK **BAN-ish: BANNED and sent away.** “You are banned from my kingdom!” the king declares, pointing at the gate, and the scheming Rex trudges off with his bag: the king **banishes** him.

In the legend, the king **banished** *the traitor to a faraway island.*

SIMILAR exile, expel, send away, cast out
OPPOSITE welcome, admit, recall

alienate AY-lee-uh-nayt *verb*



MEANING to make someone feel unwelcome, or to turn them against you

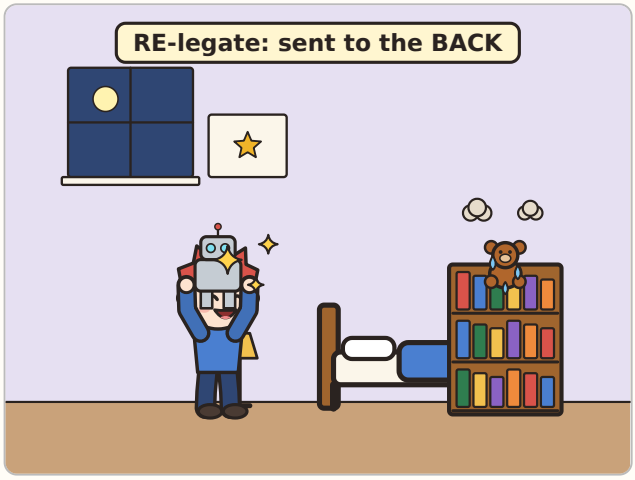
MEMORY HOOK **ALIEN-ate: friends turned into STRANGERS.** Dev brags and interrupts so much that his friends drift away one by one, until they feel like strangers: he **alienates** them.

His rude comments **alienated** *his teammates.*

PARTS **alien** belonging to another, foreign + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR estrange, drive away, turn against, push away
OPPOSITE befriend, win over, unite

relegate REL-ih-gayt *verb*



MEANING to move to a lower place, rank or position

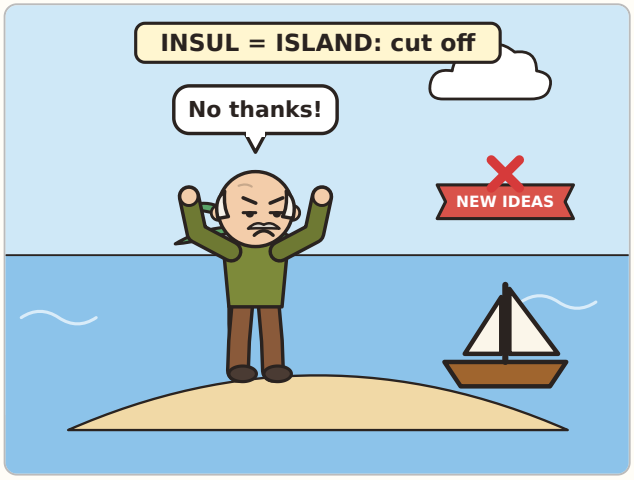
MEMORY HOOK **RE-legate: sent to the BACK.** When Pip gets a shiny new robot, his old teddy is moved to the dusty top shelf at the back: the teddy is **relegated**.

The broken lamp was **relegated** *to the attic.*

PARTS **re-** back, away + **leg** send + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR demote, downgrade, push aside, consign
OPPOSITE promote, elevate

insular IN-suh-ler *adjective*



MEANING narrow in outlook; cut off from outside ideas

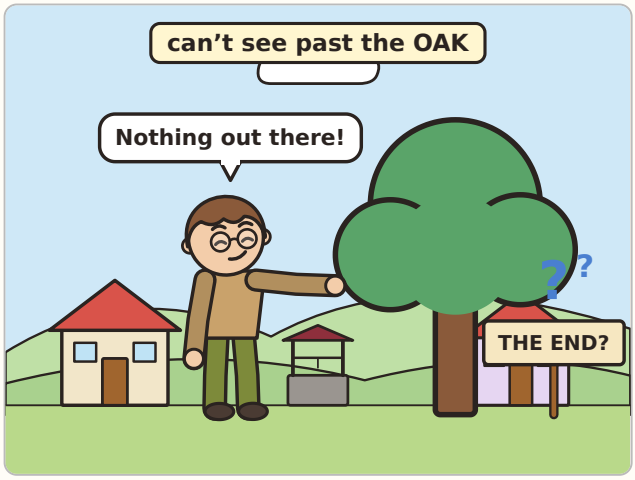
MEMORY HOOK **INSUL = ISLAND: cut off from the world.** Grandpa Gus lives on his own little island and waves away every boat bringing news and new ideas: “No thanks!” His outlook is **insular**.

The **insular** *little town rarely welcomed visitors.*

PARTS **insul** island + **-ar** having to do with

SIMILAR narrow-minded, inward-looking, isolated, parochial
OPPOSITE open-minded, cosmopolitan, broad-minded

parochial puh-ROH-kee-ul *adjective*



MEANING having a narrow, local outlook

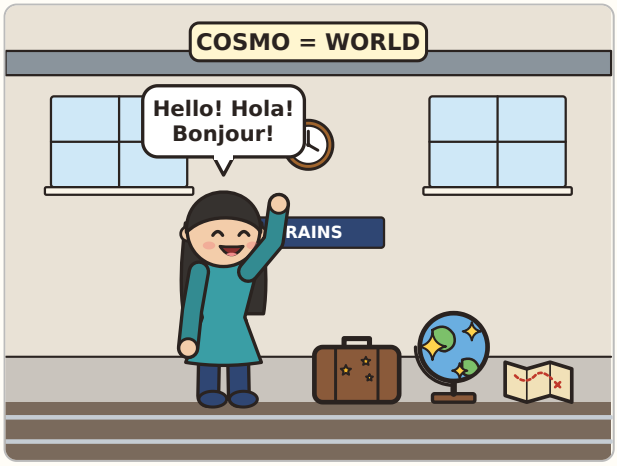
MEMORY HOOK **can’t see past the village OAK: par-OAK-ial.** To Uncle Felix, the whole world stops at the old oak at the edge of the village; nothing beyond it interests him: his outlook is **parochial**.

My cousin’s **parochial** *view was that nothing interesting ever happened outside our county.*

PARTS **paroch** parish, local district + **-ial** having to do with

SIMILAR narrow-minded, provincial, small-town, insular
OPPOSITE cosmopolitan, broad-minded, worldly

cosmopolitan koz-muh-POL-ih-tun *adjective*



MEANING familiar with many countries and cultures; worldly

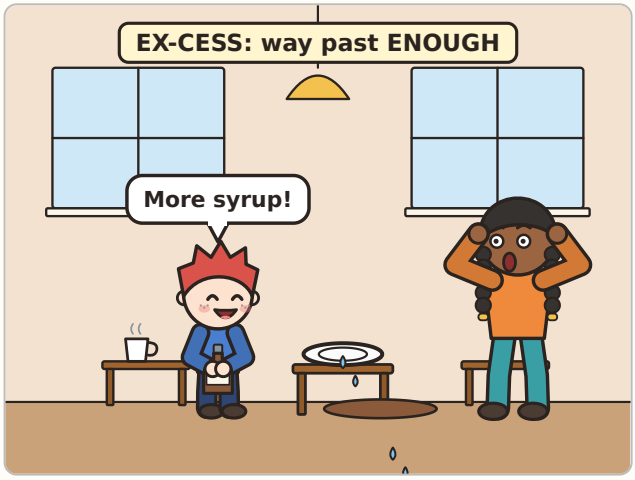
MEMORY HOOK **COSMO = WORLD: a citizen of the world.** Aunt Lin’s suitcase is covered with stickers from a dozen countries, and she greets everyone in their own language: she is **cosmopolitan**.

The **cosmopolitan** *city had restaurants from forty countries on a single street.*

PARTS **cosmo** world + **polit** citizen, city + **-an** one who, having to do with

SIMILAR worldly, sophisticated, international, broad-minded
OPPOSITE parochial, provincial, insular

excessive ik-**SES**-iv *adjective*



MEANING more than is necessary, normal or reasonable

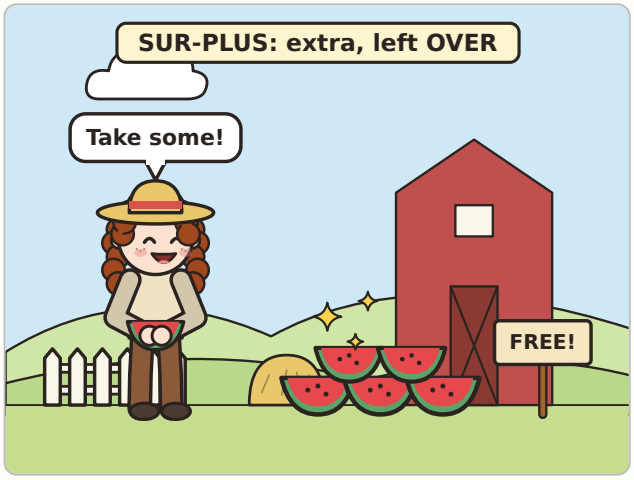
MEMORY HOOK **EX-CESS: way past ENOUGH.** Pip pours syrup on his pancakes until it floods the plate, drips off the table and puddles on the floor: the amount is **excessive**.

Ten straight minutes of honking seemed a bit **excessive**.

PARTS **ex-** out, beyond + **cess** go + **-ive** tending to, doing

SIMILAR too much, extreme, inordinate, undue
OPPOSITE moderate, reasonable, insufficient

surplus **SUR**-plus *noun*



MEANING an amount left over beyond what is needed

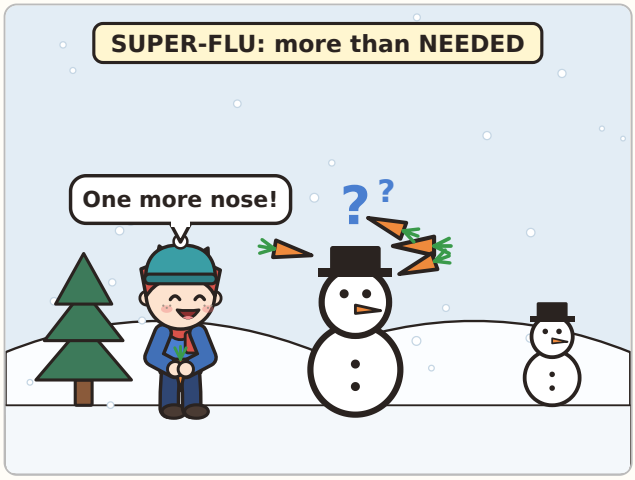
MEMORY HOOK **SUR-PLUS: over and PLUS more.** Nell's garden grows so many watermelons that she sets the extras by the road with a FREE sign: they are her **surplus**.

The bakery gave its **surplus** *bread to the shelter each evening.*

PARTS **sur-** over + **plus** more

SIMILAR excess, extra, leftover, surfeit
OPPOSITE shortage, deficit, lack

superfluous soo-**PUR**-floo-us *adjective*



MEANING more than is needed; unnecessary

MEMORY HOOK **SUPER-FLU: OVERflowing, more than needed.** The snowman already has a carrot nose, but Pip keeps adding more until there are five: four of them are **superfluous**.

With the sun shining all day, the umbrella turned out to be **superfluous**.

PARTS **super-** over + **flu** flow + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR unnecessary, needless, extra, redundant
OPPOSITE necessary, essential, needed

redundant rih-**DUN**-dunt *adjective*



MEANING unnecessary because it repeats something already there

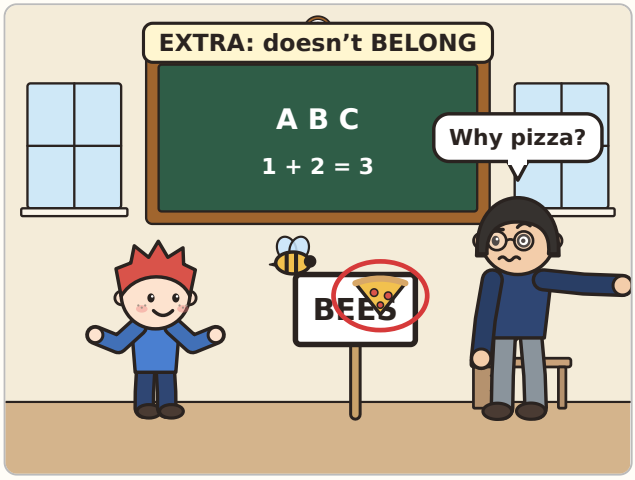
MEMORY HOOK **RE-DUN: done AGAIN, no need.** The shop sign shouts, "FREE GIFT! NO CHARGE! COSTS NOTHING!" Saying the same thing three times is **redundant**.

"Free gift" is **redundant**, *since every gift is free.*

PARTS **red- (re-)** again, back + **und** wave, flow + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR repetitive, unnecessary, superfluous
OPPOSITE necessary, essential

extraneous ik-**STRAY**-nee-us *adjective*



MEANING not belonging; unrelated to the matter at hand

MEMORY HOOK **EXTRA-neous: EXTRA stuff that doesn't belong.** Pip's poster about bees has a slice of pizza glued right in the middle: it has nothing to do with bees. The pizza is **extraneous**.

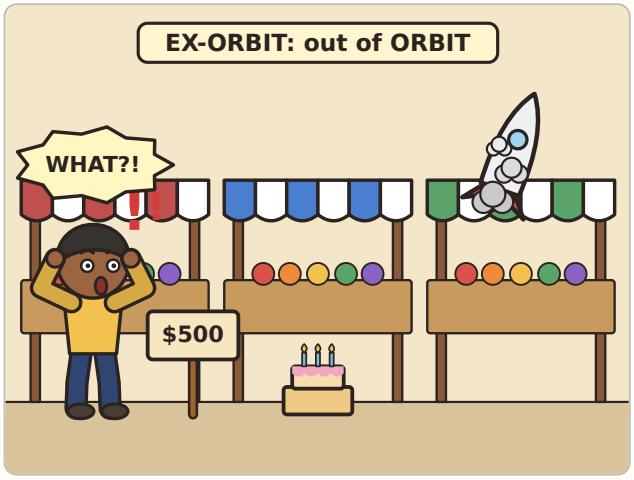
Remove any **extraneous** *details from your summary.*

PARTS **extra** outside + **-neous** having to do with

SIMILAR irrelevant, unrelated, beside the point, outside

OPPOSITE relevant, pertinent, essential

exorbitant ig-**ZOR**-bih-tunt *adjective*



MEANING far too high, especially of a price

MEMORY HOOK **EX-ORBIT: a price blasted OUT OF ORBIT.** One cupcake for five hundred dollars? The price has rocketed right out of orbit: it is **exorbitant**.

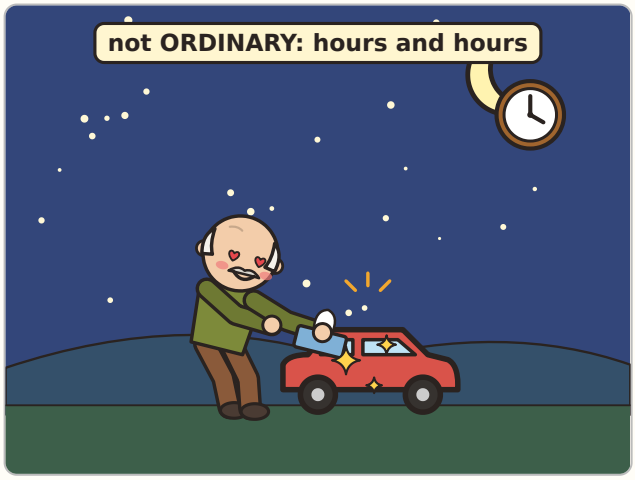
The airport charged an **exorbitant** *price for a bottle of water.*

PARTS **ex-** out of + **orbit** track, path + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR outrageous, sky-high, overpriced, steep

OPPOSITE reasonable, cheap, fair

inordinate in-**OR**-dih-nit *adjective*



MEANING far greater than is usual or reasonable

MEMORY HOOK **IN-ORDINATE: NOT an ORDINARY amount.** From sunrise to sunset, Grandpa polishes his old car, again and again: he spends an **inordinate** amount of time on it.

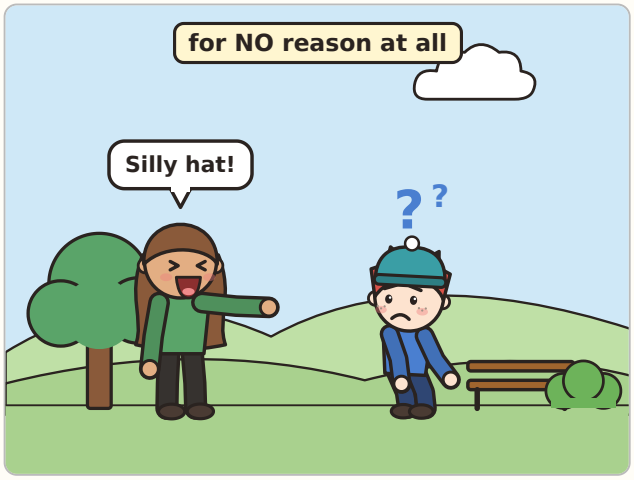
Pip spends an **inordinate** *amount of time choosing his socks.*

PARTS **in-** not + **ordin** order + **-ate** having the quality of

SIMILAR excessive, undue, disproportionate, unreasonable

OPPOSITE moderate, reasonable

gratuitous gruh-**TOO**-ih-tus *adjective*



MEANING done without good reason; uncalled for

MEMORY HOOK **GRATIS = for free: and for NO reason.** Pip walks by minding his own business, and Rosa calls out "Silly hat!" for no reason at all: the remark is **gratuitous**.

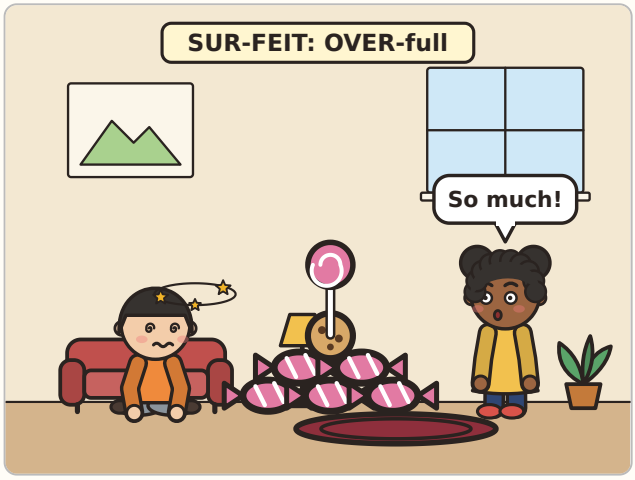
The movie was spoiled by **gratuitous** *explosions that had nothing to do with the story.*

PARTS **grat** favor, thanks (Latin gratia) + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR unnecessary, uncalled-for, unjustified, needless

OPPOSITE justified, necessary, warranted

surfeit SUR-fit *noun*



MEANING an amount that is too much; an excess

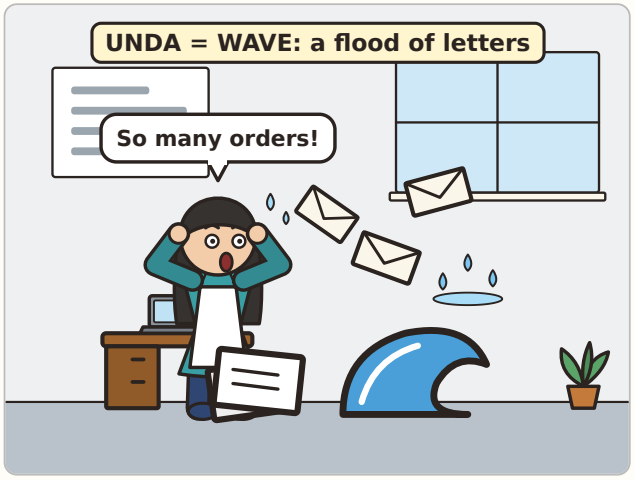
MEMORY HOOK **SUR-FEIT: OVER-full.** After the party, Kai and Zoe stare at a mountain of candy, far more than they could ever eat: a **surfeit** of sweets.

After the holidays we had a **surfeit** *of cookies.*

PARTS **sur-** over + **feit** done, made

SIMILAR excess, glut, overabundance, surplus
OPPOSITE lack, shortage, scarcity

inundate IN-un-dayt *verb*



MEANING to flood; to overwhelm with a huge amount

MEMORY HOOK **IN + UNDA (wave): a WAVE of letters rolls IN.** After the radio show, wave after wave of order letters pours into Lin's little bakery until she can barely see over them: she is **inundated**.

After the storm, the swollen river **inundated** *the low fields.*

PARTS **in-** in, onto + **und** wave + **-ate** to make, to act on

SIMILAR flood, overwhelm, swamp, deluge
OPPOSITE drain

gregarious grih-GAIR-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING fond of company; happiest when with other people

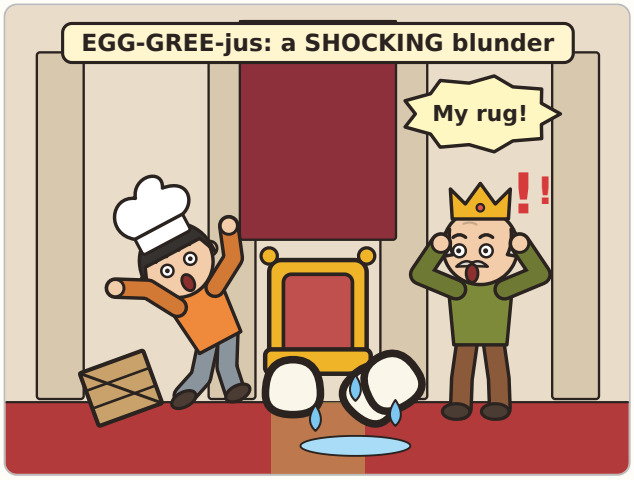
MEMORY HOOK **GREG and his FLOCK of friends.** Wherever Greg walks, a whole flock of friends tags along, laughing and talking; a man who loves company that much is **gregarious**.

Our **gregarious** *neighbor knows the name of every family on the block and most of their dogs.*

PARTS **greg** flock, herd + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR sociable, outgoing, convivial, friendly
OPPOSITE reclusive, shy, aloof

egregious ih-GREE-jus *adjective*



MEANING shockingly bad; standing out for being so wrong

MEMORY HOOK **EGG-GREE-jus: eggs on the king's rug.** The new cook trips and drops a whole crate of eggs on the king's royal rug; a blunder that stands out that badly is **egregious**.

Printing the wrong date on every wedding invitation was an **egregious** *mistake.*

PARTS **e- (ex-)** out of + **greg** flock, herd + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR shocking, flagrant, glaring, outrageous
OPPOSITE minor, trivial, slight

congregate **KONG**-grih-gayt *verb*



MEANING to gather together in a crowd

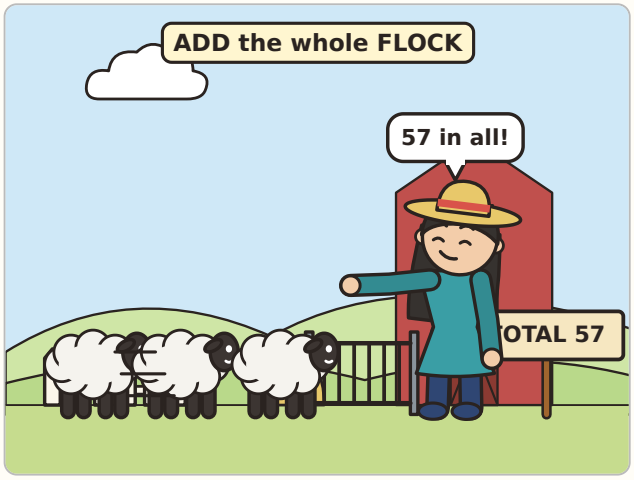
MEMORY HOOK **a CONGA line at the GATE.** When the band strikes up, the whole street forms a conga line at the garden gate; when people gather in a crowd like that, they **congregate**.

Every evening the ducks **congregate** *near the bench where Granny Mae sits.*

PARTS **con-** with, together + **greg** flock, herd + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR gather, assemble, flock, cluster
OPPOSITE disperse, scatter

aggregate **AG**-rih-git *noun*



MEANING a whole made by adding many parts together; a total

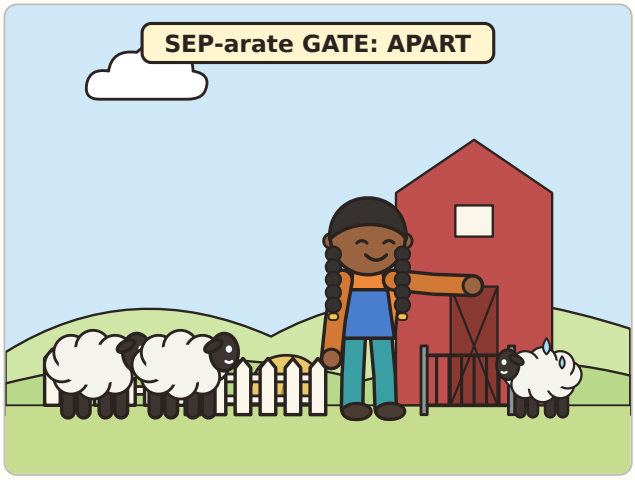
MEMORY HOOK **ADD the GREG (flock) through the GATE.** Farmer Lin counts the sheep from every field as they trot through one gate; the grand total of the whole flock is the **aggregate**.

The **aggregate** *of all the class's penny jars came to almost forty dollars.*

PARTS **ag- (ad-)** to, toward + **greg** flock, herd

SIMILAR total, sum, whole, mass
OPPOSITE part, portion, fraction

segregate **SEG**-rih-gayt *verb*



MEANING to set apart from the rest; to keep separate

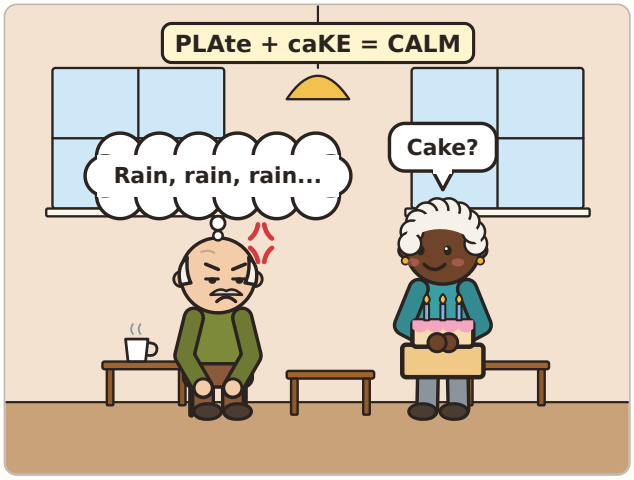
MEMORY HOOK **a SEParate GATE, apart from the flock.** The farmer leads the coughing lamb through a separate gate into its own pen until it is well; to keep it apart from the flock is to **segregate** it.

At the recycling center, workers **segregate** *glass from paper and plastic.*

PARTS **se-** apart + **greg** flock, herd + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR separate, set apart, isolate, sort
OPPOSITE integrate, combine, unite

placate **PLAY**-kayt *verb*



MEANING to calm someone's anger, often by giving them something

MEMORY HOOK **a PLAte of CAKE: calm at last.** When Grandpa Gus grumbles about the rain, Nana Lou sets a plate of cake in front of him, and the frown melts; she knows how to **placate** him.

To **placate** *the crying toddler, Dad offered him a ride on his shoulders.*

PARTS **plac** please, calm + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR appease, pacify, mollify, soothe
OPPOSITE anger, enrage, provoke

placid PLAS-id *adjective*



MEANING calm and peaceful; not easily stirred up

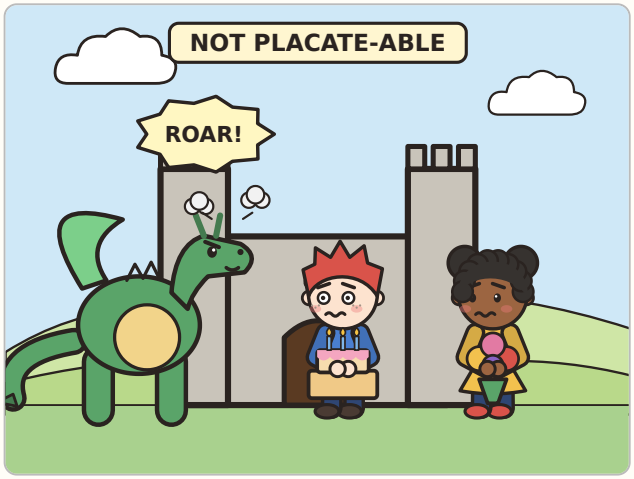
MEMORY HOOK **a PLACE to SIT: still water.** Grandpa's favorite place to sit is the river at sunrise, where not a ripple moves and even the duck dozes; it is **placid**.

At dawn the **placid** *lake held the mountains like a mirror.*

PARTS **plac** please, calm

SIMILAR calm, tranquil, serene, peaceful
OPPOSITE stormy, agitated, excitable, turbulent

implacable im-PLAK-uh-bul *adjective*



MEANING impossible to calm, please or change

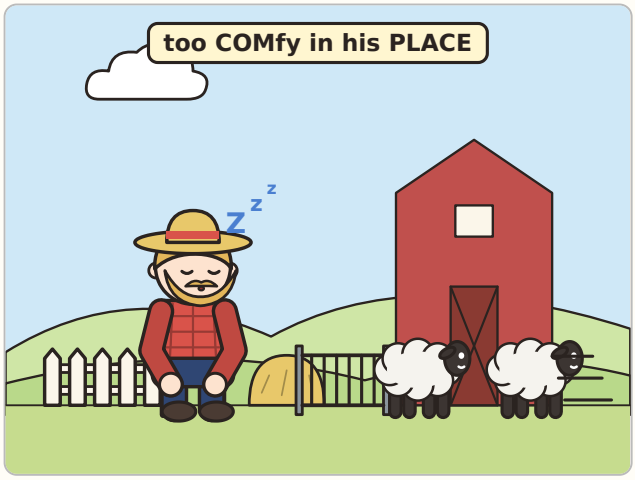
MEMORY HOOK **NOT PLACATE-ABLE.** The children offer the roaring dragon a cake, a song and a bunch of flowers, but it roars on; it is not placate-able, it is **implacable**.

The **implacable** *wind howled for three days without a pause.*

PARTS **im- (in-)** not + **plac** please, calm + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR relentless, unappeasable, unforgiving, unyielding
OPPOSITE forgiving, yielding, lenient

complacent kum-PLAY-sunt *adjective*



MEANING so pleased with oneself that one stops watching for danger or trying to improve

MEMORY HOOK **too COMfy in his PLACE.** The shepherd gets so comfy in his place that he naps while the sheep wander off; too pleased with himself to keep watch, he is **complacent**.

After ten wins in a row, the team grew **complacent** *and skipped practice.*

PARTS **com- (con-)** thoroughly + **plac** please + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR smug, self-satisfied, overconfident
OPPOSITE vigilant, alert, watchful

pacify PAS-uh-fye *verb*



MEANING to calm someone down or bring peace to a place

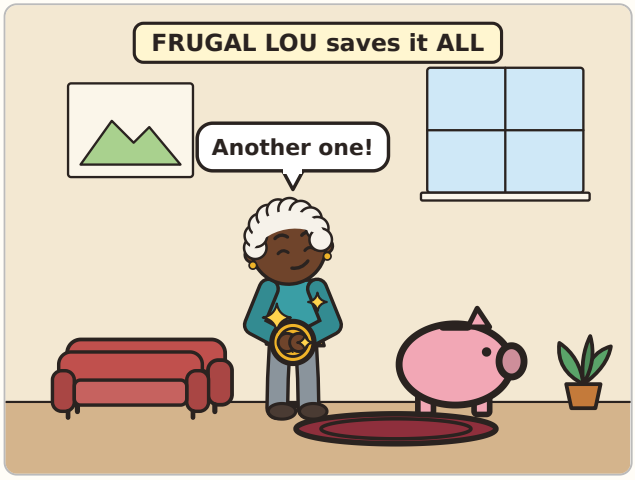
MEMORY HOOK **a PACIFIER makes PEACE.** A baby's pacifier is named for what it does: pop it in, the crying stops, and peace returns. It helps **pacify** the baby.

Rocking the cradle slowly was the only way to **pacify** *the fussy baby.*

PARTS **pac** peace + **-ify** to make

SIMILAR appease, placate, soothe, mollify
OPPOSITE agitate, provoke, enrage, inflame

frugal **FROO**-gul *adjective*



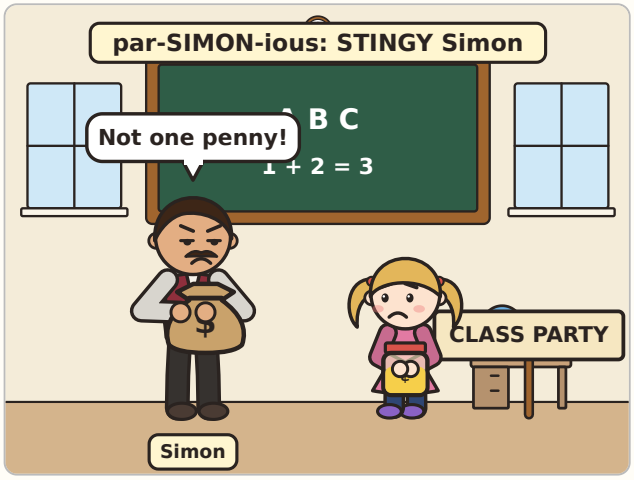
MEANING careful not to waste money, food or other things; thrifty

MEMORY HOOK **FRUGAL LOU saves it all.** Nana Lou saves every coin, even the one she found under the sofa cushion, and patches her coat instead of buying a new one; she is **frugal**.

*Our **frugal** grandmother saves twist ties, rubber bands and every jar that still has a lid.*

SIMILAR thrifty, economical, sparing, prudent
OPPOSITE extravagant, wasteful, lavish

parsimonious par-suh-**MOH**-nee-us *adjective*



MEANING so unwilling to spend money that one is stingy

MEMORY HOOK **par-SIMON-ious: stingy SIMON.** Look inside the word and you will find Simon, who hugs his money bag and will not chip in even a penny for the class party; Simon is **parsimonious**.

*The **parsimonious** landlord would not even replace the burned-out light in the stairwell.*

PARTS **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR stingy, miserly, tightfisted, penny-pinching
OPPOSITE generous, munificent, openhanded

extravagant ik-**STRAV**-uh-gunt *adjective*



MEANING spending far more than is wise or needed; going beyond reason

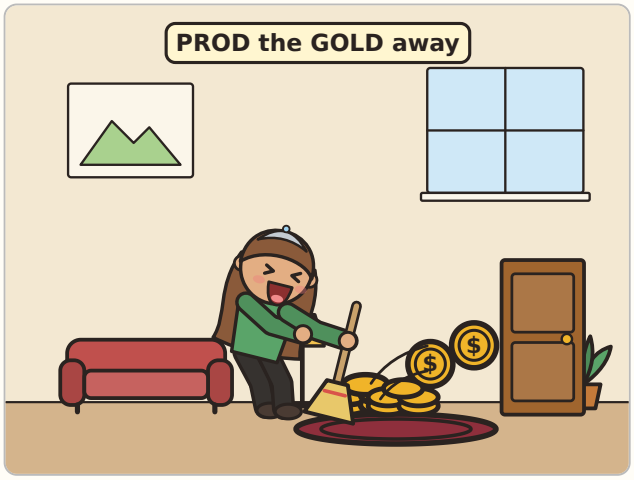
MEMORY HOOK **EXTRA, EXTRA, EXTRA!.** Mrs. Hale buys an extra cake, extra balloons and an extra band for her dog's party, just because; spending that far beyond what makes sense is **extravagant**.

*For her dog's birthday, Mrs. Hale threw an **extravagant** party with a three-layer cake and a hired band.*

PARTS **extra-** beyond, outside + **vag** wander + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR wasteful, lavish, spendthrift, excessive
OPPOSITE frugal, thrifty, economical, modest

prodigal **PROD**-ih-gul *adjective*



MEANING carelessly wasteful with money or other resources

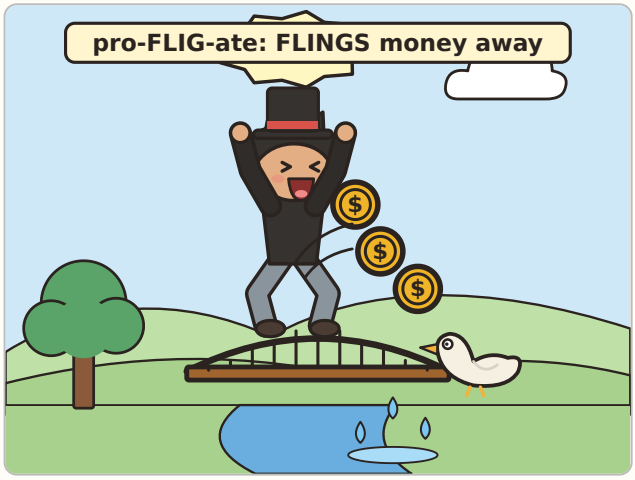
MEMORY HOOK **PROD the GOLD out the door.** Rich Rosa prods her gold coins right out the door with a broom, spending on anything that glitters; anyone that wasteful is **prodigal**.

*The **prodigal** young heir spent his whole fortune on racehorses in a single year.*

PARTS **prod- (pro-)** forth, away + **ig (ag)** drive

SIMILAR wasteful, lavish, spendthrift, excessive
OPPOSITE thrifty, frugal, careful

profligate PROF-lih-git *adjective*



MEANING wildly and recklessly wasteful

MEMORY HOOK **pro-FLIG-ate: FLINGS it away.** Rex flings handfuls of gold coins off the bridge just to hear them splash; spending money that recklessly is **profligate**.

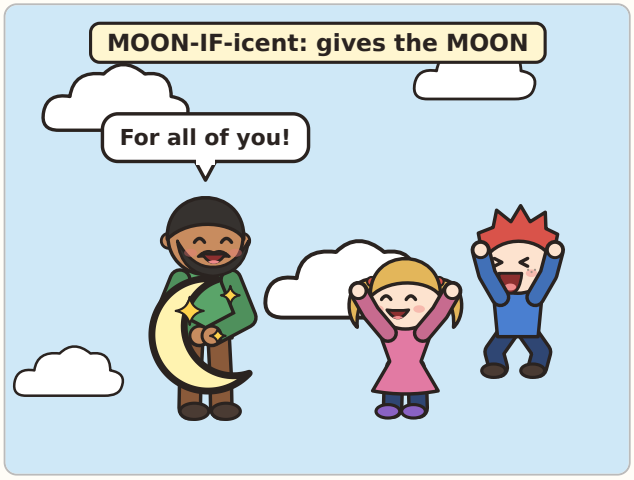
*The **profligate** prince spent the royal treasury on golden fountains while the town's roads crumbled.*

PARTS **pro-** forward, down + **flig** strike (as in conflict, inflict)

SIMILAR wasteful, lavish, spendthrift, reckless

OPPOSITE thrifty, frugal, prudent

munificent myoo-NIF-ih-sunt *adjective*



MEANING extremely generous in giving

MEMORY HOOK **MOON-IF-icent: he'd give you the MOON.** Uncle Omar would give you the moon if he could; he has already paid for the whole team's trip. He is **munificent**.

*Thanks to a **munificent** gift from a former student, the school built a new music hall.*

PARTS **mun** gift + **fic** do, make + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR generous, bountiful, openhanded, big-hearted

OPPOSITE stingy, parsimonious, miserly

largesse lar-ZHES *noun*



MEANING generous giving, or the gifts given

MEMORY HOOK **LARGE-ESS: LARGE gifts.** From the castle wall, the queen tosses down a large sack of bread and coins for the whole village; generous giving that large is **largesse**.

*Every December the baker's **largesse** filled the shelter's tables with bread and pies.*

SIMILAR generosity, bounty, gifts, charity

OPPOSITE stinginess, miserliness

avaricious av-uh-RISH-us *adjective*



MEANING greedy for money and possessions

MEMORY HOOK **HAVE-a-RICH-us: I must HAVE all the RICHES.** The dragon must have all the riches in the land and growls at anyone who comes near its pile; it is **avaricious**.

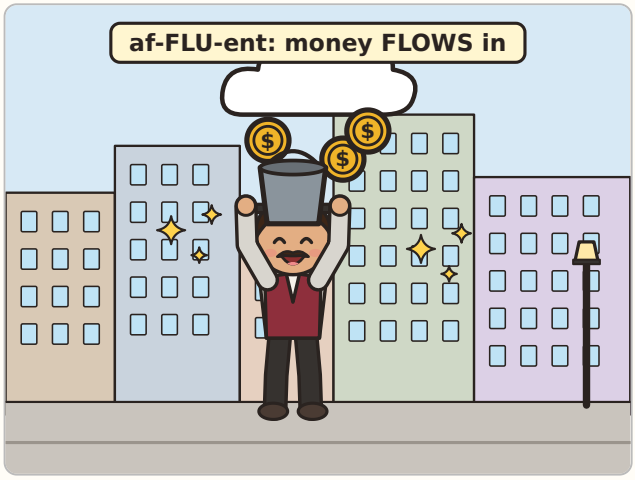
*The **avaricious** dragon slept on a mountain of gold and counted every coin each morning.*

PARTS **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR greedy, grasping, covetous, money-hungry

OPPOSITE generous, munificent, charitable

affluent **AF**-loo-unt *adjective*



MEANING having plenty of money; wealthy

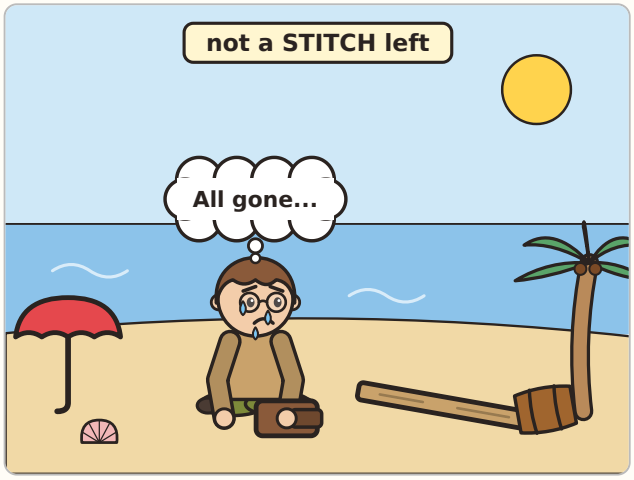
MEMORY HOOK **af-FLU-ent: money FLOWS in.** For the Hills family, money flows in like a river; they are **affluent**.

*The **affluent** family spent every summer at their lake house.*

PARTS **af- (ad-)** to, toward + **flu** flow + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR wealthy, rich, prosperous, well-off
OPPOSITE poor, destitute, needy, impoverished

destitute **DES**-tih-toot *adjective*



MEANING without money, a home or the basic things needed to live

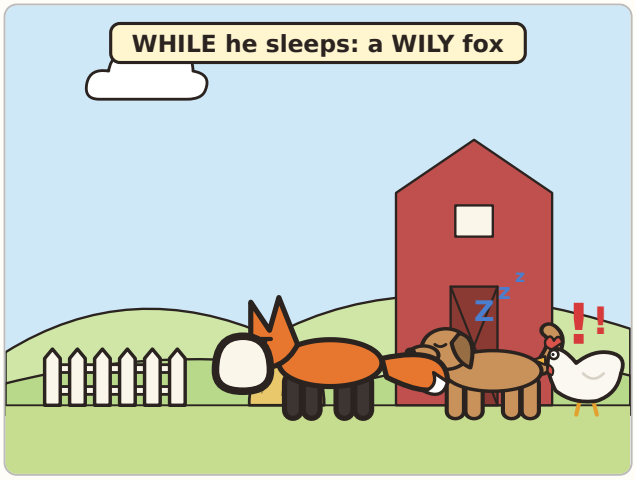
MEMORY HOOK **DE-STITCH-ute: not a STITCH left.** After the storm sank his ship, the merchant had not a stitch to his name but the shirt he wore; he was **destitute**.

*After the flood, many **destitute** families slept in the school gym until their homes could be rebuilt.*

PARTS **de-** away, from + **stit** set, place

SIMILAR penniless, impoverished, needy, poor
OPPOSITE affluent, wealthy, prosperous

wily **WYE**-lee *adjective*



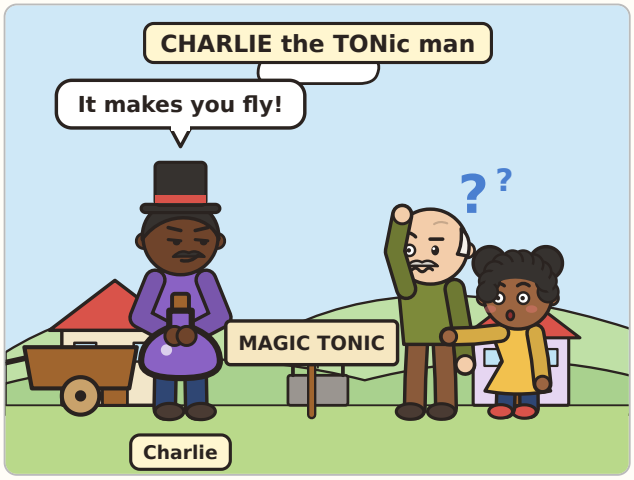
MEANING clever at tricking others; crafty

MEMORY HOOK **WHILE the dog sleeps....** While the guard dog snores, the fox tiptoes off with an egg; he plans his tricks for just that moment, because he is **wily**.

*The **wily** fox waited until the farmer fell asleep, then slipped under the fence.*

SIMILAR crafty, cunning, sly, shrewd
OPPOSITE naive, guileless, artless

charlatan **SHAR**-luh-tun *noun*



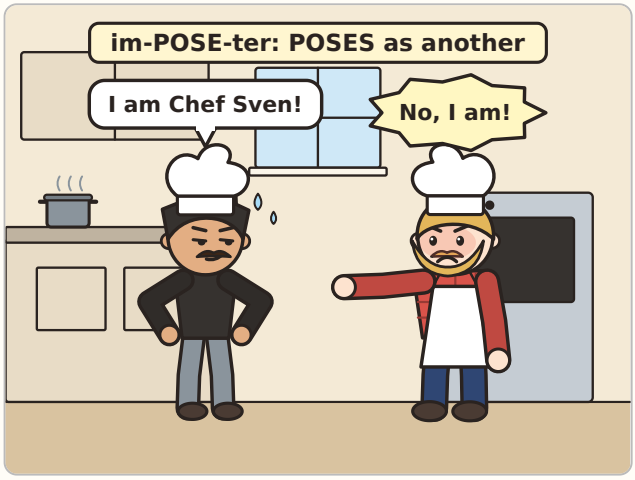
MEANING a fake who claims special knowledge or skill in order to fool people

MEMORY HOOK **CHARLIE the TONic man.** Charlie sells a "magic tonic" from his cart that he swears will make you fly; a man who claims a skill he does not have is a **charlatan**.

*The **charlatan** sold bottles of colored water as a cure for baldness.*

SIMILAR fraud, quack, fake, phony
OPPOSITE expert, authority, professional

impostor im-**POS**-ter *noun*



MEANING a person who pretends to be someone else to fool others

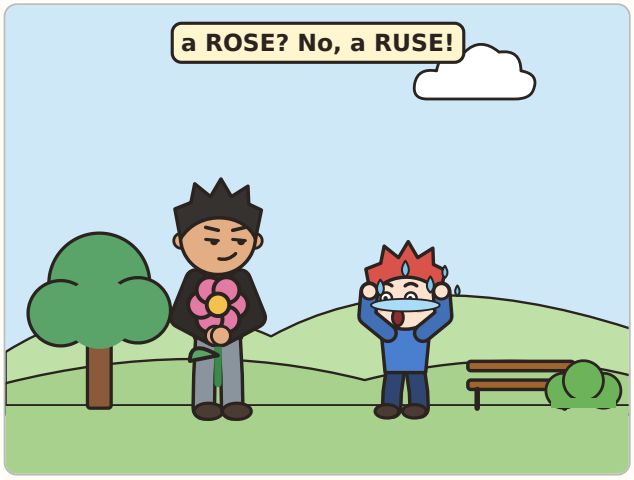
MEMORY HOOK **im-POSE-ter: he POSES as another.** Rex puts on a chef's hat and a fake mustache and poses as the famous Chef Sven, until the real Sven walks in; Rex is an **impostor**.

The man at the door claimed to be from the water company, but he was an **impostor** *with a fake badge.*

PARTS **im- (in-)** on, upon + **pos** put, place + **-or** one who

SIMILAR fraud, fake, phony, pretender

ruse **ROOZ** *noun*



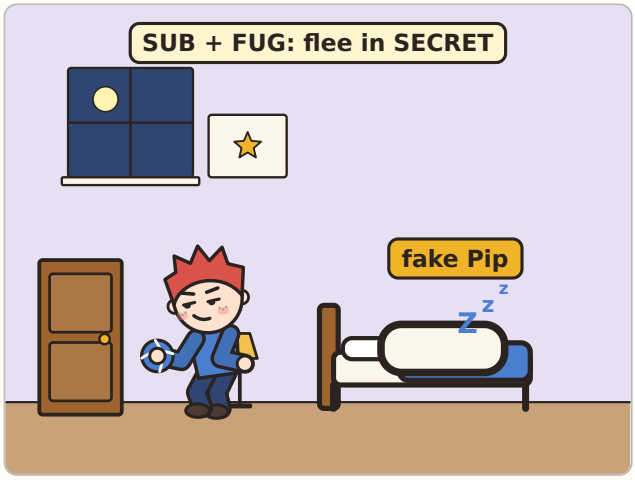
MEANING a trick meant to fool someone

MEMORY HOOK **a ROSE? No, a RUSE!.** Rex offers Pip a lovely rose, but it is a joke flower that squirts water in his face; the gift was a **ruse**.

The phone call about a free cruise was a **ruse** *to get our bank number.*

SIMILAR trick, ploy, deception, trickery

subterfuge **SUB**-ter-fyooj *noun*



MEANING a sly trick used to hide something or to get out of something

MEMORY HOOK **SUB (under) + FUG (flee): sneak away.** Pip tucks a pillow under his blanket so it looks like he is asleep, then sneaks off to play; the pillow is his **subterfuge**.

Pretending to be asleep was the twins' favorite **subterfuge** *for skipping chores.*

PARTS **subter- (sub-)** beneath, secretly + **fug** flee

SIMILAR trickery, deception, trick, ploy

OPPOSITE openness, candor, honesty

chicanery shih-**KAY**-nuh-ree *noun*



MEANING clever, dishonest trickery, especially in business or law

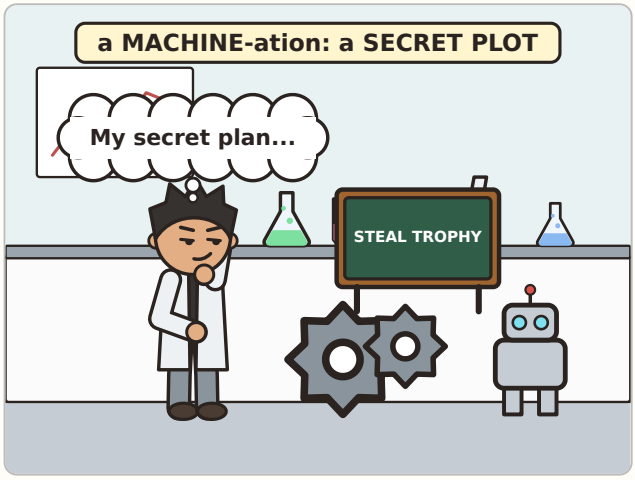
MEMORY HOOK **CHICK-ANE-ery: a painted chicken.** Sly Victor paints a plain hen gold and swears she lays golden eggs; that kind of dishonest selling is **chicanery**.

The card game was pure **chicanery**; *the dealer had marked every ace.*

SIMILAR trickery, deception, trick, double-dealing

OPPOSITE honesty, fairness, integrity

machination mak-uh-**NAY**-shun *noun*



MEANING a secret, crafty plot, usually meant to do harm

MEMORY HOOK **a MACHINE for plotting.** In his secret lab, Rex builds a giant machine with gears and levers, all to steal the town's pie-contest trophy; his crafty plot is a **machination**.

Despite all her rival's **machinations**, *Lila won the spelling bee fair and square.*

PARTS **machin** machine, device + **-tion** the act or result of

SIMILAR plot, scheme, intrigue, conspiracy

collusion kuh-**LOO**-zhun *noun*



MEANING secret teamwork for a dishonest purpose

MEMORY HOOK **COL + LUD: PLAYING TOGETHER in secret.** Two players on rival teams secretly agree who will win and split the prize; their dishonest teamwork is **collusion**.

The two bakeries were caught in **collusion**, *secretly agreeing to raise their prices on the same day.*

PARTS **col- (con-)** with, together + **lus (lud)** play + **-ion (-tion)** the act or result of

SIMILAR connivance, complicity, conspiracy, secret cooperation

complicit kum-**PLIS**-it *adjective*



MEANING taking part with others in doing something wrong

MEMORY HOOK **an acCOMPLICE is COMPLICIT.** Kai does not take the cookies himself, but he holds the ladder while Pip climbs to the jar; as Pip's accomplice, Kai is **complicit**.

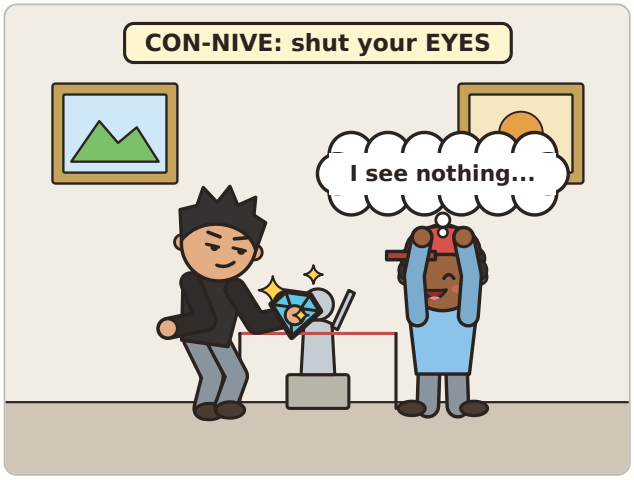
By hiding his friend's copy of the stolen answers, Jonah became **complicit** *in the cheating.*

PARTS **com- (con-)** with, together + **plic** fold

SIMILAR involved, implicated, in league, guilty

OPPOSITE innocent, blameless, uninvolved

connive kuh-**NIVE** *verb*



MEANING to plot secretly, or to let a wrong happen by looking away

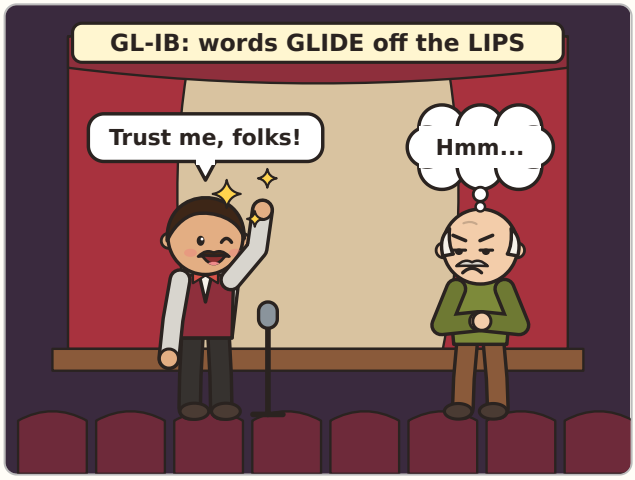
MEMORY HOOK **CON + NIVE: shut your eyes to a CON.** The museum guard covers his eyes while Rex tiptoes past with the jewel; by pretending not to see, the guard **connives** at the theft.

The two brothers **connived** *to sneak the stray puppy into the house without their parents noticing.*

PARTS **con-** together, thoroughly + **niv** shut the eyes, wink

SIMILAR plot, scheme, conspire, collude

glib GLIB *adjective*



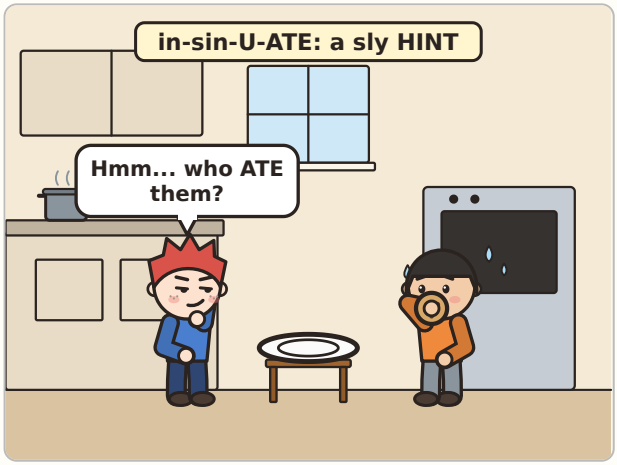
MEANING smooth and quick with words but shallow or insincere

MEMORY HOOK **words GLIDE off his LIPS.** Victor's words glide off his lips like skates on ice: fast, smooth and with nothing underneath. His talk is **glib**.

The salesman had a **glib** *answer for every question but never once looked us in the eye.*

SIMILAR slick, smooth-talking, facile, superficial
OPPOSITE sincere, thoughtful, earnest

insinuate in-**SIN**-yoo-ayt *verb*



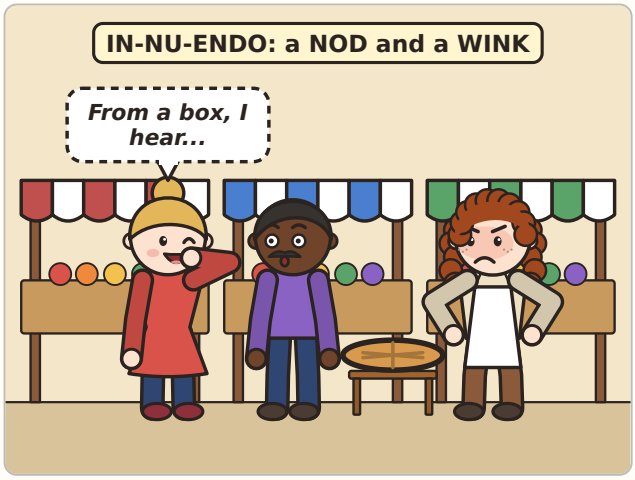
MEANING to hint at something unpleasant without saying it outright

MEMORY HOOK **in-sin-U-ATE: "so... YOU ATE them?".** Pip looks at the empty cookie jar, then slowly at Kai, and says, "Hmm, someone ate them..." He does not accuse Kai directly; he **insinuates** it.

Are you trying to **insinuate** *that I ate the last cookie?*

PARTS **in-** in, into + **sinu** curve, bend + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)
SIMILAR imply, hint, suggest, intimate
OPPOSITE declare, state plainly

innuendo in-yoo-**EN**-doh *noun*



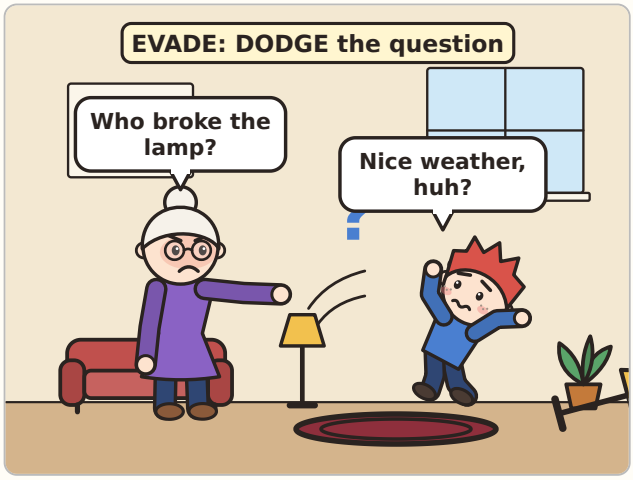
MEANING a sly, indirect hint, usually an unkind one about someone

MEMORY HOOK **a NOD and a WINK, not a word.** At the bake sale, Greta winks and murmurs, "Some people's homemade pies come from a box, I hear..." That sly, unkind hint is **innuendo**.

The gossip column was full of **innuendo** *but had not a single fact.*

PARTS **in-** toward, at + **nu** nod
SIMILAR insinuation, hint, implication, suggestion

evasive ih-**VAY**-siv *adjective*



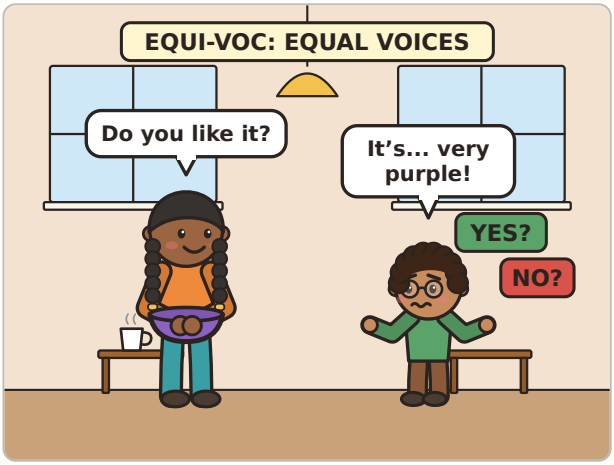
MEANING avoiding a direct answer or a clear statement

MEMORY HOOK **EVADE the question like a dodgeball.** Granny Mae asks who broke the lamp, and Pip ducks the question like a dodgeball: "Nice weather, huh?" His answer is **evasive**.

When asked where the cake had gone, the twins gave **evasive** *answers about the weather.*

PARTS **e- (ex-)** out + **vas (vad)** go + **-ive** tending to, doing
SIMILAR vague, indirect, elusive, cagey
OPPOSITE direct, frank, candid, forthright

equivocate ih-**KWIV**-uh-kayt *verb*



MEANING to use vague or double-meaning words to avoid taking a clear position

MEMORY HOOK **EQUAL VOICES: yes AND no at once.** Asked if he likes Aunt Tia's purple soup, Sami says, "Well, it's... very purple!" His answer could mean yes or no; he **equivocates**.

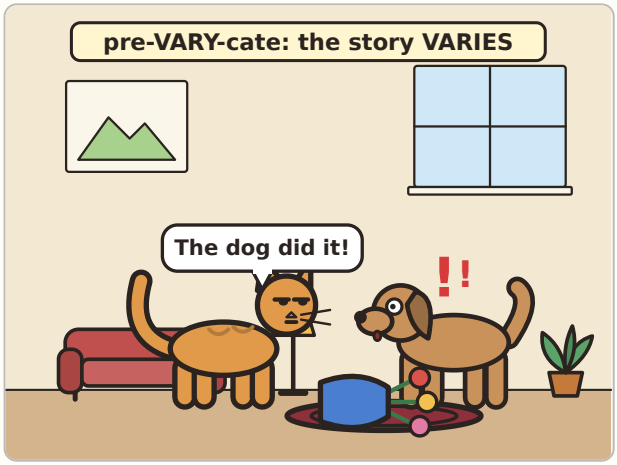
Asked if he liked the new haircut, Dad **equivocated***: "Well, it's certainly... different."*

PARTS **equi** equal + **voc** call, voice + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR hedge, waffle, dodge, be vague

OPPOSITE commit, state plainly

prevaricate prih-**VAIR**-ih-kayt *verb*



MEANING to dodge the truth, often by speaking in a misleading way

MEMORY HOOK **the CAT VARIES the story.** Caught beside the broken vase, the cat varies its story every minute: first the wind did it, then the dog. That cat loves to **prevaricate**.

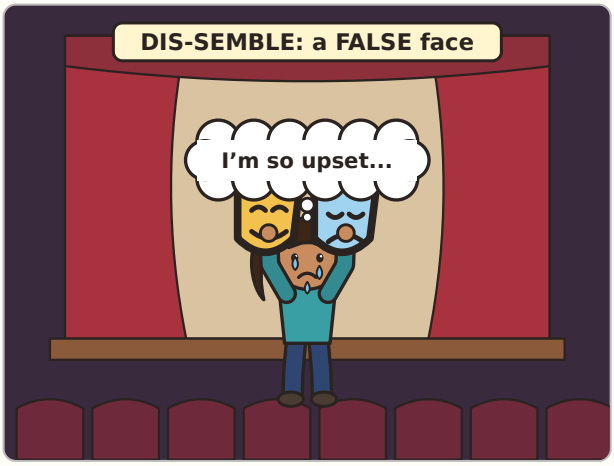
When the teacher asked about the missing homework, Jonah began to **prevaricate***, spinning a long tale about a windstorm.*

PARTS **pre- (prae-)** before, in front + **varic** straddle, walk crookedly

SIMILAR dodge, hedge, waffle, lie

OPPOSITE level with, come clean

dissemble dih-**SEM**-bul *verb*



MEANING to hide one's true feelings or aims behind a false show

MEMORY HOOK **a mask that does NOT RESEMBLE you.** Maya is sad inside, but she holds up a smiling mask that does not resemble her real face at all; to hide your feelings that way is to **dissemble**.

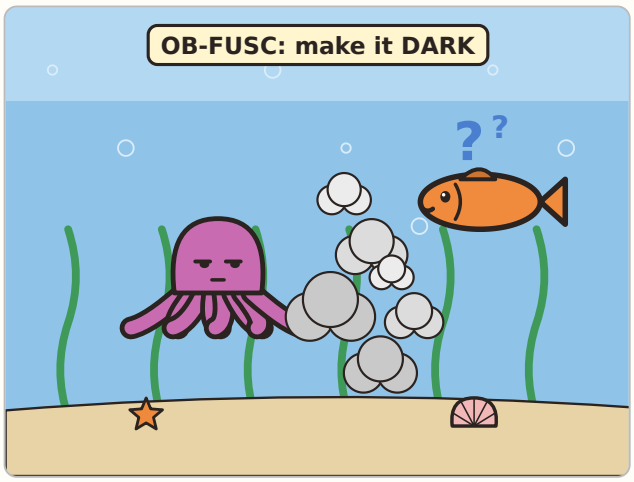
Though she was crushed by the news, Maya **dissembled** *and smiled through the whole party.*

PARTS **dis-** not + **sembl (simul)** like, seeming (as in resemble)

SIMILAR pretend, feign, disguise, mask

OPPOSITE reveal, disclose

obfuscate **OB**-fuh-skayt *verb*



MEANING to make something confusing or unclear on purpose

MEMORY HOOK **OB-FUSC: make it DARK and murky.** To slip away, the octopus squirts a cloud of dark ink until no one can see a thing; making things murky on purpose is to **obfuscate**.

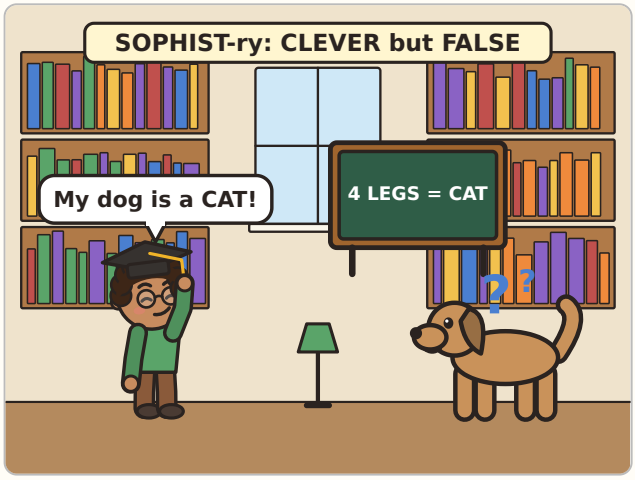
The instructions were so full of jargon that they seemed meant to **obfuscate** *rather than explain.*

PARTS **ob-** over, against + **fusc** dark + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR obscure, confuse, cloud, muddy

OPPOSITE clarify, explain, elucidate

sophistry SOF-ih-stree *noun*



MEANING clever-sounding reasoning that is false or misleading

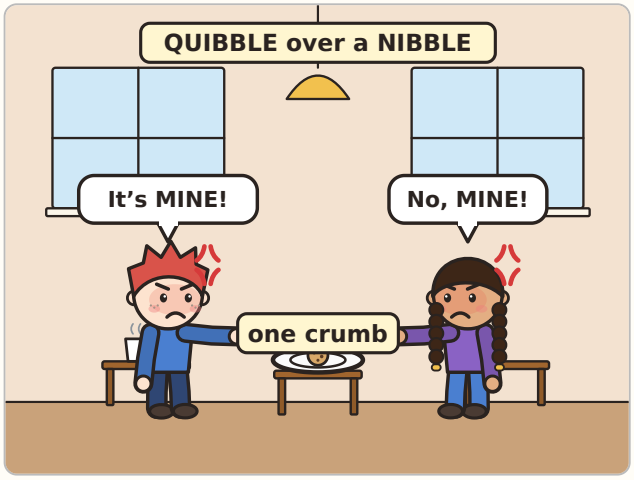
MEMORY HOOK **SOPHISTicated-sounding, but FALSE.** Sami proves at the board that cats have four legs, his dog has four legs, so his dog must be a cat; it sounds clever, but it is **sophistry**.

His argument that homework is bad because it wastes pencils was pure **sophistry**.

PARTS **soph** wise

SIMILAR false reasoning, casuistry, specious argument
OPPOSITE sound reasoning, logic

quibble KWIB-ul *verb*



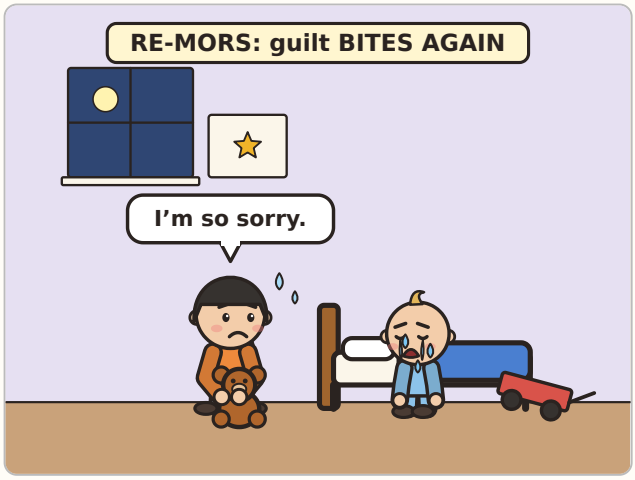
MEANING to argue or complain about small, unimportant points

MEMORY HOOK **QUIBBLE over a NIBBLE.** Pip and Lila argue for an hour over who gets the last tiny nibble of cookie; to argue over something that small is to **quibble**.

Let's not **quibble** *over a nickel; just split the bill.*

SIMILAR nitpick, bicker, split hairs, cavil
OPPOSITE agree, let it go

remorse rih-MORS *noun*



MEANING deep, painful regret for having done wrong

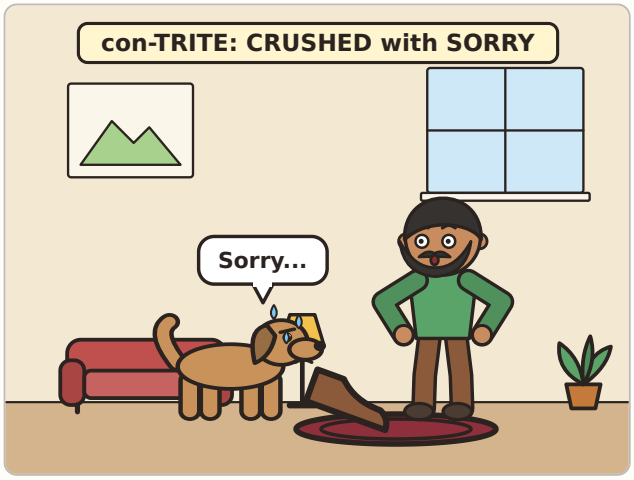
MEMORY HOOK **RE-MORS: guilt that BITES AGAIN.** Kai broke his brother's toy truck, and the guilt keeps biting at him all evening until he hands over his own teddy bear; that biting regret is **remorse**.

Filled with **remorse**, *Kai gave back the toy he had taken and apologized to his little brother.*

PARTS **re-** back, again + **mors** bite

SIMILAR regret, guilt, contrition, repentance
OPPOSITE shamelessness, indifference

contrite kun-TRITE *adjective*



MEANING truly sorry for having done wrong

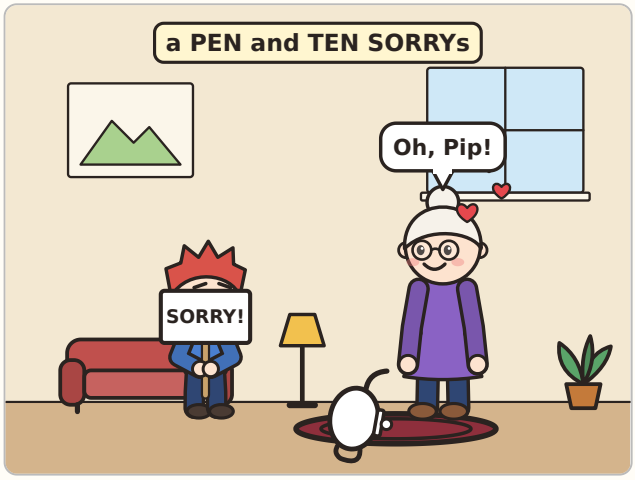
MEMORY HOOK **con-TRITE: CRUSHED with sorry.** After chewing Dad's slipper to bits, Rufus creeps over with his ears down and lays it at Dad's feet; the crushed, sorry pup is **contrite**.

The **contrite** *puppy crept out from under the table after chewing Dad's slipper.*

PARTS **con-** thoroughly + **trit** crushed, rubbed

SIMILAR sorry, remorseful, repentant, regretful
OPPOSITE unrepentant, defiant, shameless

penitent PEN-ih-tunt *adjective*



MEANING sorry for doing wrong and wanting to make up for it

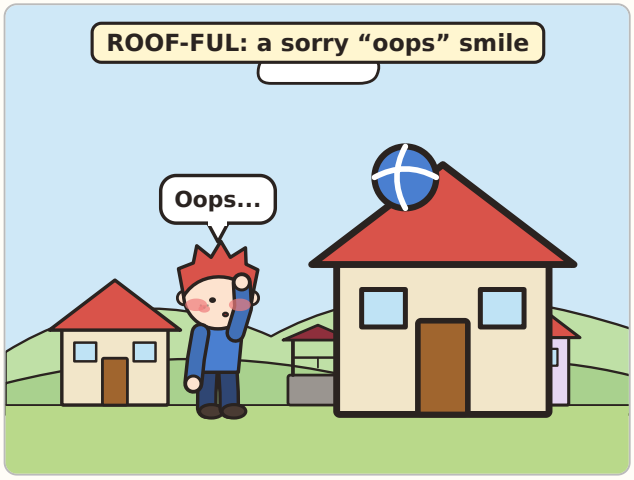
MEMORY HOOK **a PEN and TEN sorrys.** After breaking Granny's teapot, Pip takes a pen and writes "Sorry!" ten times on a big card, then offers to wash her dishes all week; he is **penitent**.

The **penitent** *boy swept up every bit of the vase he had knocked over.*

PARTS **pen (paen)** regret + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR repentant, remorseful, sorry, regretful
OPPOSITE unrepentant, impenitent, defiant

rueful ROO-ful *adjective*



MEANING showing regret, often with a sad or wry smile

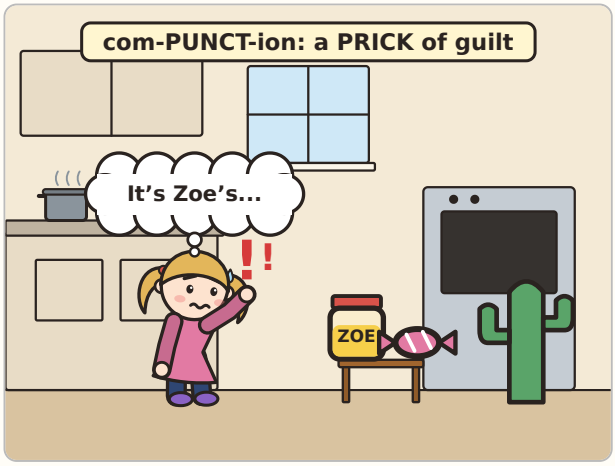
MEMORY HOOK **a ROOF-FUL of regret.** Pip kicks his new ball right onto the roof, then looks up with a sorry little half smile: "Oops." That regretful look is **rueful**.

With a **rueful** *grin, Grandpa admitted he had locked the keys in the car again.*

PARTS **rue** sorrow, regret + **-ful** full of

SIMILAR regretful, sorrowful, wry, apologetic
OPPOSITE unrepentant, carefree

compunction kum-**PUNGK**-shun *noun*



MEANING a twinge of guilt or doubt that stops or follows a wrong act

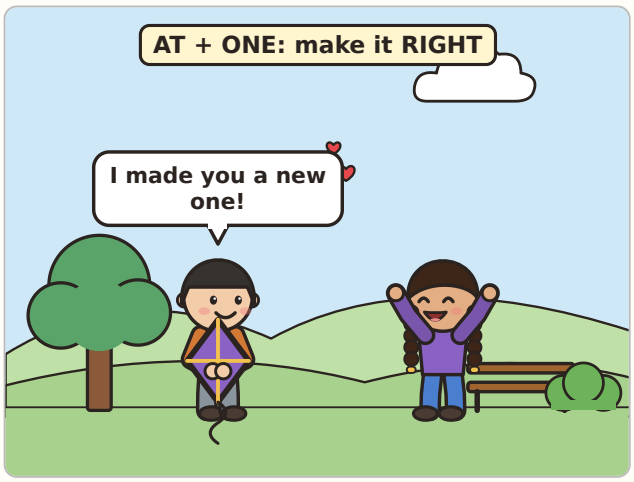
MEMORY HOOK **com-PUNCT-ion: a PRICK of guilt.** Reaching for her sister's candy, Ivy feels a little prick of guilt, sharp as a cactus needle, and pulls her hand back; that twinge is **compunction**.

The raccoon ate the whole pie without the slightest **compunction**.

PARTS **com- (con-)** thoroughly + **punct** prick, point (as in puncture) + **-ion (-tion)** the act or result of

SIMILAR scruple, qualm, misgiving, guilt
OPPOSITE shamelessness, indifference

atone uh-**TONE** *verb*



MEANING to make up for a wrong one has done

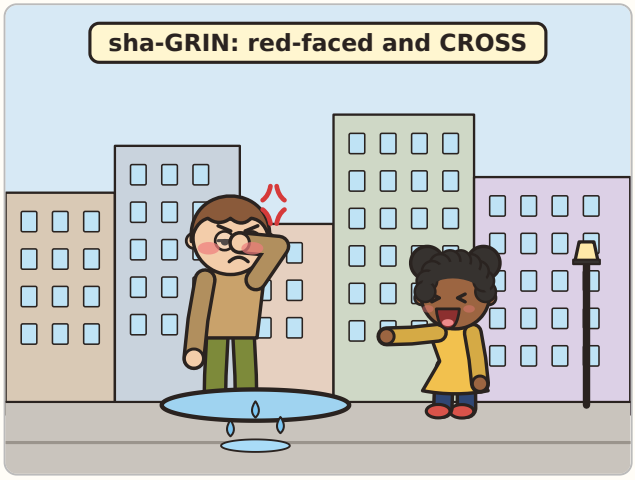
MEMORY HOOK **AT ONE again: make it up.** Kai broke Lila's kite, so he spends his whole Saturday building her a new one; he wants to **atone** for the wrong and be at one with her again.

To **atone** *for forgetting her birthday, Sami baked his sister a three-layer cake.*

PARTS **at + one** in harmony, together again

SIMILAR make amends, make up for, compensate, redeem oneself

chagrin shuh-**GRIN** *noun*



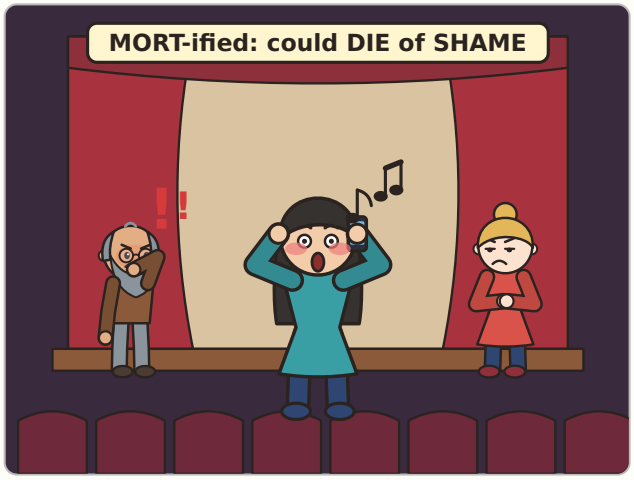
MEANING annoyance mixed with embarrassment, often after a failure

MEMORY HOOK **a SHAKY GRIN: sha-GRIN.** Felix slips in a puddle right in front of the whole bus stop, gets up red-faced and cross, and forces a shaky grin; that sour, embarrassed feeling is **chagrin**.

To his **chagrin**, *Felix discovered he had worn mismatched shoes to the job interview.*

SIMILAR embarrassment, vexation, annoyance, mortification
OPPOSITE delight, pride

mortified **MOR**-tih-fyed *adjective*



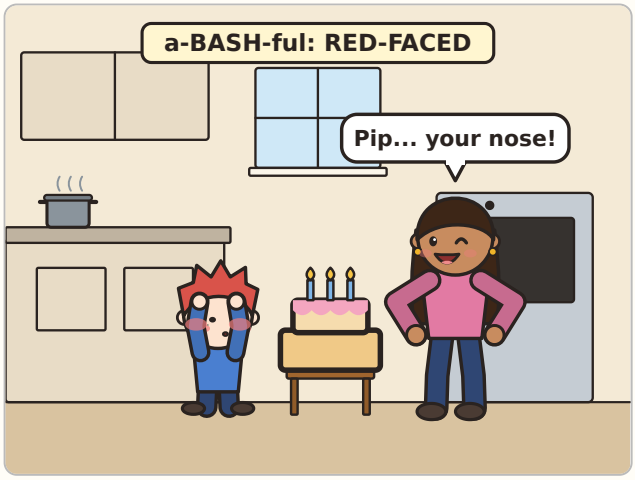
MEANING deeply embarrassed or ashamed

MEMORY HOOK **MORT = death: could DIE of shame.** When Lin's phone blares a quacking ringtone in the silent theater, she wishes the floor would swallow her; she is **mortified**.

Lin was **mortified** *when her phone rang loudly in the middle of the school play.*

PARTS **mort** death + **-ify (-fied)** to make
SIMILAR humiliated, embarrassed, red-faced, shamefaced
OPPOSITE proud, unembarrassed

abashed uh-**BASHT** *adjective*



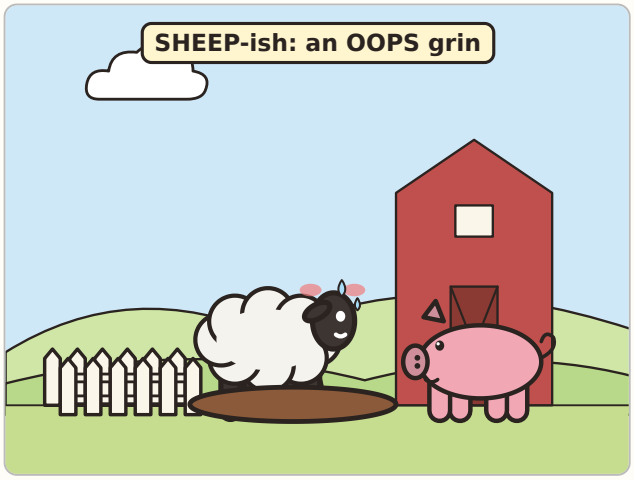
MEANING embarrassed and a little ashamed

MEMORY HOOK **a-BASH-ful: red-faced and shy.** Caught with frosting on his nose after sneaking a taste of the birthday cake, Pip turns red and stares at his shoes, as bashful as can be; he is **abashed**.

Caught singing at the top of his lungs in the shower, Dev came out looking **abashed**.

SIMILAR embarrassed, sheepish, shamefaced, red-faced
OPPOSITE bold, unashamed, brazen

sheepish **SHEEP**-ish *adjective*



MEANING embarrassed from knowing one has done something silly

MEMORY HOOK **a SHEEP with an "oops" grin.** The sheep tries to jump the fence, lands in the pigs' mud instead, and looks up with an embarrassed little grin; it looks **sheepish**.

Grandpa gave a **sheepish** *smile when he found his glasses on top of his head.*

PARTS **-ish** like
SIMILAR embarrassed, shamefaced, red-faced, abashed
OPPOSITE unabashed, brazen, confident

manifest MAN-uh-fest *adjective*



MEANING clear and plain to see or understand

MEMORY HOOK **caught BLUE-HANDED: plain to see.** Pip swears he never touched the paint, but his hands and nose are bright blue; his guilt is **manifest**.

Her joy was **manifest** *in the way she skipped all the way home.*

SIMILAR obvious, evident, plain, clear
OPPOSITE hidden, obscure, unclear

palpable PAL-puh-bul *adjective*



MEANING so strong or clear that it can almost be touched

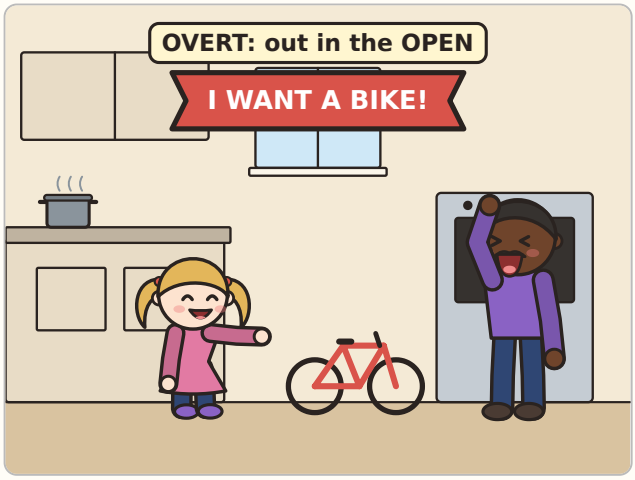
MEMORY HOOK **PALP-ABLE: you could almost PAT it.** As the spelling bee reaches its last word, the nerves in the room are so thick that you could almost reach out and pat them; the tension is **palpable**.

The tension in the room was **palpable** *as the judges opened the envelope.*

PARTS **palp** touch, stroke + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR tangible, obvious, noticeable, perceptible
OPPOSITE imperceptible, intangible, subtle

overt oh-VURT *adjective*



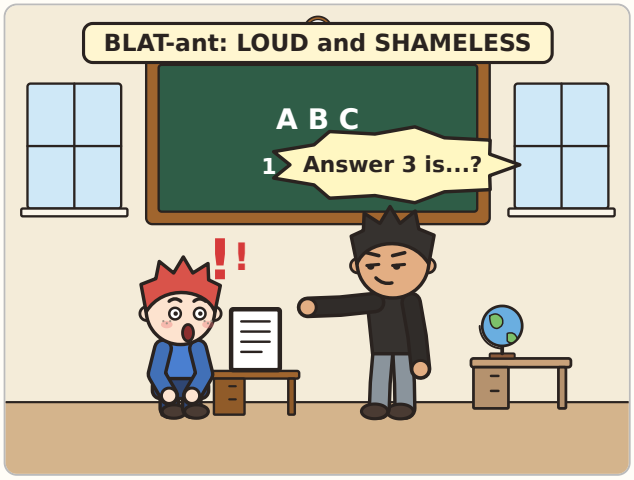
MEANING done or shown openly, not hidden

MEMORY HOOK **OVER-T: right out in the OPEN.** Ivy does not drop hints; she hangs a giant sign over the fridge that says "I WANT A BIKE!" Her wish is **overt**.

Lila's **overt** *yawning during the long speech made the speaker frown.*

SIMILAR open, unconcealed, public, plain
OPPOSITE covert, secret, hidden, concealed

blatant BLAY-tunt *adjective*



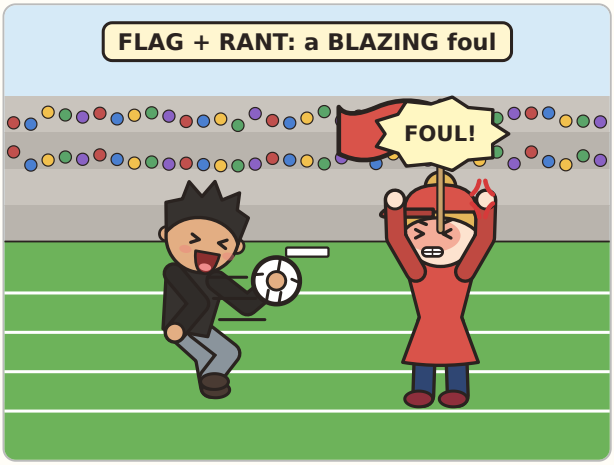
MEANING completely obvious and done without shame

MEMORY HOOK **BLAT-ant: as loud as a BLARING horn.** Rex copies Pip's test while reading the answers out loud, as loud as a blaring horn; cheating that shameless and obvious is **blatant**.

Copying your neighbor's answers word for word is **blatant** *cheating.*

SIMILAR obvious, flagrant, glaring, brazen
OPPOSITE subtle, hidden, inconspicuous

flagrant FLAY-grunt *adjective*



MEANING shockingly obvious and wrong

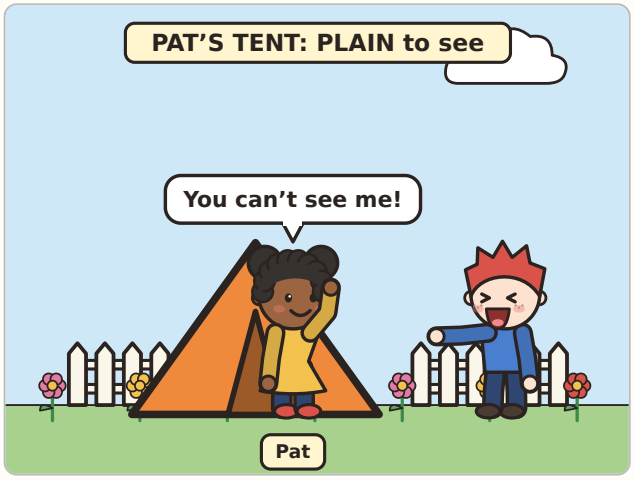
MEMORY HOOK **FLAG + RANT: a wrong that BLAZES.** Rex picks up the soccer ball and carries it into the goal; the referee waves her red flag and rants. A foul that glaringly wrong is **flagrant**.

Picking up the soccer ball and running it into the goal was a **flagrant** *break of the rules.*

PARTS **flagr** burn, blaze + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR glaring, blatant, outrageous, obvious
OPPOSITE minor, slight

patent PAT-unt *adjective*



MEANING plain and obvious

MEMORY HOOK **PAT'S TENT: as plain as can be.** Pat pitches a bright orange tent in the middle of the lawn and calls it her secret hideout; that hiding place is **patent** to everyone.

His story about a dog eating his homework was a **patent** *fib; he doesn't even have a dog.*

PARTS **pat** lie open + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR obvious, evident, plain, clear
OPPOSITE hidden, unclear, doubtful

ostensible os-TEN-suh-bul *adjective*



MEANING stated or seeming to be true, but perhaps not the real thing

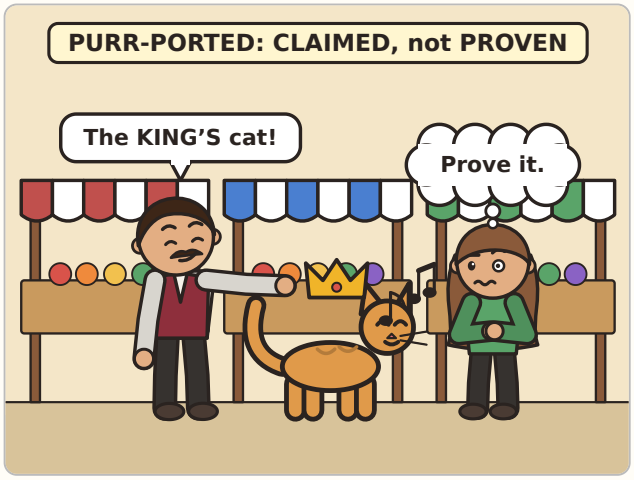
MEMORY HOOK **it SOUNDS SENSIBLE: o-STEN-SIBLE.** Dev says he is visiting Nana Lou to fix her clock, which sounds sensible, but his eyes are on her cookies; fixing the clock is his **ostensible** reason.

The **ostensible** *reason for his visit was to return a book, but he stayed for three helpings of pie.*

PARTS **os- (ob-)** before, in front of + **tens** stretch, hold out + **-ible** able to be

SIMILAR apparent, seeming, supposed, professed
OPPOSITE real, actual, genuine

purported per-POR-tid *adjective*



MEANING claimed or said to be, but not proven

MEMORY HOOK **PURR-PORTED: the "royal" cat.** The seller swears his purring cat once belonged to a king, but he has no proof at all; it is only the **purported** royal cat.

The museum showed a **purported** *dinosaur egg that turned out to be a smooth river stone.*

PARTS **pur- (pro-)** forth + **port** carry

SIMILAR supposed, alleged, reputed, professed
OPPOSITE proven, confirmed, verified

tacit TAS-it *adjective*



MEANING understood without being said out loud

MEMORY HOOK **TAC = SILENT: a deal with no words.** Across the dinner table, Zoe winks and Kai nods; without a word, they agree to swap peas for carrots. Their deal is **tacit**.

With a **tacit** *nod, the twins agreed to keep the surprise party a secret.*

PARTS **tac** be silent

SIMILAR unspoken, implied, understood, silent
OPPOSITE explicit, stated, spoken

unmistakable un-mih-**STAY**-kuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING impossible to mistake for anything else; very clear

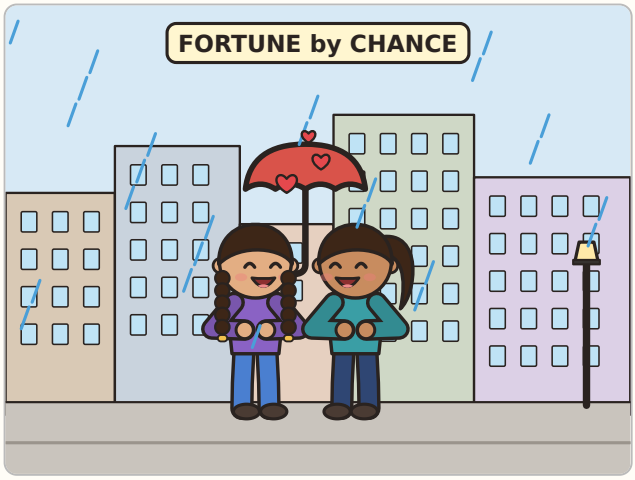
MEMORY HOOK **UN-MISTAKE-ABLE: a giraffe in a crowd.** Grandpa brings his pet giraffe to the busy station; in a crowd of a hundred people, no one could mistake where he is. The giraffe is **unmistakable**.

The **unmistakable** *smell of fresh bread drifted down the street from the bakery.*

PARTS **un-** not + **mis-** wrongly + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR obvious, evident, plain, clear
OPPOSITE unclear, ambiguous, doubtful

fortuitous for-**TOO**-ih-tus *adjective*



MEANING happening by chance, often by lucky chance

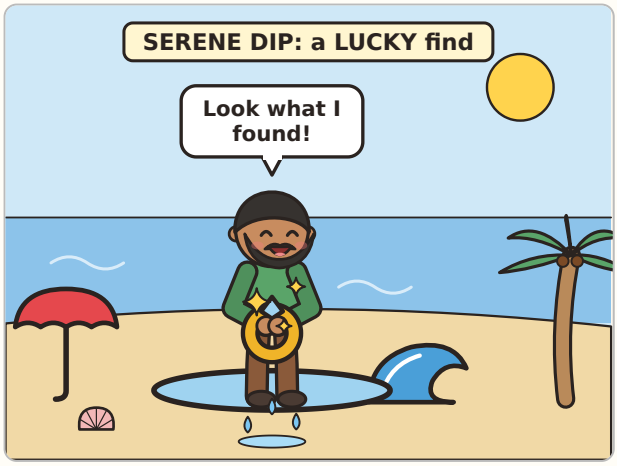
MEMORY HOOK **FORTUNE by CHANCE.** Caught in the rain, Lila ducks under a shop awning and finds her old best friend sheltering there too; the meeting, pure chance and good fortune, is **fortuitous**.

Our meeting at the airport was **fortuitous***: neither of us knew the other was flying that day.*

PARTS **fort** chance, luck + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR chance, accidental, unplanned, lucky
OPPOSITE planned, intended, deliberate

serendipity ser-un-**DIP**-ih-tee *noun*



MEANING the luck of finding good things without looking for them

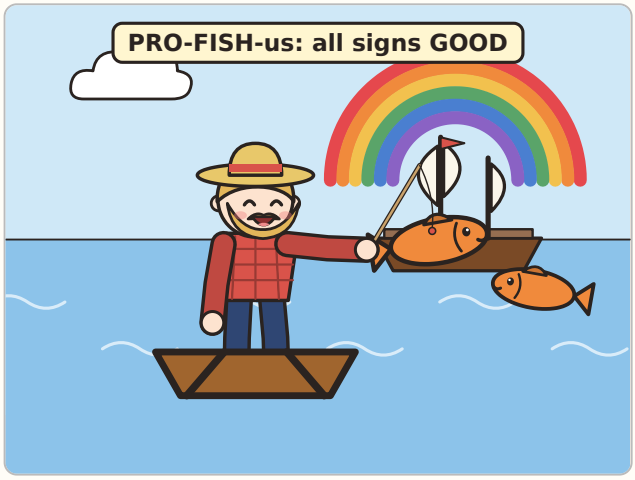
MEMORY HOOK **a SERENE DIP finds a treasure.** Taking a serene dip in the lake, Omar feels something under his toes: a lost gold ring. Finding something wonderful without looking for it is **serendipity**.

By pure **serendipity***, Sami found his favorite book at a yard sale for a dime.*

PARTS **-ity** the state or quality of being

SIMILAR luck, happy accident, good fortune, lucky find
OPPOSITE misfortune, bad luck

propitious pruh-**PISH**-us *adjective*



MEANING favorable; likely to lead to success

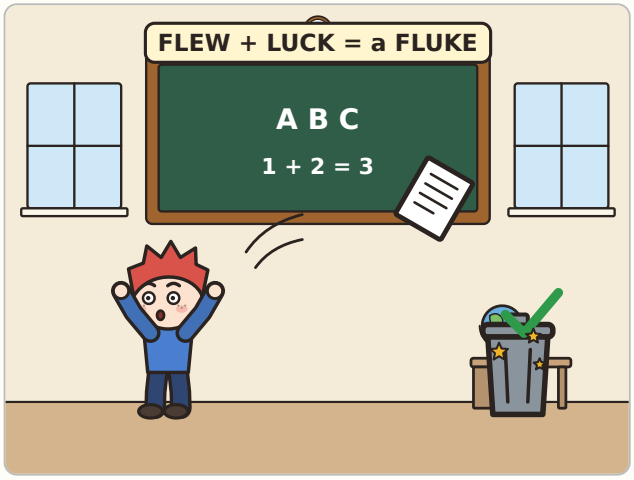
MEMORY HOOK **a PRO-FISH day: every sign says GO.** The old fisherman sees calm water, a rainbow and fish leaping all around his boat; every sign is good, so it is a **propitious** day to fish.

Clear skies and a steady breeze made it a **propitious** *day for the kite festival.*

PARTS **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR favorable, promising, auspicious, advantageous
OPPOSITE unfavorable, inauspicious, ominous

fluke **FLOOK** *noun*



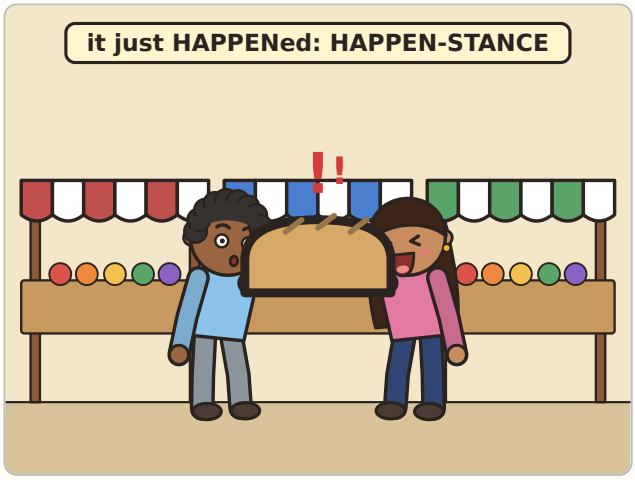
MEANING a lucky or unlikely chance happening

MEMORY HOOK **it FLEW in by LUCK.** Pip tosses a paper ball over his shoulder without even looking, and it flies straight into the trash can across the room; a lucky shot like that is a **fluke**.

Her first basket from half court was a **fluke**; *she missed the next twenty.*

SIMILAR luck, happy accident, stroke of luck, lucky break
OPPOSITE sure thing, certainty

happenstance **HAP**-un-stans *noun*



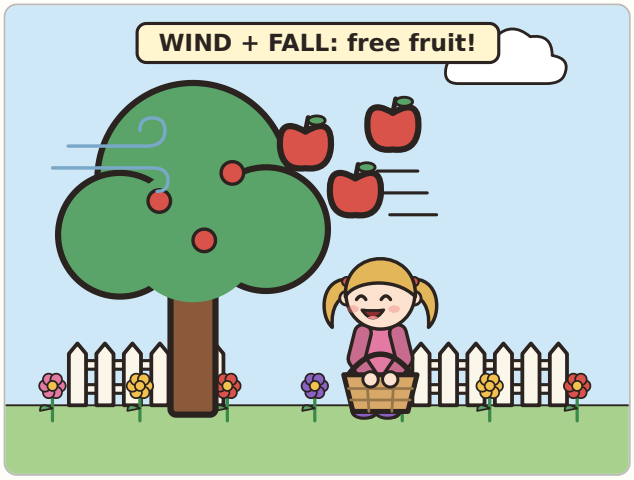
MEANING a chance happening; a coincidence

MEMORY HOOK **HAPPEN + circumSTANCE.** Two strangers reach for the very last loaf of bread at the same moment and end up sharing a picnic; their meeting just happened, by **happenstance**.

By **happenstance**, *the two cousins ended up in the same college dorm.*

SIMILAR chance, coincidence, accident, fluke
OPPOSITE plan, design, intention

windfall **WIND**-fawl *noun*



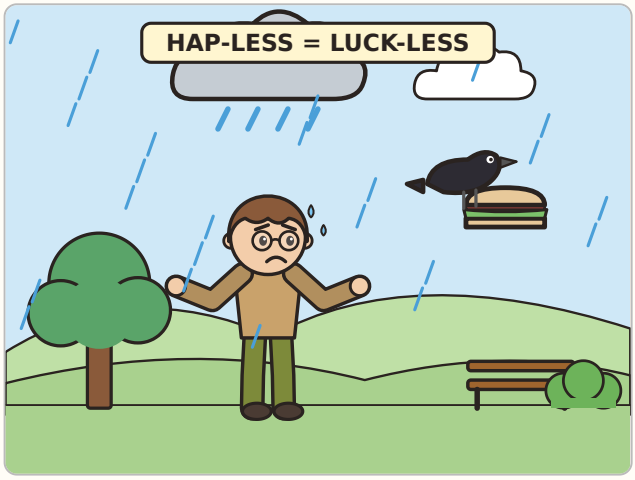
MEANING an unexpected gain, such as money one did not work for

MEMORY HOOK **the WIND makes the fruit FALL.** A gust of wind shakes the old tree, and a dozen ripe pieces of fruit tumble right into Ivy's basket; a gift you did not work for is a **windfall**.

A **windfall** *from a forgotten savings account paid for the family's trip to the coast.*

SIMILAR bonanza, godsend, jackpot, stroke of luck
OPPOSITE loss, setback

hapless HAP-lis *adjective*



MEANING unlucky; having one bad break after another

MEMORY HOOK **HAP-LESS = LUCK-LESS.** Poor Felix: a crow steals his sandwich, a rain cloud follows only him, and his umbrella turns inside out. With no luck at all, he is **hapless**.

*The **hapless** hiker lost his map, then his hat, then his left boot.*

PARTS **hap** luck, chance + **-less** without

SIMILAR unlucky, unfortunate, luckless, ill-fated
OPPOSITE lucky, fortunate

calamity kuh-LAM-ih-tee *noun*



MEANING a disaster that causes great loss or suffering

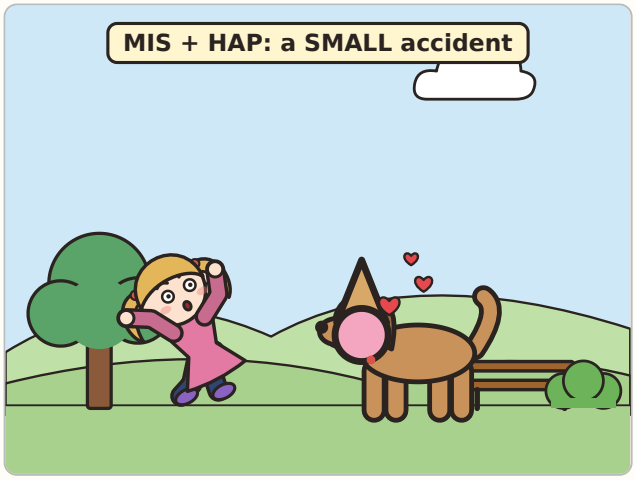
MEMORY HOOK **no CALM at all: a disaster.** A giant wave sweeps away the whole sandcastle city the children spent all day building; to them, it is a **calamity**.

*The flood was the worst **calamity** the valley had seen in a hundred years.*

PARTS **-ity** the state or quality of being

SIMILAR disaster, catastrophe, tragedy, cataclysm
OPPOSITE blessing, godsend

mishap MIS-hap *noun*



MEANING a small accident or bit of bad luck

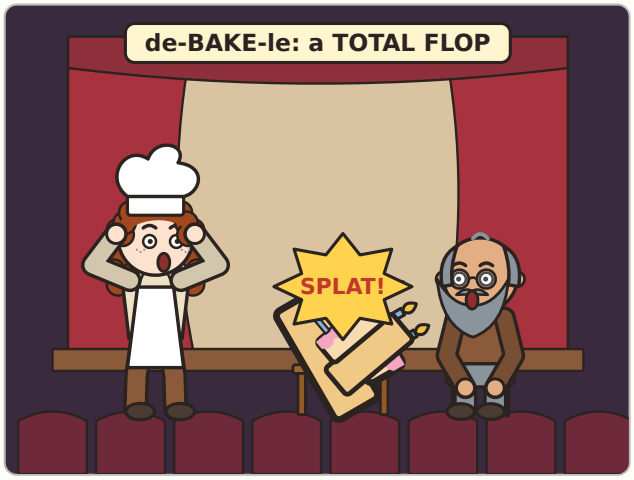
MEMORY HOOK **MIS + HAP: a little BAD LUCK.** Ivy trips, and her ice cream cone lands upside down on the dog's head; it is only a small **mishap**, and the dog does not mind one bit.

*Apart from one **mishap** with a spilled paint can, the mural went up without trouble.*

PARTS **mis-** wrongly, badly + **hap** luck, chance

SIMILAR accident, misadventure, slip, mischance

debacle dih-BOK-ul *noun*



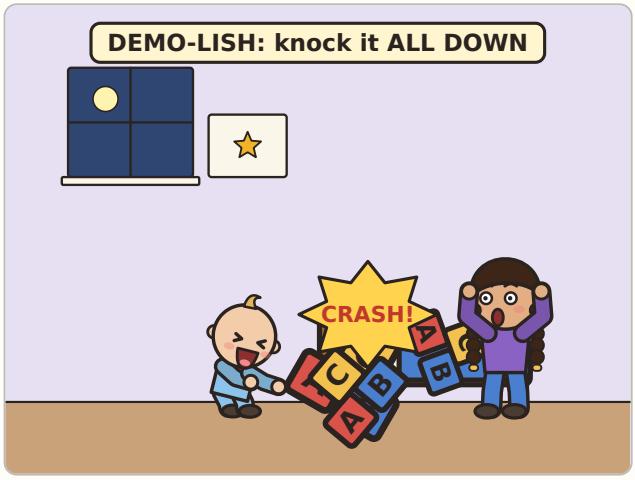
MEANING a sudden and complete failure

MEMORY HOOK **de-BAKE-le: the bake-off that fell apart.** At the big bake-off, Nell's tower cake wobbles, tilts and crashes onto the judges' table; the whole entry is a **debacle**.

*The school play was a **debacle**: the curtain fell, the lights went out and the lead forgot every line.*

SIMILAR fiasco, disaster, failure, flop
OPPOSITE success, triumph

demolish dih-**MOL**-ish *verb*



MEANING to knock down or destroy completely

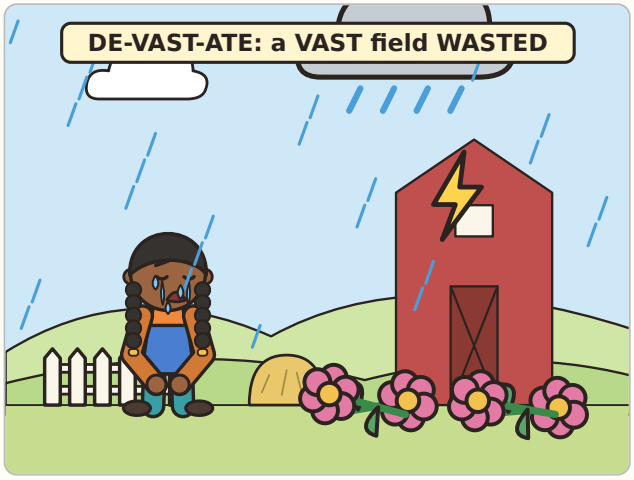
MEMORY HOOK **DEMO-LISH: the tower comes DOWN.** Theo spends one second looking at his sister's tall block tower, then knocks the whole thing flat; he can **demolish** it faster than anyone can build it.

The crew will **demolish** *the old warehouse to make room for a park.*

PARTS **de-** down, undoing + **mol** build (from moles, a great mass)

SIMILAR tear down, level, flatten, knock down
OPPOSITE build, construct, erect

devastate **DEV**-uh-stayt *verb*



MEANING to destroy over a wide area; also, to overwhelm with grief or shock

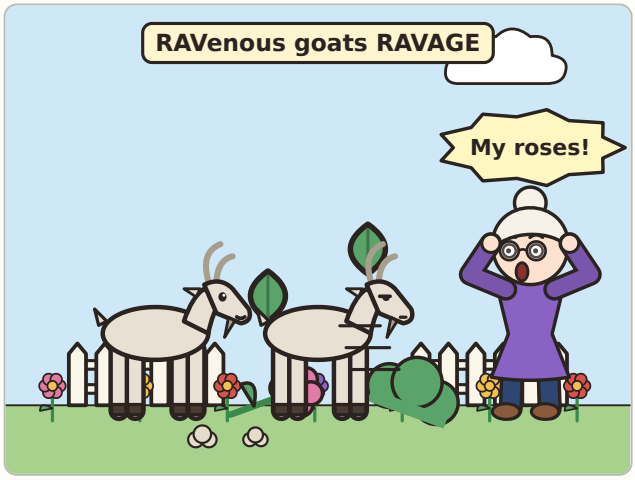
MEMORY HOOK **DE-VAST-ATE: a VAST field laid waste.** A storm flattens a vast field of sunflowers in a single night, and the farmer drops to her knees; the storm has **devastated** her farm.

The hailstorm **devastated** *the farmer's whole field of corn.*

PARTS **de-** completely + **vast** lay waste, empty + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR ruin, lay waste, crush, overwhelm
OPPOSITE restore, rebuild, comfort

ravage **RAV**-ij *verb*



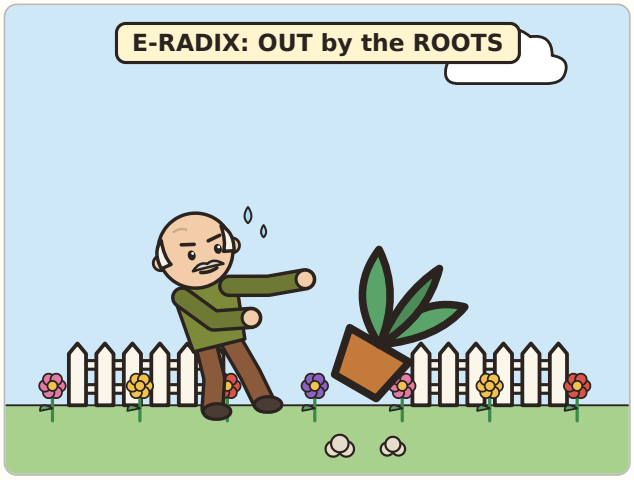
MEANING to damage badly and violently

MEMORY HOOK **RAVenous goats RAVAGE the garden.** A herd of ravenous goats storms through Granny Mae's garden and leaves nothing but stalks and torn petals; they **ravage** it.

Locusts **ravaged** *the valley, stripping every field bare.*

SIMILAR ruin, lay waste, plunder, despoil
OPPOSITE restore, repair, protect

eradicate ih-**RAD**-ih-kayt *verb*



MEANING to wipe out completely, as if pulling up by the roots

MEMORY HOOK **E-RADISH-ATE: out by the ROOTS.** Grandpa Gus does not just snip the weed; he yanks it out by the roots like a radish so it can never grow back. He wants to **eradicate** it.

The town worked for years to **eradicate** *the weeds choking the pond.*

PARTS **e- (ex-)** out + **radic** root + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR wipe out, erase, eliminate, root out
OPPOSITE plant, establish, foster

annihilate uh-**NYE**-uh-layt *verb*



MEANING to destroy completely; also, to defeat by a huge margin

MEMORY HOOK **AN-NIHIL-ATE: down to NIL (nothing).** Zoe wins the checkers final 400 to nil; her brother is left with nothing at all. She **annihilates** him.

In the board game final, Maya **annihilated** *her brothers, winning by four hundred points.*

PARTS **an- (ad-)** to + **nihil** nothing + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR wipe out, erase, eliminate, crush
OPPOSITE create, preserve

obliterate uh-**BLIT**-uh-rayt *verb*



MEANING to wipe out so completely that no trace is left

MEMORY HOOK **OB-LITER-ATE: wipe out every LETTER.** Lila writes her name in huge letters on the sand, and one big wave wipes out every letter until no trace is left; the wave **obliterates** it.

The tide **obliterated** *the names we had written in the sand.*

PARTS **ob-** against, over + **liter** letter + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR wipe out, erase, eliminate, efface
OPPOSITE preserve, keep, restore

decimate **DES**-ih-mayt *verb*



MEANING to destroy a large part of something

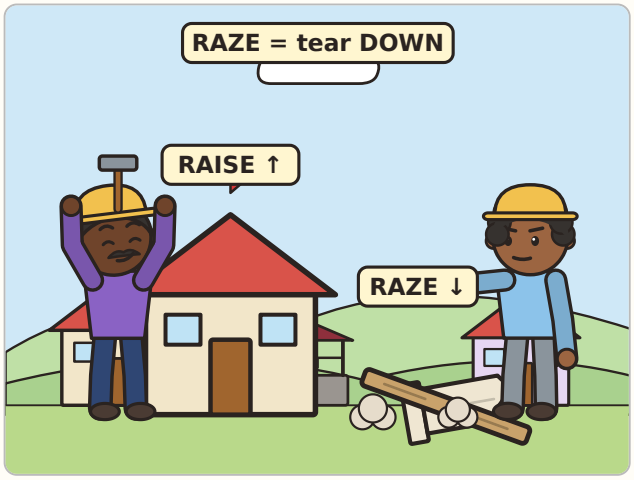
MEMORY HOOK **DECI = TEN, but now MOST are gone.** Nell baked a hundred cookies; while she answered the door, the dog ate all but ten. He **decimated** the batch.

A harsh winter **decimated** *the deer herd, leaving only a few dozen animals.*

PARTS **decim** tenth + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR cut down, thin out, cripple, lay low
OPPOSITE increase, build up

raze **RAYZ** *verb*



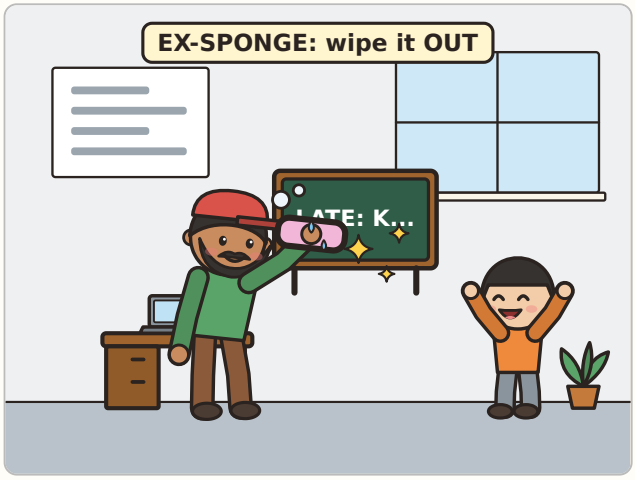
MEANING to tear down completely, all the way to the ground

MEMORY HOOK **RAZE is the opposite of RAISE.** On one lot the crew raises a new house; on the next lot they tear the old one flat. To **raze** a building is the opposite of raising it.

The city plans to **raze** *the crumbling old mill next spring.*

SIMILAR tear down, level, flatten, knock down
OPPOSITE raise, build, erect

expunge ik-**SPUNJ** *verb*



MEANING to erase or remove completely

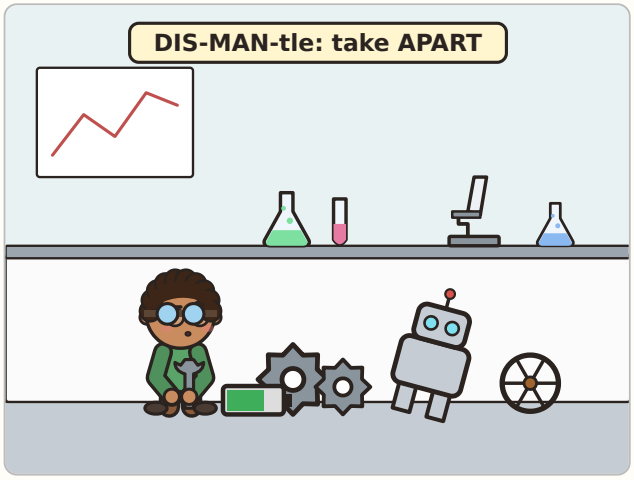
MEMORY HOOK **EX-SPONGE: wipe it OUT.** Coach Omar takes a big wet sponge and wipes Kai's name off the list of late players; the mark is gone, **expunged**.

Once the mistake was found, the school **expunged** *the late mark from her record.*

PARTS **ex-** out + **pung** prick, point

SIMILAR erase, wipe out, eliminate, delete
OPPOSITE add, insert, record

dismantle dis-**MAN**-tul *verb*



MEANING to take apart piece by piece

MEMORY HOOK **DIS-MAN-TLE: the robot MAN in pieces.** Sami unscrews the old robot man bolt by bolt and lines every piece up on the floor; he **dismantles** it to see how it works.

Dad had to **dismantle** *the bunk bed to get it through the doorway.*

PARTS **dis-** apart, away

SIMILAR take apart, disassemble, strip down, break up
OPPOSITE assemble, build, put together

covert **KOH**-vurt *adjective*



MEANING secret; not openly shown or done

MEMORY HOOK **COVERed: kept under COVER.** Behind the sofa, under a blanket, the cousins whisper their plans for Mom's surprise party; the whole plan is kept under cover, **covert**.

Lila shot a **covert** *glance at the clock, hoping the teacher would not notice.*

SIMILAR secret, undercover, hidden, secretive
OPPOSITE overt, open, public

clandestine klan-**DES**-tin *adjective*



MEANING done in secret, often because it is not allowed

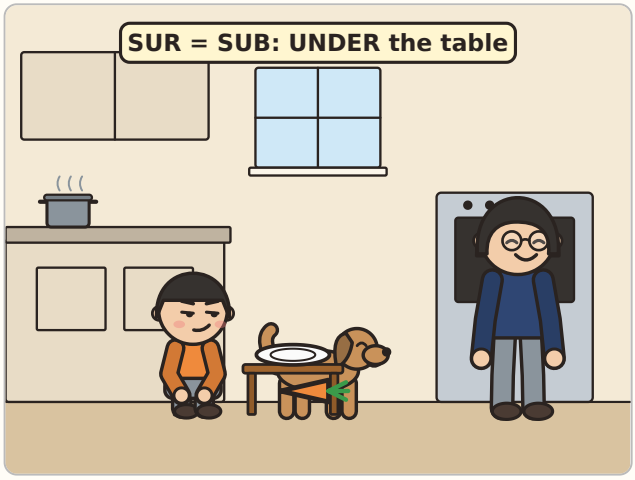
MEMORY HOOK **the CLAN's secret meeting.** At midnight the cat clan meets on the rooftop by lantern light, so the dogs below never find out; their meeting is **clandestine**.

The twins held a **clandestine** *midnight feast in the attic.*

PARTS **clam** secretly

SIMILAR secret, undercover, hidden, secretive
OPPOSITE open, public, aboveboard

surreptitious sur-up-**TISH**-us *adjective*



MEANING done secretly so as not to be noticed

MEMORY HOOK **SUR (= SUB): UNDER the table.** When Mom turns to the stove, Kai sneaks his carrots under the table to the dog; the quick, secret handoff is **surreptitious**.

Kai slipped a **surreptitious** *carrot to the dog under the table.*

PARTS **sur- (sub-)** under, secretly + **rept** snatch, seize + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR secret, sneaky, sly, underhand
OPPOSITE open, obvious, blatant

furtive **FUR**-tiv *adjective*



MEANING sly and secret, as if trying not to get caught

MEMORY HOOK **FUR = THIEF: a sly, guilty look.** The furry little thief tiptoes off with the fish, glancing back over its shoulder again and again; that sly, guilty look is **furtive**.

The raccoon cast a **furtive** *look over its shoulder before diving into the trash can.*

PARTS **furt** theft + **-ive** tending to, doing

SIMILAR sneaky, sly, secretive, underhand
OPPOSITE open, frank, forthright

stealthy **STEL**-thee *adjective*



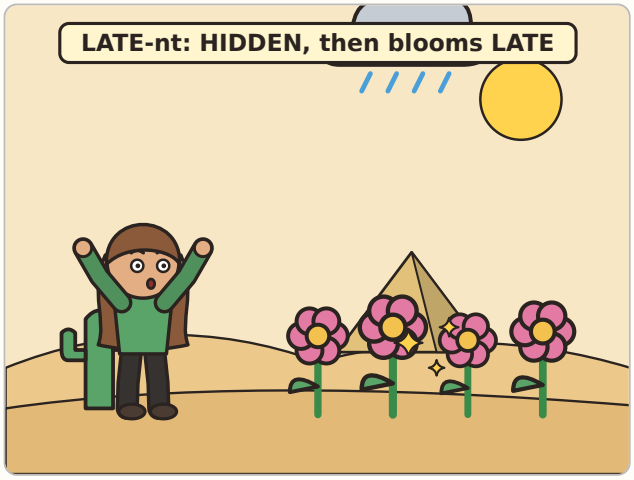
MEANING moving quietly and carefully so as not to be noticed

MEMORY HOOK **STEAL-THY: steal past without a sound.** Jonah tiptoes past the sleeping dog in his socks, carrying his shoes; he steals by so quietly that he is **stealthy**.

The **stealthy** *cat crept up on the butterfly without rustling a single leaf.*

SIMILAR sneaky, quiet, secretive, sly
OPPOSITE noisy, clumsy, conspicuous

latent **LAY**-tunt *adjective*



MEANING present but hidden, or not yet active

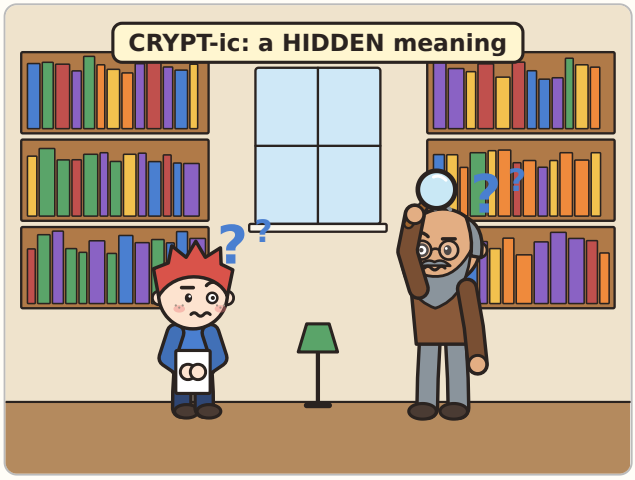
MEMORY HOOK **LATE-nt: there all along, it shows up LATE.** Seeds sleep in the desert sand for years, then bloom late, after one rare rain; the flowers were **latent** there the whole time.

Lin had a **latent** *gift for singing that no one discovered until the school musical.*

PARTS **lat** lie hidden + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR dormant, potential, undeveloped, untapped
OPPOSITE active, visible, manifest

cryptic KRIP-tik *adjective*



MEANING mysterious and hard to understand

MEMORY HOOK **CRYPT = hidden: a note in CODE.** Pip finds a note that says only "ZEBRA AT NOON, UNDER THE SECOND MOON," and no one can work out what it means; it is **cryptic**.

Grandpa left a **cryptic** *note on the fridge: "Look where the moon sleeps."*

PARTS **crypt** hidden + **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR mysterious, puzzling, enigmatic, obscure
OPPOSITE clear, plain, obvious

veiled VAYLD *adjective*



MEANING partly hidden; hinted at but not said openly

MEMORY HOOK **behind a thin VEIL.** Nana Lou smiles and says, "What lively music, dear!" but her hands are over her ears; her complaint is there, behind a thin veil. It is **veiled**.

Her remark about his "interesting" shoes was a **veiled** *criticism.*

SIMILAR disguised, masked, indirect, implied
OPPOSITE open, overt, explicit

elusive ih-LOO-siv *adjective*



MEANING hard to find, catch or remember

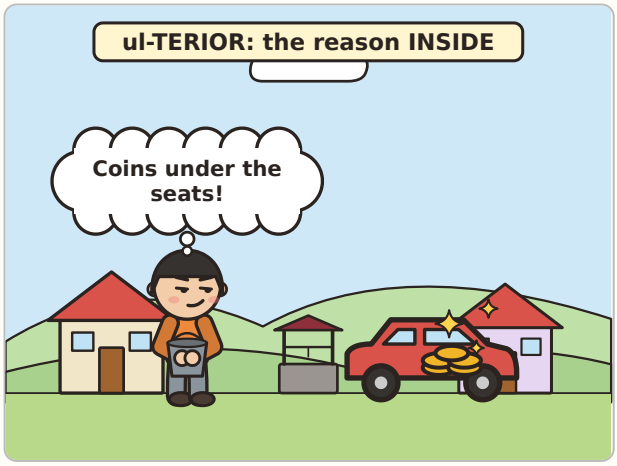
MEMORY HOOK **e-LOOSE-ive: it gets LOOSE every time.** Every time Pip swings his net, the butterfly slips loose and flutters just out of reach; it is **elusive**.

The **elusive** *snow leopard is rarely caught on camera.*

PARTS **e- (ex-)** out, away + **lus (lud)** play, trick + **-ive** tending to, doing

SIMILAR slippery, evasive, fleeting, hard to pin down
OPPOSITE accessible, obtainable

ulterior ul-TEER-ee-er *adjective*



MEANING hidden beyond what is openly said, as a secret reason

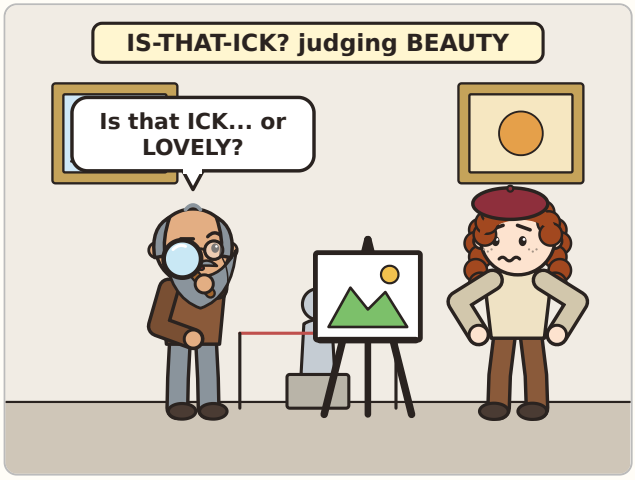
MEMORY HOOK **ul-TERIOR: the real reason is in the inTERIOR.** Kai offers to vacuum Grandpa's car, but his real reason is hidden in the car's interior: the coins under the seats. His motive is **ulterior**.

Was his offer to wash the dishes sincere, or did he have an **ulterior** *motive?*

PARTS **ulter** beyond, farther

SIMILAR underlying, unstated, unspoken, deeper
OPPOSITE stated, open, obvious

aesthetic es-**THET**-ik *adjective*



MEANING having to do with beauty or the enjoyment of beauty

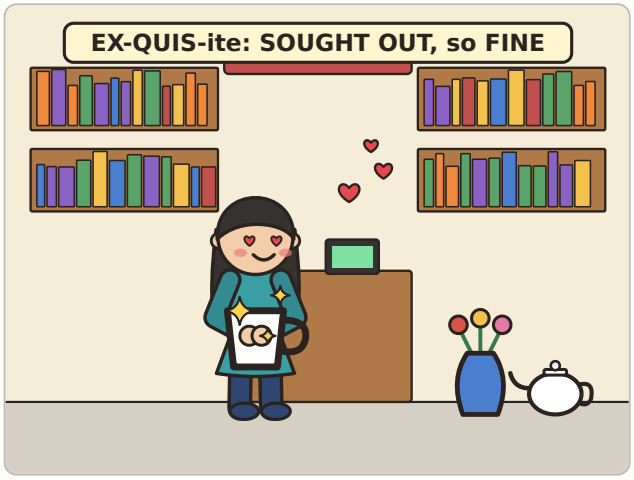
MEMORY HOOK **IS-THAT-ICK? or is that lovely?.** At the art show, Professor Edwin peers at each painting and asks, “Is that ick, or is that lovely?” He is judging its **aesthetic** value.

The bridge is useful, but its **aesthetic** *appeal is what draws the photographers.*

PARTS **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR artistic, visual, decorative, tasteful
OPPOSITE unattractive, unsightly

exquisite ek-**SKWIZ**-it *adjective*



MEANING extremely beautiful, fine and delicate

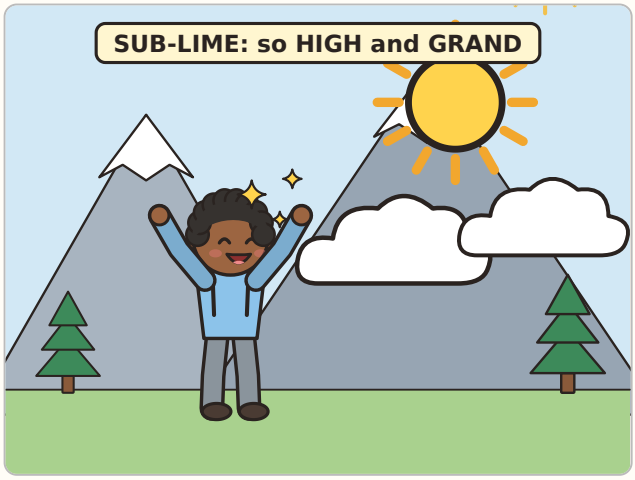
MEMORY HOOK **EX-QUIS: SOUGHT OUT, the finest.** Lin searched every shop in the city for the finest teacup, and the one she finally found, painted with tiny gold birds, is **exquisite**.

The tiny ship inside the bottle was **exquisite**, *right down to its silk sails.*

PARTS **ex-** out + **quis** seek

SIMILAR beautiful, delicate, fine, elegant
OPPOSITE crude, coarse, clumsy

sublime suh-**BLIME** *adjective*



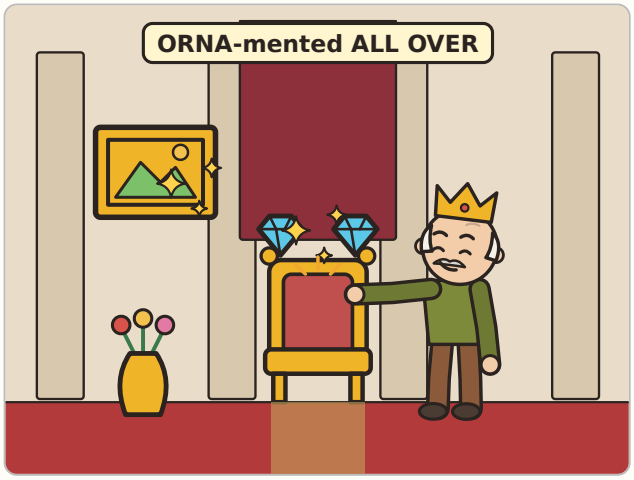
MEANING so grand or beautiful that it fills one with awe

MEMORY HOOK **SUB-LIME: climb up HIGH for a GRAND view.** After climbing all morning, Jamal reaches the summit and watches the sun rise over a sea of clouds; the view is so grand he cannot speak. It is **sublime**.

From the mountaintop, the sunrise over the valley was **sublime**.

SIMILAR awe-inspiring, magnificent, glorious, majestic
OPPOSITE ordinary, mediocre, ridiculous

ornate or-**NATE** *adjective*



MEANING covered with fancy, detailed decoration

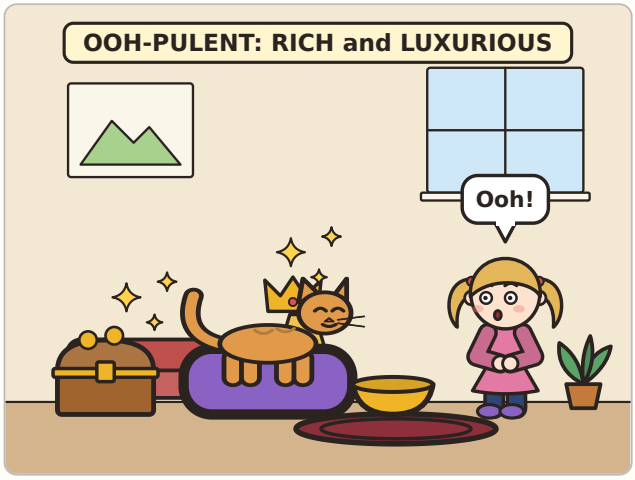
MEMORY HOOK **ORNA-mented all over.** The king’s throne is covered in ornaments: golden curls, jewels, carved lions and a velvet cushion. It is **ornate**.

The old theater had an **ornate** *ceiling painted gold and carved with vines and birds.*

PARTS **orn** decorate, adorn

SIMILAR elaborate, fancy, decorated, showy
OPPOSITE plain, simple, austere

opulent **OP**-yuh-lunt *adjective*



MEANING rich and luxurious

MEMORY HOOK **OOH-PULENT: OOH, velvet and GOLD!.** The pampered cat naps on a velvet pillow, eats from a golden bowl and wears a tiny jeweled crown; visitors say “Ooh!” Its life is **opulent**.

The hotel lobby was **opulent**, *with marble floors and crystal chandeliers.*

PARTS **op** wealth, resources

SIMILAR luxurious, lavish, sumptuous, rich
OPPOSITE plain, shabby, austere

ostentatious os-ten-**TAY**-shus *adjective*



MEANING showy in order to impress others

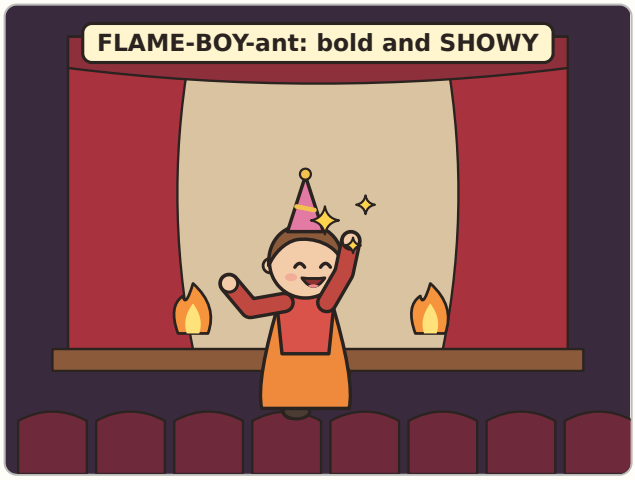
MEMORY HOOK **os-TENT-atious: a GOLD TENT to show off.** At the campground, Victor pitches a golden tent with a flag and a sign bearing his name, just so everyone will look; that showing off is **ostentatious**.

He drove an **ostentatious** *gold car with his name painted on both doors.*

PARTS **ostent** show, display + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR showy, flashy, pretentious, loud
OPPOSITE modest, understated, plain

flamboyant flam-**BOY**-unt *adjective*



MEANING bold, colorful and showy in a way that draws attention

MEMORY HOOK **FLAME-BOY: dressed like a FLAME.** Jonah twirls into the party in a red-and-orange cape that ripples like fire, then takes a sweeping bow; he is **flamboyant**.

The **flamboyant** *magician wore a purple cape covered in silver stars.*

PARTS **flamb** flame

SIMILAR showy, flashy, colorful, loud
OPPOSITE modest, restrained, subdued

gaudy **GAW**-dee *adjective*



MEANING too bright or showy in a tasteless way

MEMORY HOOK **GAW-dy: everyone GAWKS at it.** Uncle Marcus wears a neon-pink tie, sparkly sunglasses, a party hat and six necklaces to the family picnic; everyone gawks, because his outfit is **gaudy**.

The **gaudy** *sweater had blinking lights, sequins and a plastic snowman sewn on the front.*

SIMILAR showy, flashy, loud, tasteless
OPPOSITE tasteful, elegant, understated

garish GAIR-ish *adjective*



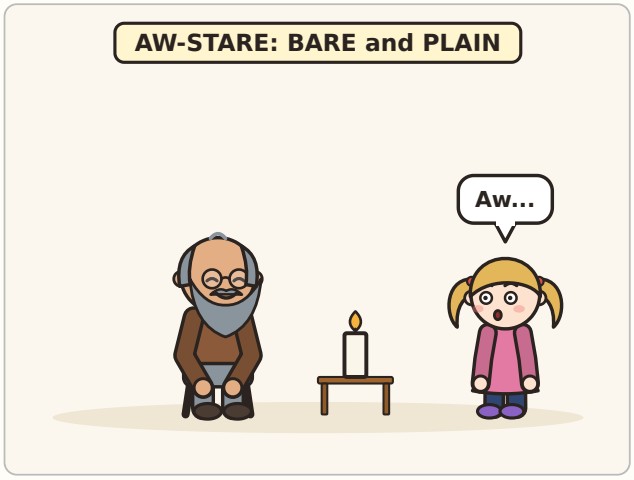
MEANING so bright and showy that it is unpleasant

MEMORY HOOK **GLARE-ish: so bright it GLARES.** Pip paints the doghouse lime green, hot pink and orange all at once; the colors glare so hard that Grandpa puts on sunglasses. They are **garish**.

The **garish** *orange paint made the little cottage look like a traffic cone.*

SIMILAR showy, flashy, loud, glaring
OPPOSITE subdued, muted, tasteful

austere aw-STEER *adjective*



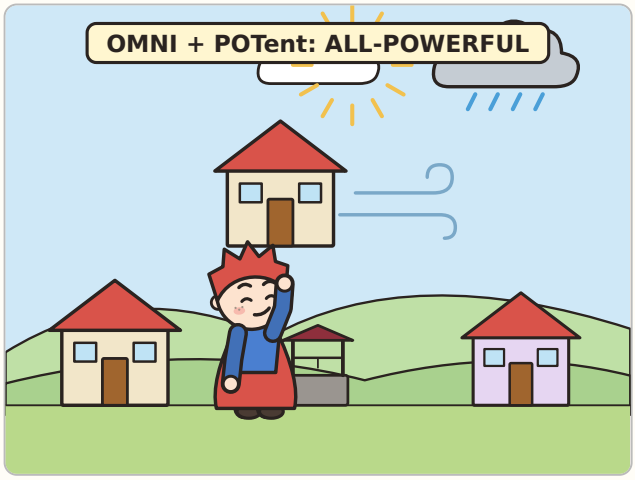
MEANING plain and without decoration; also, stern and strict

MEMORY HOOK **AW, STARE at the bare walls.** Visitors to the old judge's room can only say "Aw..." and stare: one stool, one candle, one plain table and nothing else. His room is **austere**.

The cabin was **austere***: a cot, a wooden chair and a single lamp.*

SIMILAR plain, spare, stark, severe
OPPOSITE ornate, opulent, luxurious, lavish

omnipotent om-NIP-uh-tunt *adjective*



MEANING all-powerful; having unlimited power

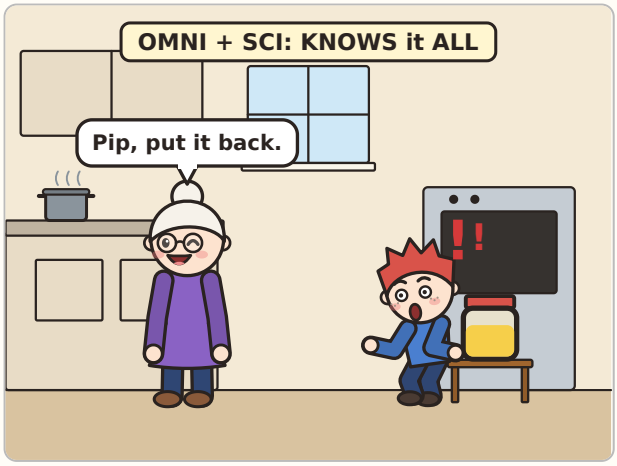
MEMORY HOOK **OMNI + POTent: ALL-POWERFUL.** In Pip's daydream he lifts a whole house with one finger and waves away the rain clouds; he imagines he is **omnipotent**.

In the fairy tale, the **omnipotent** *wizard could turn mountains into marbles with a wave of his wand.*

PARTS **omni-** all + **pot** able, powerful + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR all-powerful, almighty, supreme, invincible
OPPOSITE powerless, helpless, weak

omniscient om-NISH-unt *adjective*



MEANING knowing everything there is to know

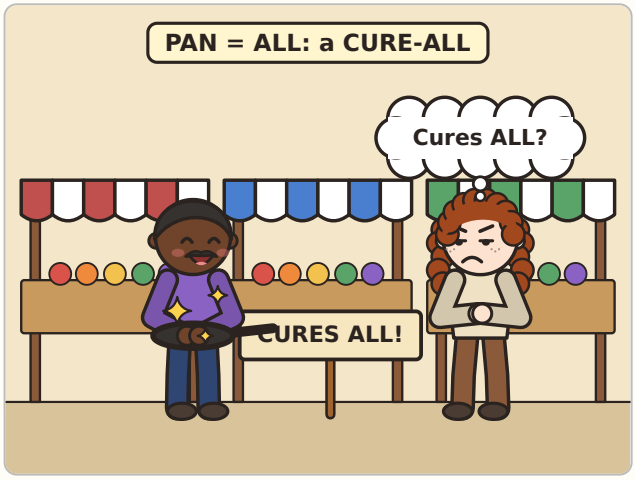
MEMORY HOOK **OMNI + SCIence: KNOWS it ALL.** With her back to the room, Granny Mae says, "Pip, put that cookie back." She knows everything that happens in her kitchen; she seems **omniscient**.

The story is told by an **omniscient** *narrator who knows every character's secret thoughts.*

PARTS **omni-** all + **sci** know + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR all-knowing, all-seeing
OPPOSITE ignorant, unaware

panacea pan-uh-**SEE**-uh *noun*



MEANING a cure for all problems or illnesses

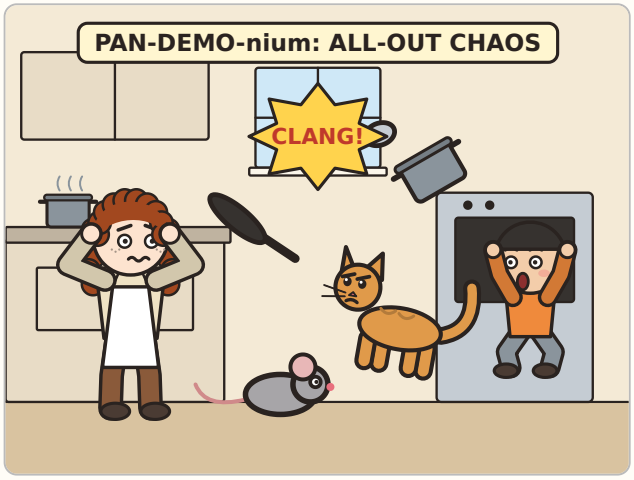
MEMORY HOOK **PAN-ACEA: one PAN that cures ALL?.** A traveling seller swears his shiny frying pan cures colds, sadness and bad grades; nobody believes in a **panacea** like that.

A new phone is no **panacea** *for boredom.*

PARTS **pan-** all + **acea (akos)** cure, remedy

SIMILAR cure-all, remedy, magic bullet, elixir

pandemonium pan-duh-**MOH**-nee-um *noun*



MEANING wild noise and confusion

MEMORY HOOK **PAN-DEMO-nium: ALL the PANS banging.** A mouse dashes across the kitchen; the cat leaps, every pan clatters to the floor, and everyone shrieks at once. The kitchen is **pandemonium**.

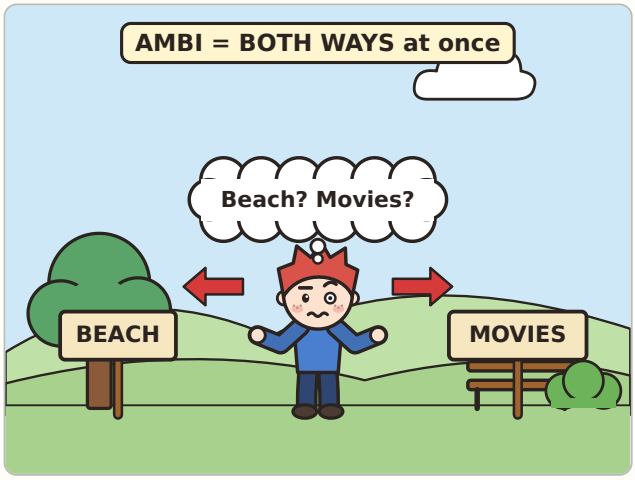
When the mouse ran across the cafeteria, **pandemonium** *broke out.*

PARTS **pan-** all

SIMILAR chaos, uproar, bedlam, turmoil

OPPOSITE calm, order, peace

ambivalent am-**BIV**-uh-lunt *adjective*



MEANING having mixed feelings, pulled two ways at once

MEMORY HOOK **AMBI = BOTH: pulled BOTH ways.** Pip wants to go to the beach and wants to go to the movies just as much; pulled both ways at once, he is **ambivalent**.

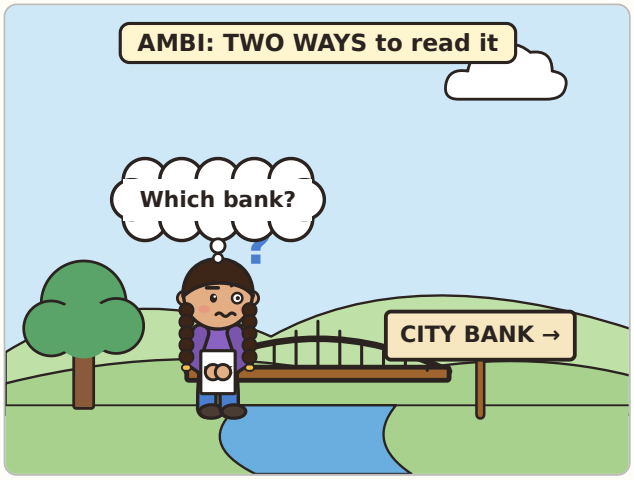
Lila felt **ambivalent** *about moving: excited to see a new city but sad to leave her friends.*

PARTS **ambi-** both + **val** be strong + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR torn, conflicted, undecided, of two minds

OPPOSITE certain, decided, sure

ambiguous am-**BIG**-yoo-us *adjective*



MEANING able to be understood in more than one way

MEMORY HOOK **the BANK? or the river BANK?.** Kai's note says "Meet me at the bank," so Lila waits at the riverbank while Kai waits at the money bank; the note was **ambiguous**.

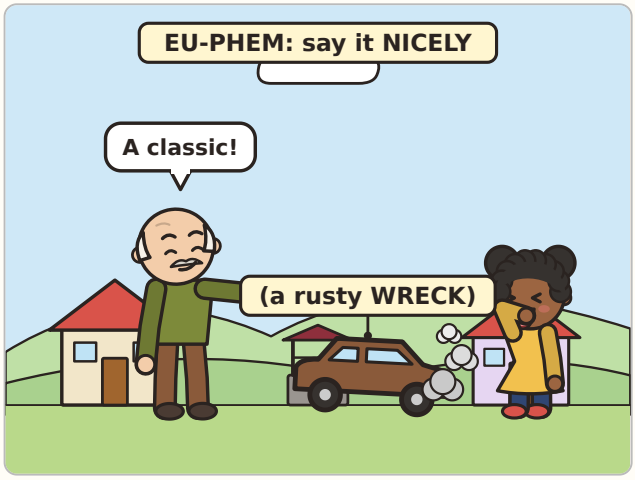
Her **ambiguous** *reply, "We'll see," could have meant yes or no.*

PARTS **ambi-** both, around + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR unclear, vague, equivocal, open to interpretation

OPPOSITE clear, explicit, unambiguous

euphemism YOO-fuh-miz-um *noun*



MEANING a gentle word used in place of a harsh or blunt one

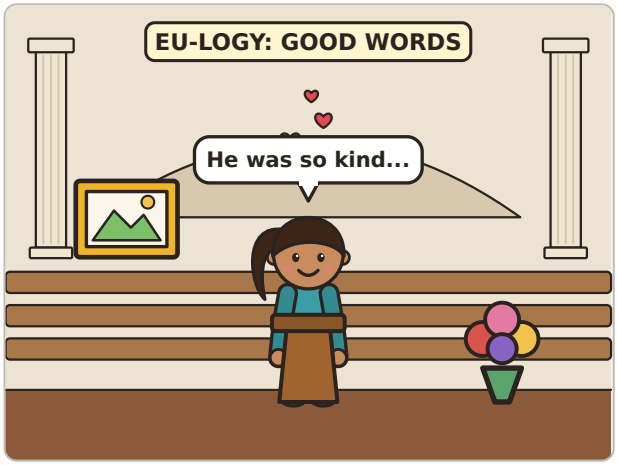
MEMORY HOOK **EU = GOOD: a nice word for a bad thing.** Grandpa Gus calls his rusty, smoking old car "a classic." That kind word for a wreck is a **euphemism**.

"Passed away" is a **euphemism** *for "died."*

PARTS **eu-** good, well + **phem** speak + **-ism** a practice, a way of doing

SIMILAR polite term, softer word, gentle term
OPPOSITE bluntness, plain speech

eulogy YOO-luh-jee *noun*



MEANING a speech or writing in praise of someone, especially someone who has died

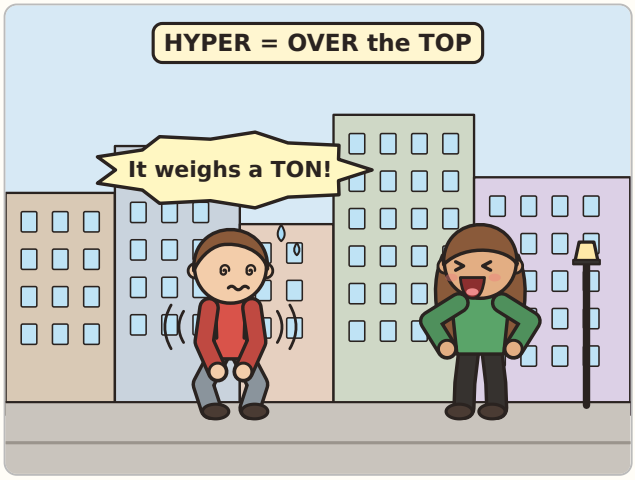
MEMORY HOOK **EU-LOGY: GOOD WORDS about a life.** At the memorial, Maya steps to the podium and shares warm, funny stories about her grandfather's life; her speech of praise is a **eulogy**.

Grandpa's oldest friend gave a warm **eulogy**, *full of funny stories, at his memorial.*

PARTS **eu-** good, well + **log** word, speech

SIMILAR tribute, praise, encomium, homage
OPPOSITE condemnation, criticism

hyperbole hye-**PUR**-buh-lee *noun*



MEANING deliberate exaggeration for effect

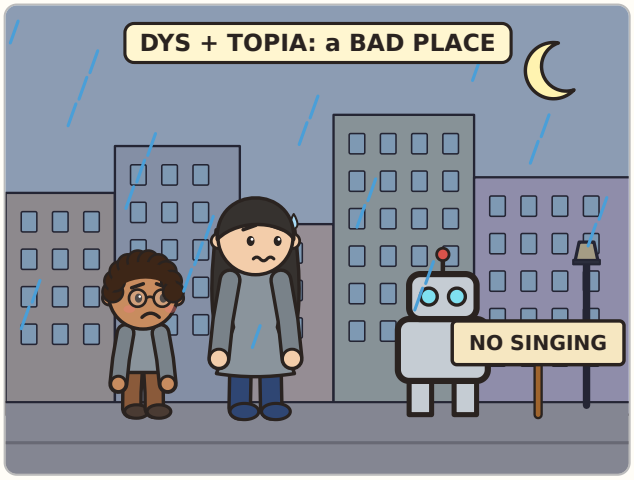
MEMORY HOOK **HYPER: words thrown way OVER the top.** Jonah staggers in with a small backpack, groaning, "This weighs a TON! I'm dying!" His over-the-top words are **hyperbole**.

"I've told you a million times" is **hyperbole**.

PARTS **hyper-** over, beyond + **bol** throw

SIMILAR exaggeration, overstatement, embellishment
OPPOSITE understatement

dystopia dis-**TOH**-pee-uh *noun*



MEANING an imagined society where life is miserable and people are not free

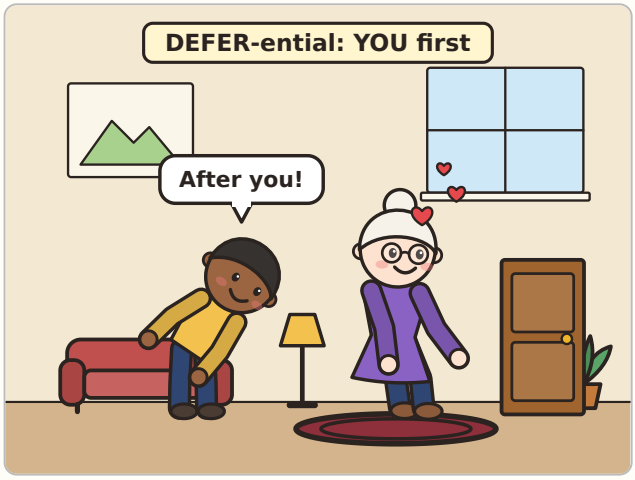
MEMORY HOOK **DYS + TOPIA: a BAD PLACE.** In the story, robots patrol gray streets under a sign that says NO SINGING, and nobody smiles; that miserable imagined world is a **dystopia**.

The novel is set in a gray **dystopia** *where no one is allowed to sing.*

PARTS **dys-** bad, difficult + **top** place + **-ia** a state or condition

SIMILAR nightmare world, anti-utopia
OPPOSITE utopia, paradise

deferential def-uh-**REN**-shul *adjective*



MEANING showing polite respect and readiness to give way to others

MEMORY HOOK **DEFER: you go FIRST.** At the door, Dev steps back, bows a little and lets Granny Mae go first; showing her that polite respect is being **deferential**.

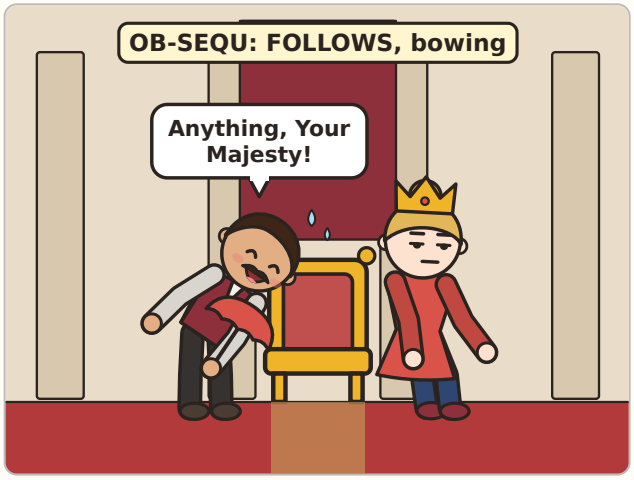
The young players were **deferential** *to their coach, listening closely and never interrupting.*

PARTS **de-** down, away + **fer** carry, bear

SIMILAR respectful, polite, courteous, dutiful

OPPOSITE insolent, impudent, disrespectful

obsequious ub-**SEE**-kwee-us *adjective*



MEANING too eager to please or obey someone

MEMORY HOOK **OB-SEQU: FOLLOWS the queen, bowing.** Victor follows the queen everywhere, bowing low and crying, “Anything, Your Majesty! Anything!” That much eagerness to please is **obsequious**.

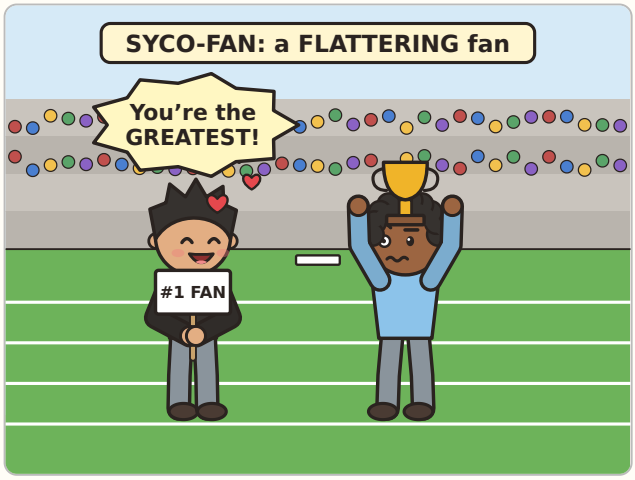
The **obsequious** *waiter refilled our glasses every thirty seconds and laughed at every joke.*

PARTS **ob-** toward + **sequ** follow + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR groveling, toadying, sycophantic, slavish

OPPOSITE insolent, defiant, independent

sycophant **SIK**-uh-funt *noun*



MEANING a person who flatters powerful people to get ahead

MEMORY HOOK **SYCO-FAN: a flattering FAN.** Rex follows the champion around shouting, “You’re the GREATEST! Can I carry your trophy?” He does it only to win favors; he is a **sycophant**.

The king’s court was crowded with **sycophants** *who praised every word he said.*

SIMILAR flatterer, toady, yes-man, bootlicker

OPPOSITE critic

servile **SUR**-vul *adjective*



MEANING too willing to serve or obey others

MEMORY HOOK **SERVE-ILE: SERVES far too much.** Asked to pass the salt, Felix leaps up, polishes the shaker, bows and asks if he may also cut Ada’s food; that overeager serving is **servile**.

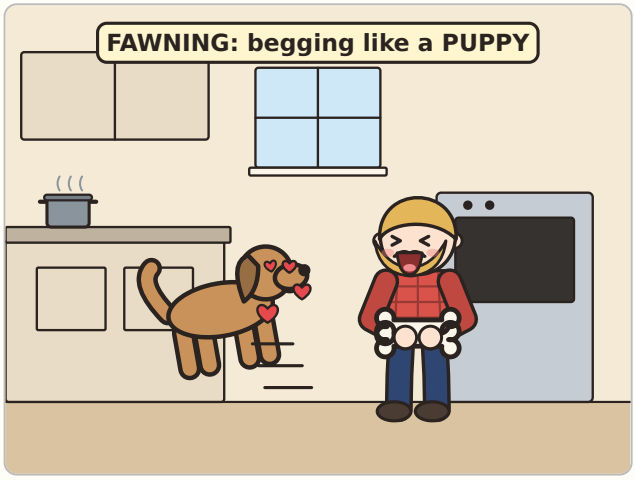
The **servile** *assistant agreed with every idea, even the ones he knew were wrong.*

PARTS **serv** serve, servant

SIMILAR slavish, groveling, toadying, sycophantic

OPPOSITE independent, proud, assertive

fawning **FAW**-ning *adjective*



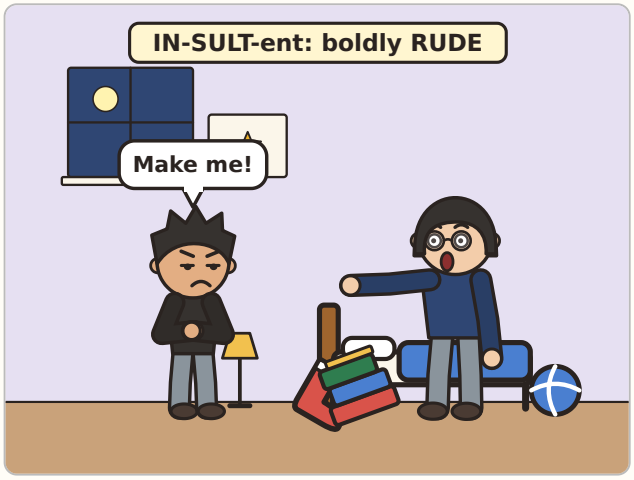
MEANING flattering in an overeager, groveling way

MEMORY HOOK **FAWNING: like a puppy begging.** The puppy wags, rolls over and licks Sven's boots, all for one biscuit; flattery that eager, from a person, is **fawning**.

The **fawning** *fans crowded around the singer, praising even her sneezes.*

SIMILAR groveling, sycophantic, toadying, slavish
OPPOSITE critical, dismissive, standoffish

insolent **IN**-suh-lunt *adjective*



MEANING boldly rude and disrespectful

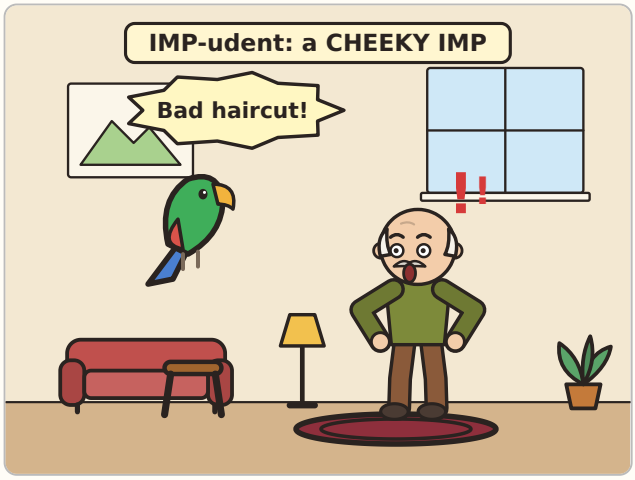
MEMORY HOOK **IN-SUL(T)-ENT: full of INSULTS.** Told to tidy his room, teenage Rex crosses his arms and says, "Make me!" Talking back that rudely is **insolent**.

The **insolent** *student rolled his eyes and yawned loudly while the principal spoke.*

PARTS **in-** not + **sol** be used to + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR rude, disrespectful, impertinent, cheeky
OPPOSITE respectful, polite, deferential

impudent **IM**-pyuh-dunt *adjective*



MEANING rudely bold, without shame; cheeky

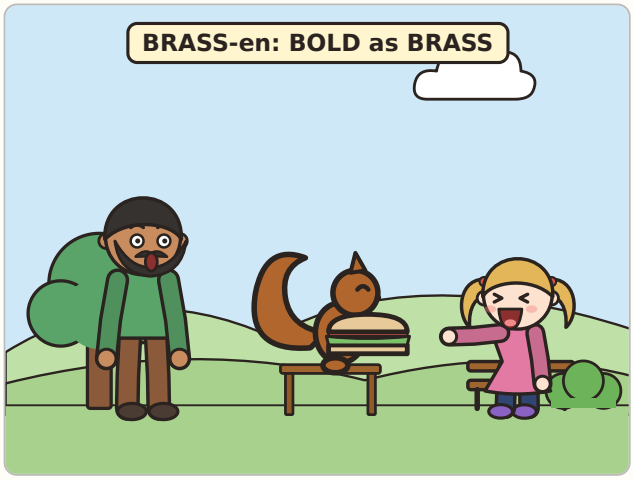
MEMORY HOOK **IMP-udent: a cheeky little IMP.** Rosa's parrot is a little imp: it squawks "Bad haircut!" at every guest who walks in. The bird is **impudent**.

The **impudent** *parrot squawked "Bad haircut!" at every visitor.*

PARTS **im- (in-)** not + **pud** shame + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR cheeky, impertinent, rude, disrespectful
OPPOSITE respectful, polite, meek

brazen **BRAY**-zun *adjective*



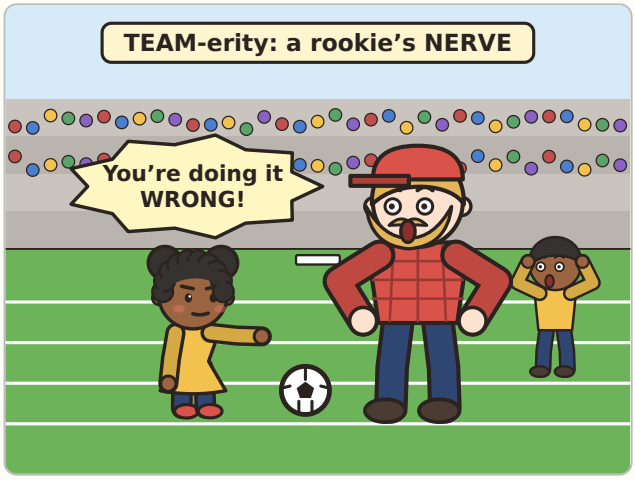
MEANING bold and without any shame

MEMORY HOOK **BRASS-en: BOLD as BRASS.** In front of the whole family, the squirrel hops onto the picnic table, grabs a sandwich and stares right back at them; it is as bold as brass, **brazen**.

In a **brazen** *move, the squirrel climbed onto the picnic table and grabbed a whole sandwich.*

SIMILAR shameless, bold, barefaced, audacious
OPPOSITE shy, timid, modest

temerity tuh-**MAIR**-ih-tee *noun*



MEANING reckless boldness; nerve

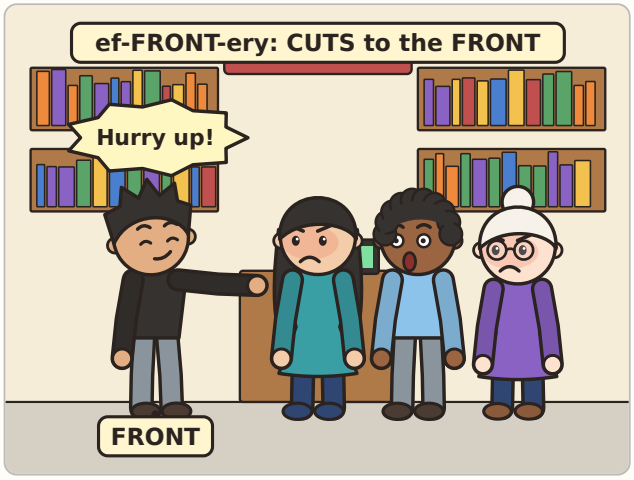
MEMORY HOOK **TEAM-erity: the rookie tells the TEAM captain.** On her first day, the smallest player on the team tells the giant captain, "You're doing it wrong!" Everyone gasps at her **temerity**.

The rookie had the **temerity** *to correct the famous coach in front of the whole team.*

PARTS **-ity** the state or quality of being

SIMILAR nerve, gall, audacity, cheek
OPPOSITE timidity, caution, shyness

effrontery ih-**FRUN**-tuh-ree *noun*



MEANING shameless boldness; the nerve to do something rude

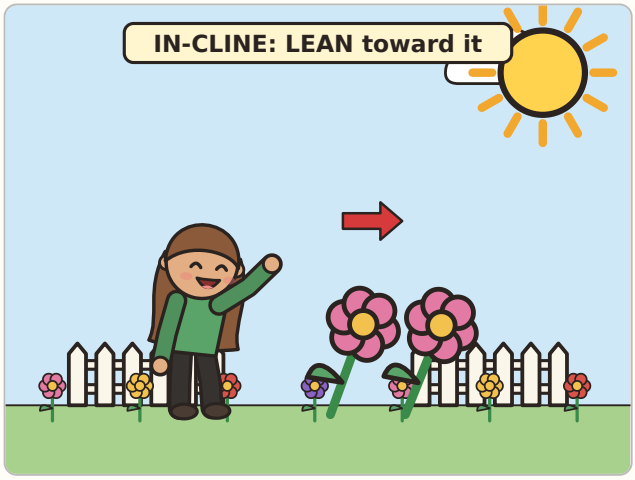
MEMORY HOOK **ef-FRONT-ery: cuts to the FRONT.** Rex strolls past the long line, steps right to the front of it and tells the clerk to hurry up; that shameless nerve is **effrontery**.

After breaking our window, he had the **effrontery** *to ask for his ball back.*

PARTS **ef- (ex-)** out + **front** forehead, face

SIMILAR nerve, gall, audacity, cheek
OPPOSITE humility, respect, modesty

inclination in-kluh-**NAY**-shun *noun*



MEANING a natural tendency or liking

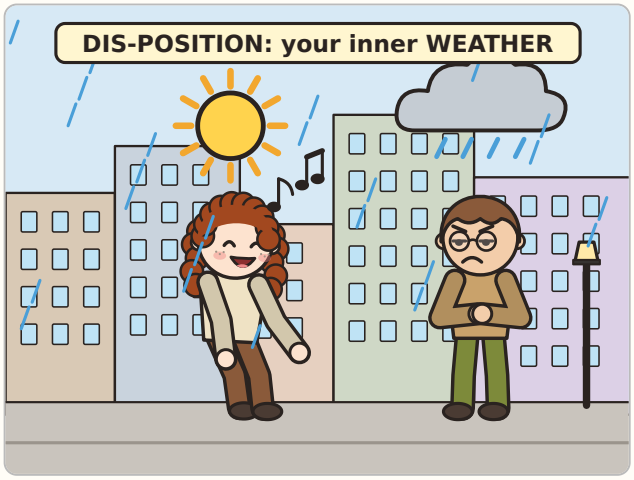
MEMORY HOOK **IN-CLINE: you LEAN toward it.** Every morning the sunflowers lean toward the sun, and so does Rosa, who heads straight for the sunny dock; leaning toward what you like is an **inclination**.

Dev has an **inclination** *to doodle in the margins of every notebook.*

PARTS **in-** toward + **clin** lean, bend + **-ation (-tion)** the act or result of

SIMILAR tendency, leaning, bent, liking
OPPOSITE aversion, dislike, disinclination

disposition dis-puh-**ZISH**-un *noun*



MEANING a person's usual mood or nature

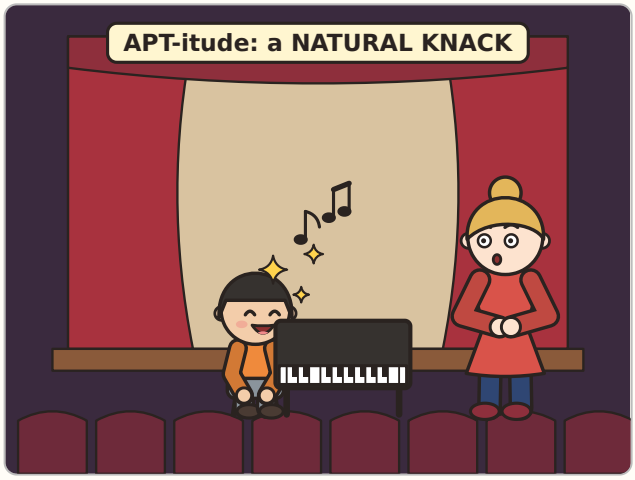
MEMORY HOOK **a SUNNY DISPOSITION: the weather inside you.** Even in a rainstorm, Nell whistles and smiles as if a little sun followed her around; her usual mood, her **disposition**, is sunny.

Our mail carrier has a sunny **disposition***; she whistles even in the pouring rain.*

PARTS **dis-** apart + **pos** put, place + **-tion** the act or result of

SIMILAR temperament, nature, character, temper

aptitude **AP**-tih-tood *noun*



MEANING a natural ability to learn or do something

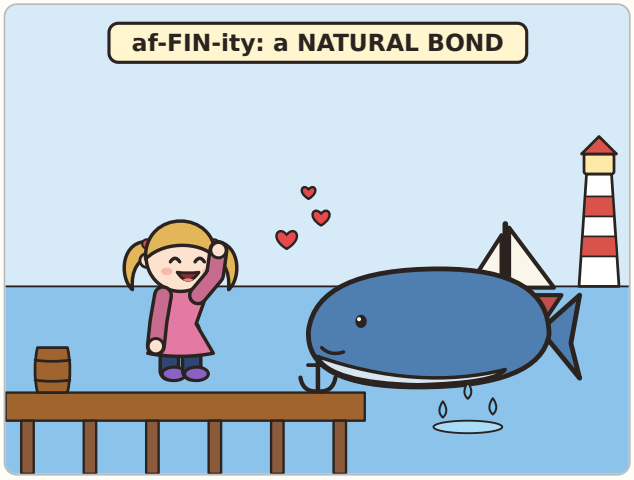
MEMORY HOOK **APT-itude: a natural FIT.** The very first time Kai sits at a piano, he plays a whole song by ear; he has an **aptitude** for music.

Maya showed an early **aptitude** *for languages and spoke three by age ten.*

PARTS **apt** fit, suited + **-itude** the state of being

SIMILAR talent, gift, knack, ability
OPPOSITE inability, ineptitude

affinity uh-**FIN**-ih-tee *noun*



MEANING a natural liking for, or sense of connection with, someone or something

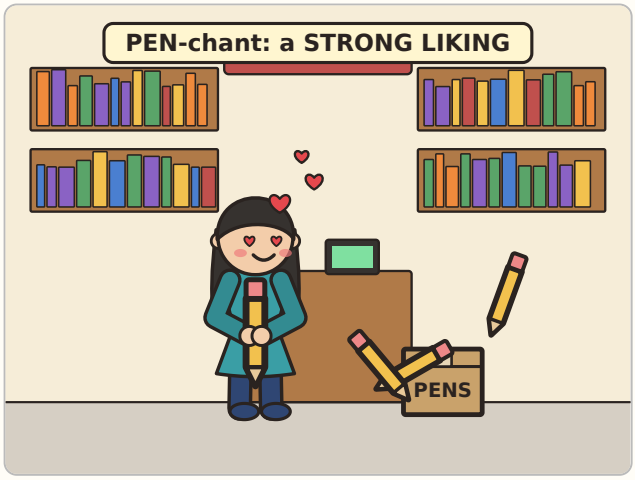
MEMORY HOOK **a FIN-ITY: the girl and the whale.** Every time Ivy visits the harbor, the same friendly whale swims up and waves a fin at her; the two share a natural **affinity**.

Ivy has always had an **affinity** *for animals; stray cats follow her home.*

PARTS **af- (ad-)** to, toward + **fin** border, boundary + **-ity** the state or quality of being

SIMILAR liking, fondness, connection, rapport
OPPOSITE aversion, dislike, antipathy

penchant **PEN**-chunt *noun*



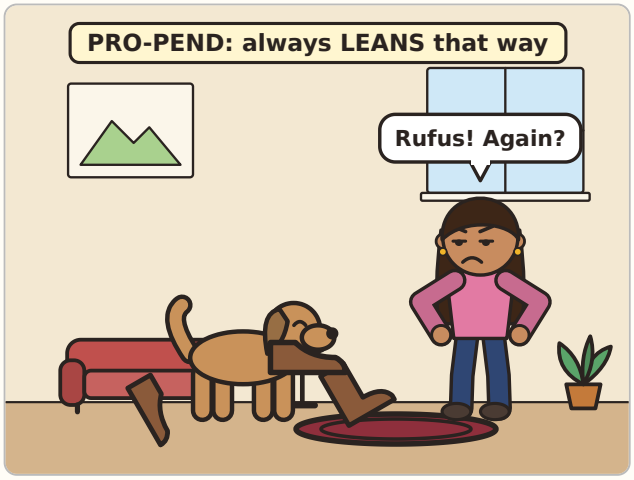
MEANING a strong liking for something

MEMORY HOOK **PEN-CHANT: she can never pass up a PEN.** Lin cannot walk past a stationery shop without buying one more pen; she has a **penchant** for pens.

Grandpa has a **penchant** *for loud plaid shirts.*

SIMILAR liking, fondness, taste, preference
OPPOSITE dislike, aversion

propensity pruh-**PEN**-sih-tee *noun*



MEANING a natural tendency to act in a certain way

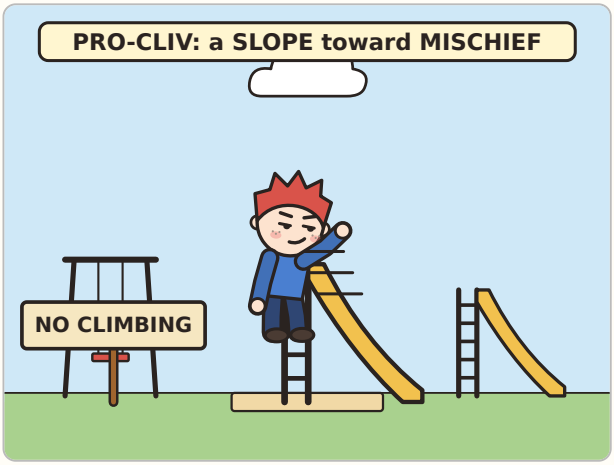
MEMORY HOOK **PRO-PEND: always LEANING toward it.** Leave a shoe by the door and Rufus will find it within a minute; the puppy has a **propensity** for chewing shoes.

Our puppy has a **propensity** *for chewing shoes.*

PARTS **pro-** forward + **pens (pend)** hang, lean + **-ity** the state or quality of being

SIMILAR tendency, leaning, bent, readiness
OPPOSITE disinclination, aversion

proclivity proh-**KLIV**-ih-tee *noun*



MEANING a tendency, often toward something one should not do

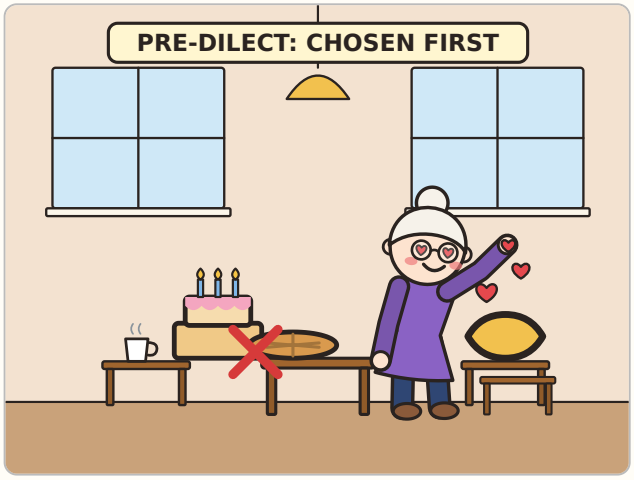
MEMORY HOOK **PRO-CLIV: a SLOPE toward mischief.** No matter how many signs say NO CLIMBING, Pip always scrambles up the slide the wrong way; he has a **proclivity** for it.

The raccoon's **proclivity** *for raiding trash cans did not make it popular with the neighbors.*

PARTS **pro-** forward + **cliv** slope + **-ity** the state or quality of being

SIMILAR tendency, leaning, bent, weakness
OPPOSITE aversion, disinclination

predilection pred-uh-**LEK**-shun *noun*



MEANING a special liking or preference

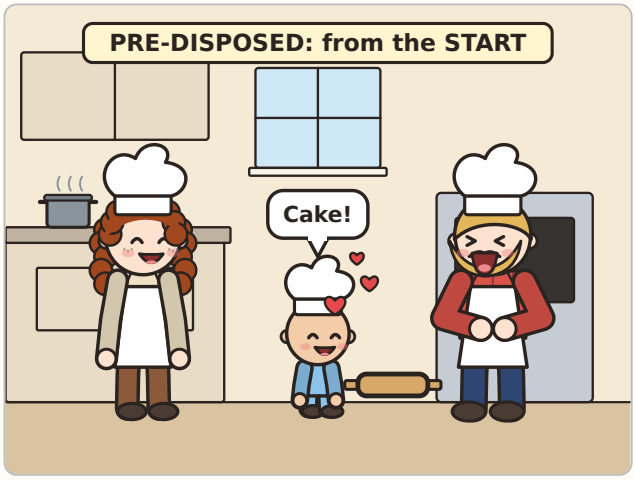
MEMORY HOOK **PRE-DILECT: CHOSEN before all others.** At every party, Granny Mae walks right past the cakes and pies to the lemon bars; lemon is her **predilection**.

The cat has a **predilection** *for napping in the laundry basket.*

PARTS **pre-** before + **dilect** love, choose + **-ion (-tion)** the act or result of

SIMILAR preference, liking, fondness, taste
OPPOSITE dislike, aversion

predisposed pree-dih-**SPOHZD** *adjective*



MEANING inclined ahead of time to act or think a certain way

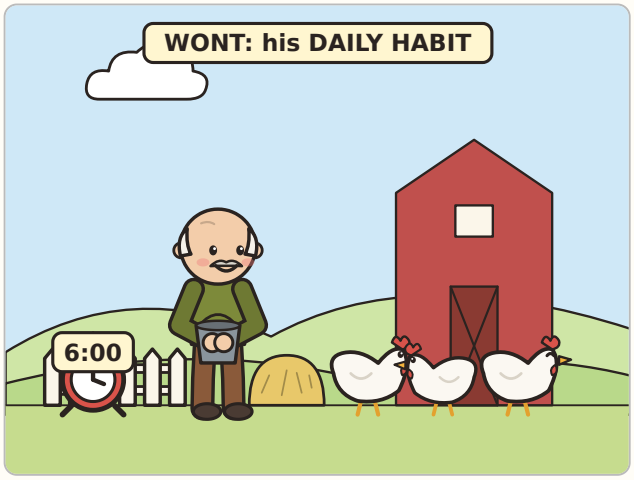
MEMORY HOOK **PRE-DISPOSED: leaning that way from the START.** Born into a family of bakers, little Theo seemed **predisposed** to love baking; his very first word was "Cake!"

Having grown up near the sea, Omar was **predisposed** *to love sailing.*

PARTS **pre-** before + **dis-** apart + **pos** put, place

SIMILAR inclined, prone, disposed, apt
OPPOSITE disinclined, averse, unwilling

wont **WAWNT** *noun*



MEANING a habit or usual way of acting

MEMORY HOOK **WONT: what he always WANTS to do.** Every morning at six, as is his **wont**, Grandpa Gus feeds the chickens in his slippers.

As was his **wont**, *Grandpa rose at dawn to feed the chickens.*

SIMILAR habit, custom, practice, routine

encomium en-**KOH**-mee-um *noun*



MEANING a speech or piece of writing full of high praise

MEMORY HOOK **en-COME-ium: PRAISE as she COMES IN.** When Zoe comes in through the village gate with the spelling trophy, the whole town greets her with a song of high praise; that welcome is an **encomium**.

The retiring coach received an **encomium** *from every player on the team.*

SIMILAR tribute, eulogy, praise, homage
OPPOSITE criticism, condemnation, denunciation

panegyric pan-uh-**JEER**-ik *noun*



MEANING a public speech or piece of writing of great praise

MEMORY HOOK **PAN = ALL: praise in front of ALL.** At the school assembly, in front of everyone, the principal praises Mr. Marcus for forty years of fixing, sweeping and smiling; her speech is a **panegyric**.

The principal's **panegyric** *for the retiring janitor brought the whole school to its feet.*

PARTS **pan-** all

SIMILAR tribute, eulogy, homage, praise
OPPOSITE criticism, tirade, diatribe

plaudit **PLAW**-dit *noun*



MEANING an expression of praise or approval (usually in the plural)

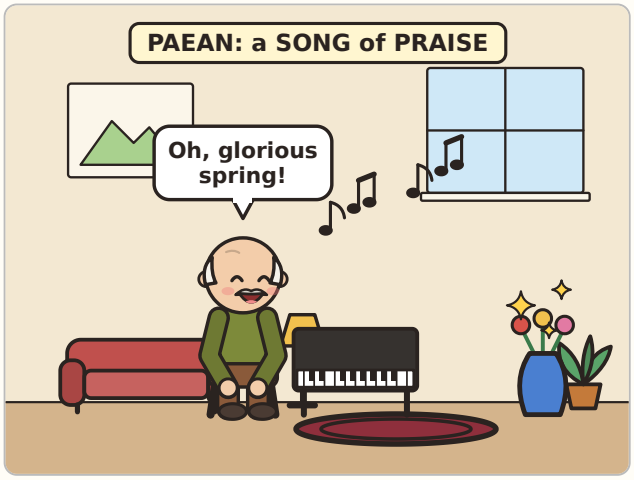
MEMORY HOOK **apPLAUD IT!.** When Lila finishes her violin solo, the whole hall leaps up to applaud it; the cheers and praise she wins are **plaudits**.

The young violinist won **plaudits** *from critics across the country.*

PARTS **plaud** clap

SIMILAR praise, acclaim, applause, accolade
OPPOSITE criticism, censure, jeers

paean **PEE**-un *noun*



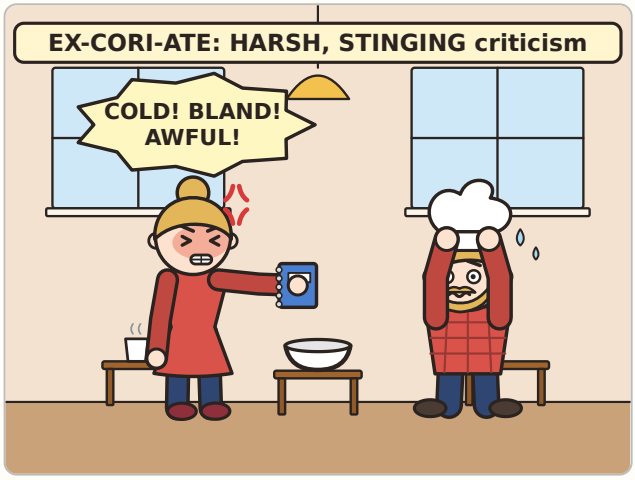
MEANING a song, speech or piece of writing full of joyful praise

MEMORY HOOK **a PIAN(o) song of PRAISE.** On the first warm day of spring, Grandpa Gus sits at the piano and sings a joyful song praising the sun, the robins and every new flower; it is a **paean** to spring.

The film is a **paean** *to small-town life.*

SIMILAR song of praise, hymn, ode, tribute
OPPOSITE lament, dirge

excoriate ek-**SKOR**-ee-ayt *verb*



MEANING to criticize very harshly

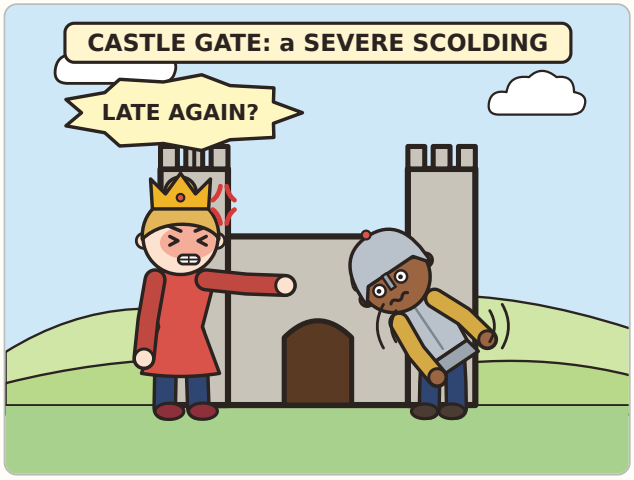
MEMORY HOOK **EX-CORI: criticism that STINGS to the core.** The food critic tastes one spoonful of the chef's soup and tears into it so harshly that the chef shrinks behind his ladle; she **excoriates** it.

The review **excoriated** *the restaurant for its cold soup and rude service.*

PARTS **ex-** off, out + **cori** skin, hide (as in leather) + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR blast, slam, denounce, criticize harshly
OPPOSITE praise, commend, laud

castigate **KAS**-tih-gayt *verb*



MEANING to scold or criticize severely

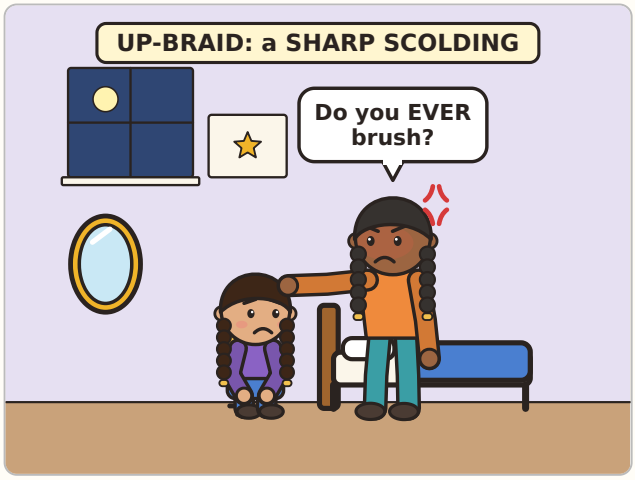
MEMORY HOOK **CASTLE GATE: a sharp scolding.** The queen meets the late knight at the castle gate and scolds him so sharply that his armor rattles; she **castigates** him.

The teacher **castigated** *the class for leaving the art room a mess.*

PARTS **castig (castus)** pure, set right + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR scold, rebuke, berate, chastise
OPPOSITE praise, commend, compliment

upbraid up-**BRAYD** *verb*



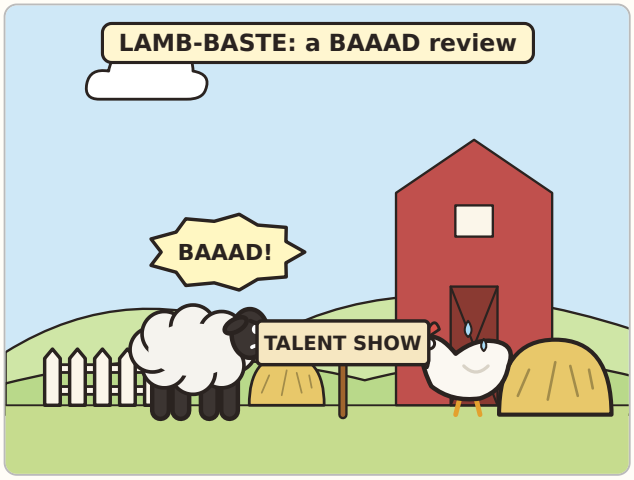
MEANING to scold sharply

MEMORY HOOK **UP-BRAID: a scolding while braiding.** Tugging Lila's tangled braids up tight, Aunt Tia scolds, "Do you EVER brush?" She **upbraids** her.

Mom **upbraided** *us for tracking mud across the clean kitchen floor.*

SIMILAR scold, rebuke, berate, chastise
OPPOSITE praise, commend

lambaste lam-**BAYST** *verb*



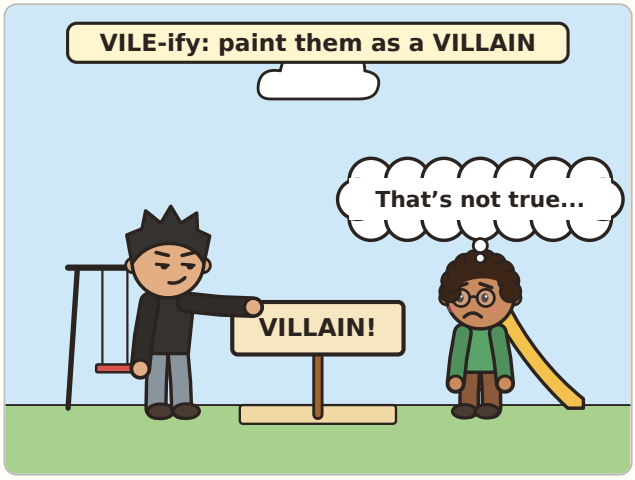
MEANING to criticize harshly

MEMORY HOOK **LAMB-BASTE: a BAAAD review.** At the barnyard talent show, the lamb boos the rooster's song so loudly that the rooster hides behind the hay; the lamb **lambastes** the act.

Critics **lambasted** *the movie for its silly plot and wooden acting.*

SIMILAR blast, slam, criticize harshly, denounce
OPPOSITE praise, laud, acclaim

vilify VIL-uh-fye *verb*



MEANING to speak about someone as if they were evil

MEMORY HOOK **VILE-ify: paint someone as a VILLAIN.** Rex hangs a poster calling the new kid a lunch-stealing villain, though it is not true at all; he is trying to **vilify** him.

Old stories often **vilify** *wolves, but real wolves rarely bother people.*

PARTS **vil** cheap, worthless + **-ify** to make

SIMILAR malign, slander, smear, denigrate
OPPOSITE praise, defend, honor

impugn im-PYOON *verb*



MEANING to question someone's honesty or the truth of a claim

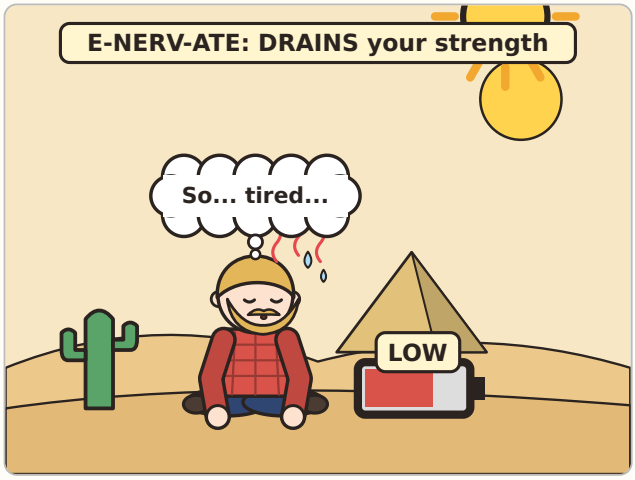
MEMORY HOOK **im-PUG-n: the PUG fights your word.** Pip says he walked the dog twice today, but the pug barks, "Did NOT!" The pug **impugns** Pip's story.

The visiting coach **impugned** *the referee's fairness.*

PARTS **im- (in-)** against + **pugn** fight

SIMILAR challenge, question, dispute, cast doubt on
OPPOSITE support, defend, vouch for

enervate EN-er-vayt *verb*



MEANING to weaken; to drain of energy

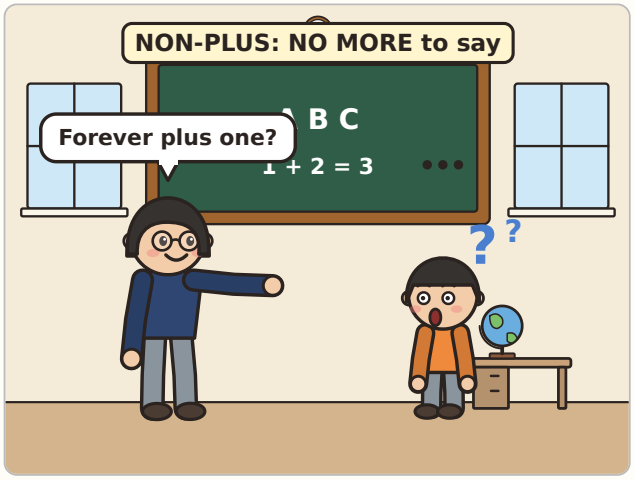
MEMORY HOOK **E-NERV-ATE: drains the NERVE OUT.** The heat wave drains every bit of nerve and strength out of Sven; he flops on the sand like a wet noodle. The heat **enervates** him.

The long, humid afternoon **enervated** *the hikers, and they barely made it back to camp.*

PARTS **e- (ex-)** out + **nerv** sinew, strength + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR weaken, exhaust, drain, sap
OPPOSITE energize, invigorate, strengthen

nonplussed non-PLUST *adjective*



MEANING so puzzled that one does not know what to say or do

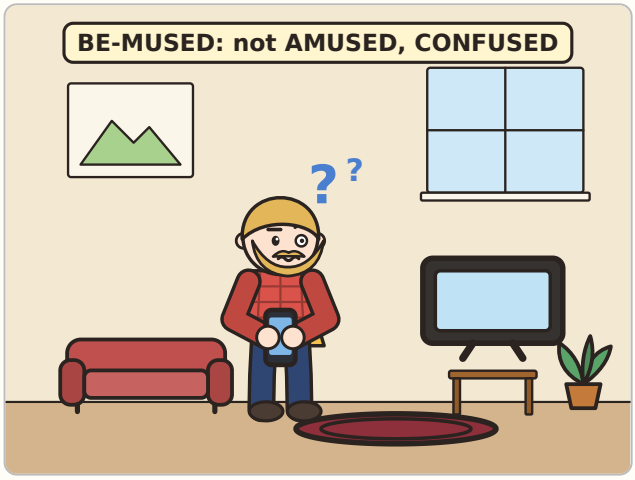
MEMORY HOOK **NON-PLUS: NO MORE to say.** Ms. Ada asks Kai, "What is forever plus one?" He opens his mouth, closes it, and just stares, with nothing more to say. He is **nonplussed**.

When the parrot answered the phone, the caller was completely **nonplussed**.

PARTS **non-** not + **plus** more

SIMILAR baffled, bewildered, perplexed, puzzled
OPPOSITE composed, self-possessed

bemused bih-**MYOOZD** *adjective*



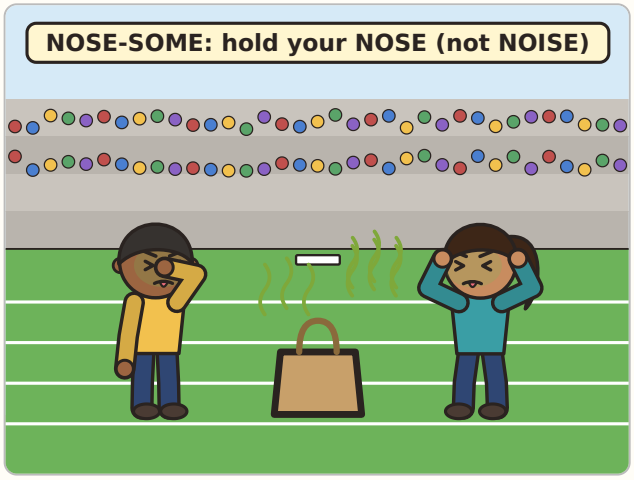
MEANING puzzled and confused

MEMORY HOOK **BE-MUSED: not AMUSED, CONFUSED.** Uncle Sven turns the new remote over and over, staring at its forty buttons; he is not amused, just confused: **bemused**.

The tourists looked **bemused** *by the street signs written in three languages.*

SIMILAR puzzled, bewildered, perplexed, baffled
OPPOSITE clearheaded, unconfused

noisome **NOY**-sum *adjective*



MEANING having a very bad smell; also, harmful

MEMORY HOOK **NOSE-SOME: hold your NOSE.** The tuna sandwich forgotten in Dev's gym bag for a week smells so bad that the whole team holds its nose; the bag is **noisome**.

A **noisome** *odor drifted from the lunch box forgotten at the back of the closet.*

SIMILAR smelly, foul, stinking, offensive
OPPOSITE fragrant, sweet-smelling, pleasant

restive **RES**-tiv *adjective*



MEANING restless and hard to control

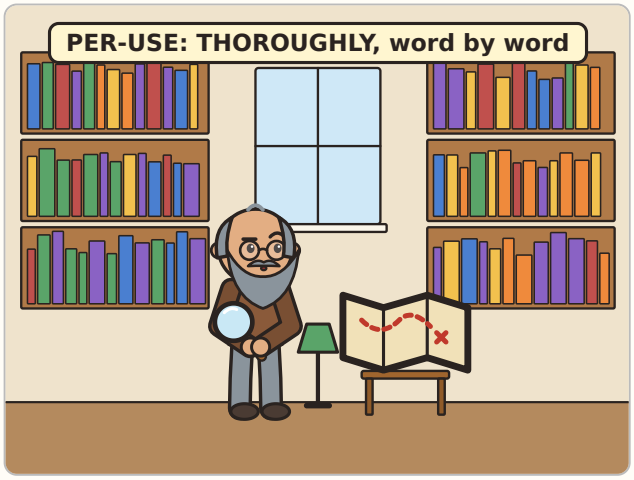
MEMORY HOOK **REST-ive? NO REST at all.** Told to wait at the gate, the young horse stamps, snorts and tosses its head; it is anything but restful. It is **restive**.

The **restive** *horse stamped and tossed its head at the starting gate.*

PARTS **-ive** tending to, doing

SIMILAR restless, fidgety, unruly, impatient
OPPOSITE calm, docile, patient

peruse puh-**ROOZ** *verb*



MEANING to read carefully; also, often, to look over casually

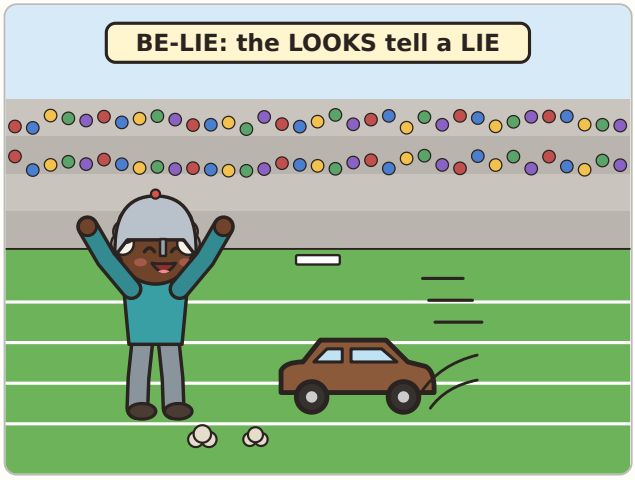
MEMORY HOOK **PER-USE: go THROUGH every word.** Professor Edwin reads the old treasure map with a magnifying glass, every tiny word and line, twice; he **peruses** it.

Before signing, Dad **perused** *every page of the lease.*

PARTS **per-** thoroughly

SIMILAR read, study, examine, scrutinize
OPPOSITE skim, glance at

belie bih-**LYE** *verb*



MEANING to give a false picture of; also, to show to be false

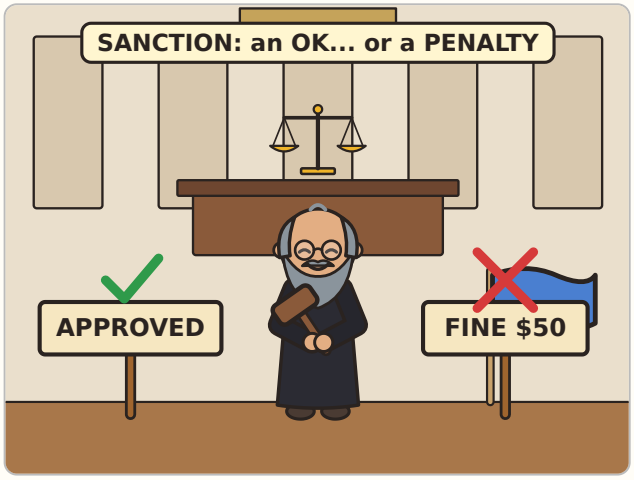
MEMORY HOOK **BE-LIE: the LOOKS tell a LIE.** Grandma's rusty little car looks as if it could barely roll, but at the go-kart track it zooms past everyone; its shabby looks **belie** its speed.

Her calm smile **belied** *how nervous she felt before the recital.*

PARTS **be-** thoroughly, about + **lie** tell a falsehood

SIMILAR disguise, misrepresent, contradict, disprove
OPPOSITE reveal, confirm, show

sanction **SANGK**-shun *noun*



MEANING official approval; also, a penalty for breaking a rule

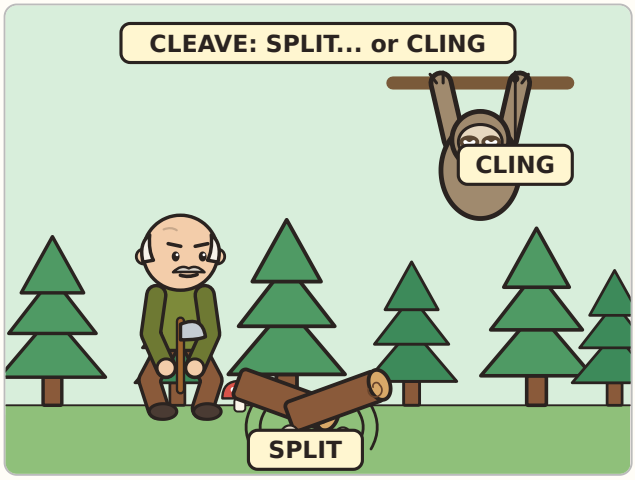
MEMORY HOOK **SANCTION: an OK... or a PENALTY.** Judge Edwin stamps OK on the parade plan, a **sanction** that lets it go ahead; then he fines the band that marched through the flower beds, a sanction of the other kind.

The club cannot hold its bake sale without the principal's **sanction**.

PARTS **sanct** holy, made binding + **-ion (-tion)** the act or result of

SIMILAR approval, permission, authorization, consent
OPPOSITE disapproval, prohibition

cleave **KLEEV** *verb*



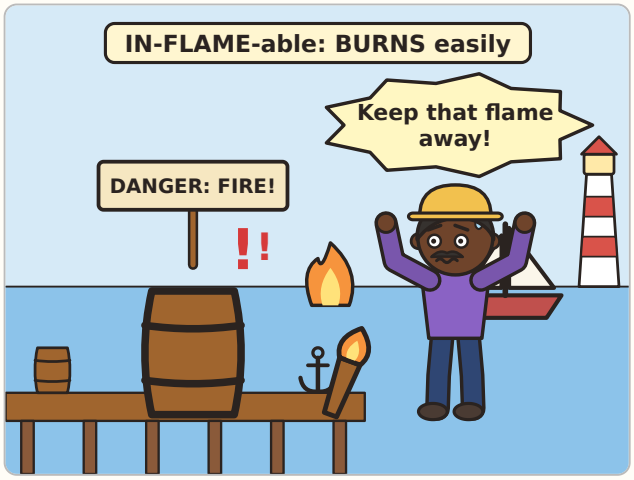
MEANING to split apart; also, to cling closely

MEMORY HOOK **a CLEAVER SPLITS... a sloth CLINGS.** Grandpa's axe splits the log in two, while in the tree above, a sloth clings tight to its branch; to **cleave** can mean either one.

With one swing of the axe, Grandpa **cleaved** *the log in two.*

SIMILAR split, divide, sever, chop
OPPOSITE join, unite

inflammable in-**FLAM**-uh-bul *adjective*



MEANING easily set on fire; the same as flammable

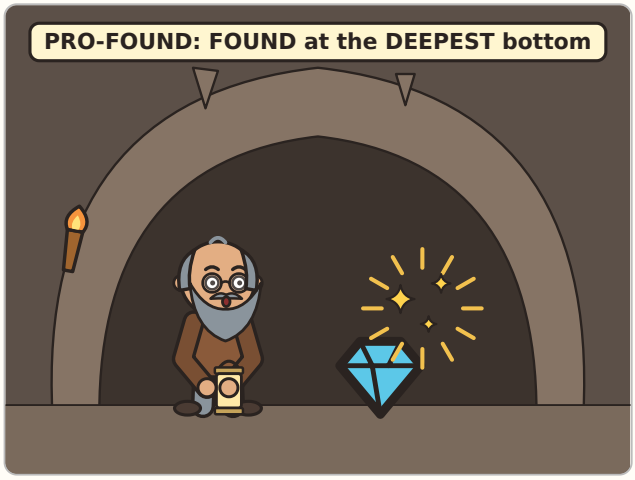
MEMORY HOOK **IN-FLAME-able: can go up IN FLAMES.** One spark could send the barrel up in flames, so Marcus keeps the torch far away; the barrel is **inflammable**: it burns easily.

Keep the **inflammable** *paint thinner far away from the stove.*

PARTS **in-** in, into (here not "not") + **flamm** flame + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR flammable, combustible, burnable
OPPOSITE fireproof, nonflammable, fire-resistant

profound pruh-**FOUND** *adjective*



MEANING very deep in thought, feeling or effect

MEMORY HOOK **PRO-FOUND: FOUND at the very bottom.** Professor Edwin climbs down to the deepest part of the cave and finds a glowing gem no one else ever reached; a thought that comes from that deep is **profound**.

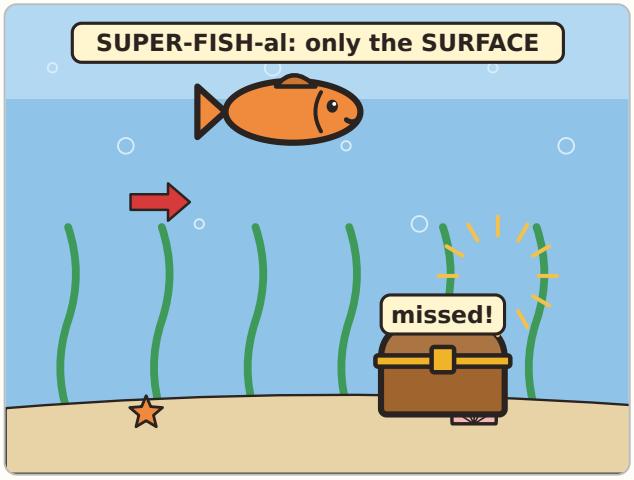
Grandma's quiet advice had a **profound** *effect on how I treat my friends.*

PARTS **pro-** forward, down + **fund** bottom

SIMILAR deep, insightful, intense, wise

OPPOSITE superficial, shallow, trivial

superficial soo-per-**FISH**-ul *adjective*



MEANING on the surface only; not deep or thorough

MEMORY HOOK **SUPER-FISH-al: only skims the SURFACE.** The little fish skims the top of the sea all day and never looks below, missing the treasure on the bottom; its view of the sea is **superficial**.

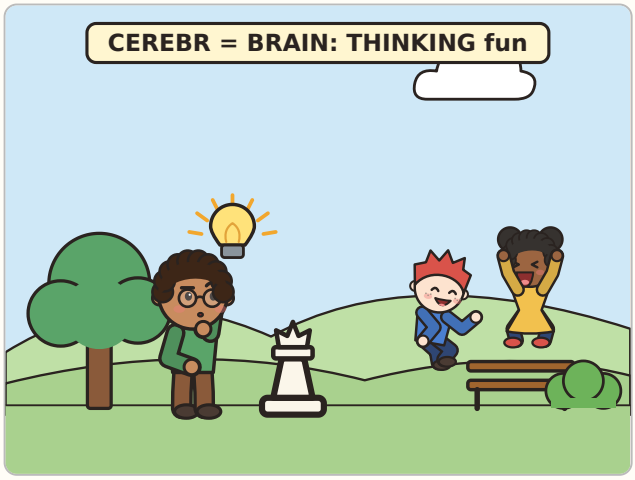
Luckily, the scratch on the car door was only **superficial**.

PARTS **super-** over, above + **fic (fac)** face, surface

SIMILAR shallow, surface, cursory, skin-deep

OPPOSITE profound, deep, thorough

cerebral suh-**REE**-brul *adjective*



MEANING having to do with careful thinking rather than feelings

MEMORY HOOK **CEREBRUM = the BRAIN: thinking fun.** While the other kids race around the field, Sami sits under a tree working out a chess puzzle; he likes the **cerebral** kind of fun.

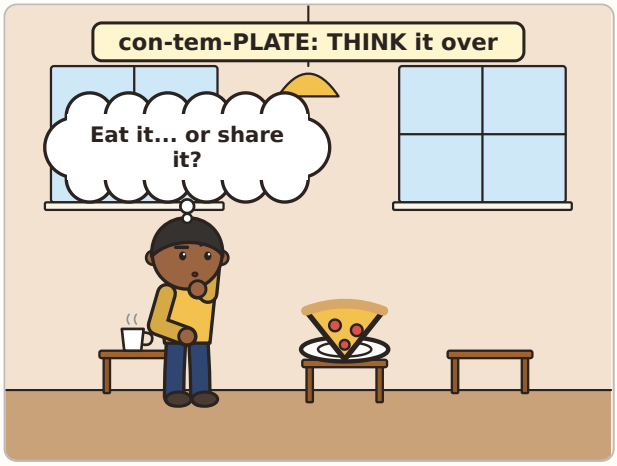
Chess is a **cerebral** *game, all planning and no luck.*

PARTS **cerebr** brain

SIMILAR intellectual, thoughtful, analytical, academic

OPPOSITE emotional, physical, instinctive

contemplate **KON**-tum-playt *verb*



MEANING to think long and carefully about something, or to look at it thoughtfully

MEMORY HOOK **con-tem-PLATE: staring at the PLATE, thinking.** Dev stares at the last slice of pizza on the plate for a long time: eat it or save it for his sister? He **contemplates** the question.

Rosa sat on the dock to **contemplate** *the sunset.*

PARTS **con-** thoroughly + **templ** an open space marked out for watching + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR ponder, mull over, reflect on, consider

OPPOSITE ignore, disregard

pensive PEN-siv *adjective*



MEANING quietly and deeply thoughtful, often a little sad

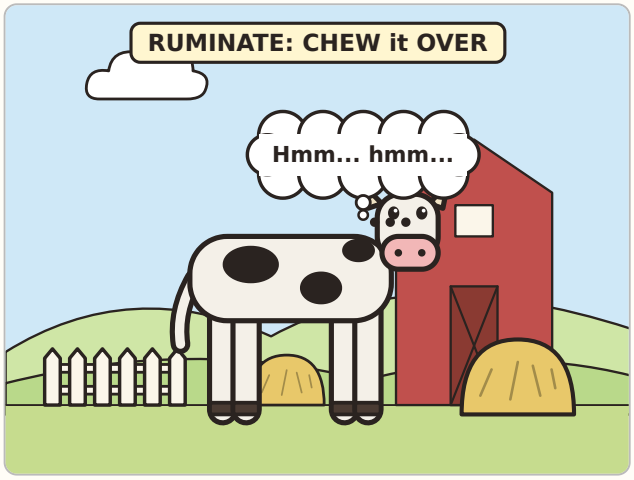
MEMORY HOOK **PEN-SIVE: chewing the PEN, lost in thought.** Lila sits by the rainy window chewing on her pen, thinking about the friend who moved away; she is quiet and **pensive**.

On the last day of camp, the **pensive** *campers watched the lake in silence.*

PARTS **pens** weigh, think + **-ive** tending to, doing

SIMILAR thoughtful, reflective, wistful, meditative
OPPOSITE carefree, lighthearted, thoughtless

ruminate ROO-muh-nayt *verb*



MEANING to think something over again and again

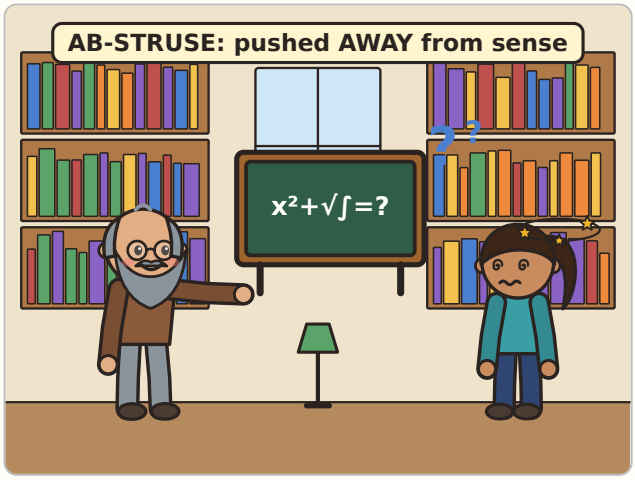
MEMORY HOOK **a COW chewing it over and over.** Daisy the cow chews the same mouthful of grass for an hour, round and round; to chew a thought over like that is to **ruminate**.

Kai lay awake, **ruminating** *about the easy goal he had missed.*

PARTS **rumin** throat, the cow's first stomach + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR ponder, mull over, reflect on, chew over
OPPOSITE dismiss

abstruse ab-**STROOS** *adjective*



MEANING very hard to understand

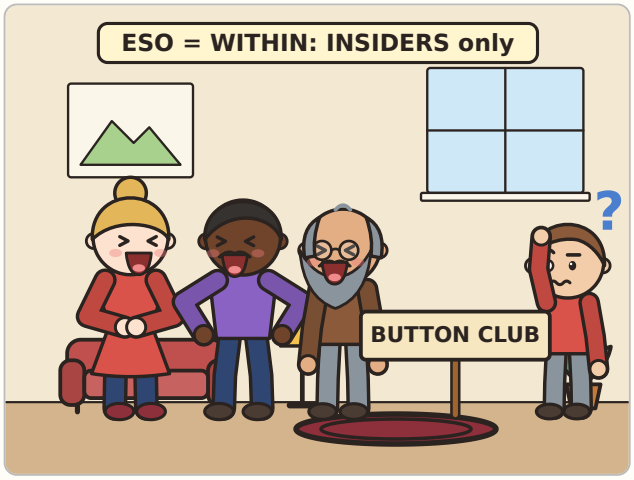
MEMORY HOOK **AB-STRUSE: pushed AWAY out of reach.** Professor Edwin fills the board with symbols so tangled that every student's head spins; the meaning is pushed far out of reach. His lecture is **abstruse**.

The professor's **abstruse** *lecture lost half the class in the first ten minutes.*

PARTS **abs- (ab-)** away + **trus** push

SIMILAR obscure, difficult, impenetrable, complex
OPPOSITE clear, simple, plain

esoteric es-uh-**TAIR**-ik *adjective*



MEANING understood or enjoyed by only a small group

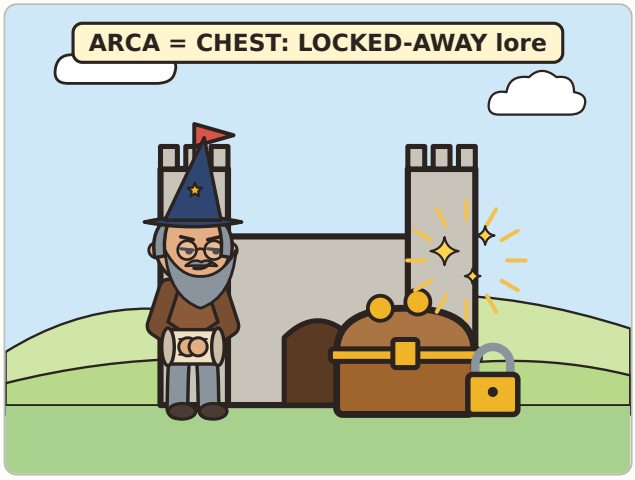
MEMORY HOOK **ESO = WITHIN: for INSIDERS only.** Inside the Button Club, three members laugh at a joke about four-hole buttons that no outsider understands; their humor is **esoteric**.

The club's **esoteric** *jokes about antique buttons made no sense to newcomers.*

PARTS **eso** within + **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR obscure, little-known, specialized, mysterious
OPPOSITE popular, familiar, well-known

arcane ar-**KANE** *adjective*



MEANING known or understood by only a few; mysterious

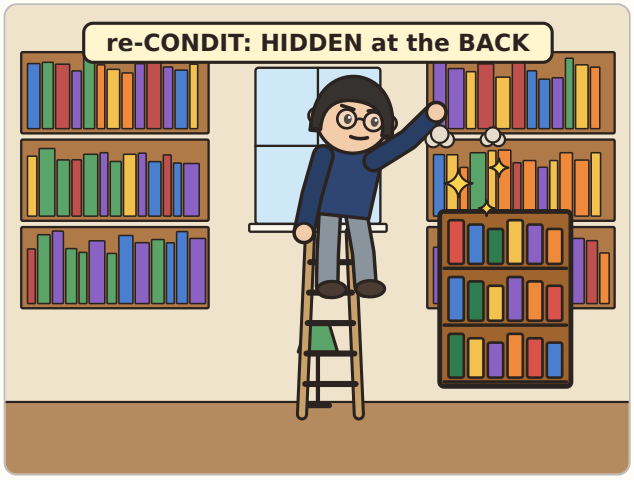
MEMORY HOOK **ARCA = CHEST: locked-away knowledge.** The old wizard keeps his strangest spells locked in a chest, written in a script only he can read; they are **arcane**.

The old book was full of **arcane** *rules for a card game no one plays anymore.*

PARTS **arc** chest, box

SIMILAR mysterious, obscure, little-known, specialized
OPPOSITE common, familiar, well-known

recondite **REK**-un-dite *adjective*



MEANING little known and hard to understand

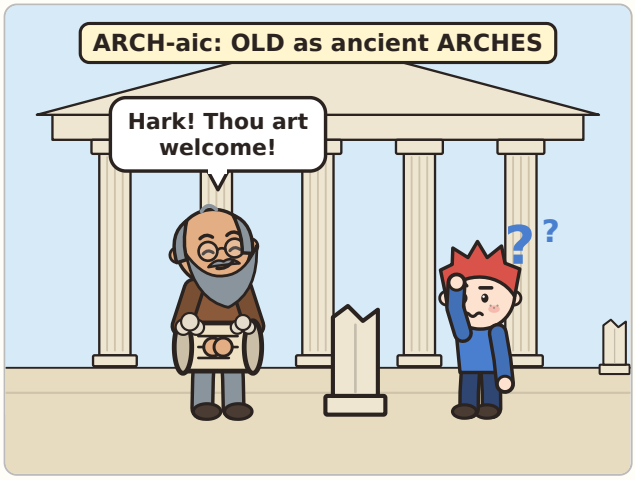
MEMORY HOOK **re-CONDIT: HIDDEN at the BACK.** Ada climbs to the dustiest shelf at the back of the library for a book on the moths of a single mountain; knowledge hidden that far back is **recondite**.

The quiz bowl team studied **recondite** *facts about ancient coins and rare beetles.*

PARTS **re-** back, away + **cond** put away, hide

SIMILAR obscure, little-known, difficult, specialized
OPPOSITE simple, familiar, common

archaic ar-**KAY**-ik *adjective*



MEANING very old, or no longer in everyday use

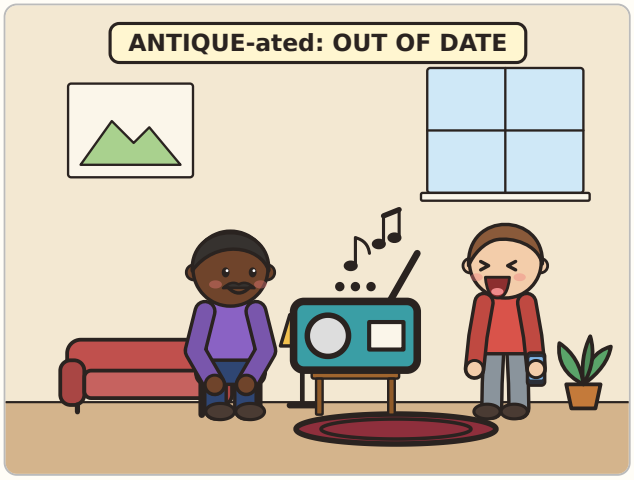
MEMORY HOOK **ARCH-aic: as old as a crumbling ARCH.** Among the broken columns, Professor Edwin reads aloud from a crumbling scroll: “Hark! Thou art welcome!” Words that old, no longer used, are **archaic**.

“Thou” and “thee” are **archaic** *words for “you.”*

PARTS **arch** ancient, beginning + **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR old-fashioned, outdated, obsolete, ancient
OPPOSITE modern, current, up-to-date

antiquated **AN**-tih-kway-tid *adjective*



MEANING old-fashioned and out of date

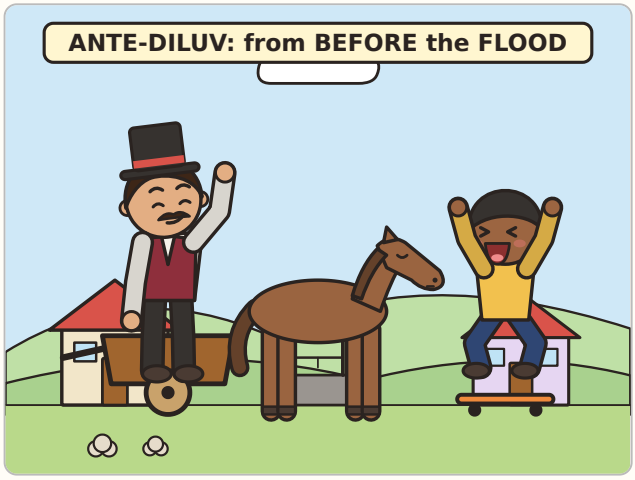
MEMORY HOOK **ANTIQUE-ATED: belongs in an ANTIQUE shop.** Uncle Marcus still listens to the news on a radio the size of a suitcase that crackles more than it talks; it belongs in an antique shop. It is **antiquated**.

The office still used an **antiquated** *fax machine that jammed every afternoon.*

PARTS **antiqu** old + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR outdated, old-fashioned, obsolete, outmoded
OPPOSITE modern, up-to-date, new

antediluvian an-tee-dih-**LOO**-vee-un *adjective*



MEANING extremely old or old-fashioned (often said as a joke)

MEMORY HOOK **ANTE-DILUV: from BEFORE the FLOOD.** Uncle Victor rides to town in a creaky wooden cart pulled by an old horse, while the kids zoom past on skateboards; his ride seems to date from before the great flood. It is **antediluvian**.

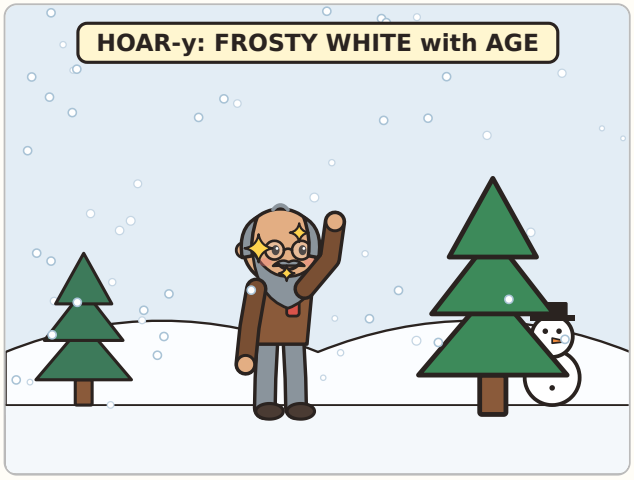
My uncle's **antediluvian** *computer takes ten minutes to start.*

PARTS **ante-** before + **diluv** flood + **-ian** belonging to

SIMILAR outdated, old-fashioned, obsolete, outmoded

OPPOSITE modern, up-to-date, newfangled

hoary **HOR**-ee *adjective*



MEANING very old; gray or white with age

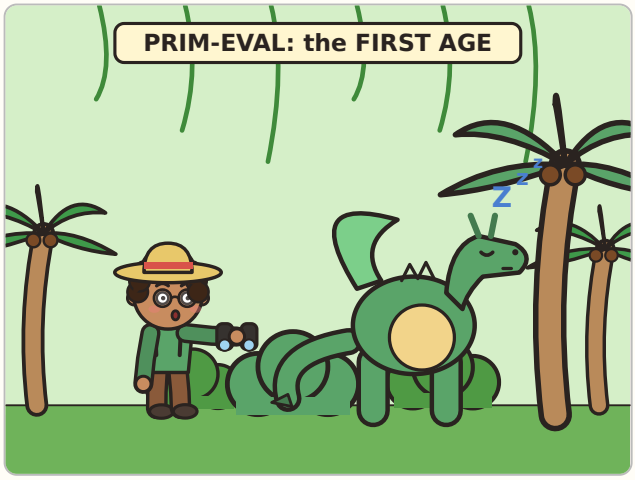
MEMORY HOOK **HOAR-FROST white: gray with AGE.** Professor Edwin's beard is so long and white that it looks dusted with frost; he is **hoary** with age.

The **hoary** *old oak had stood in the village square for three hundred years.*

SIMILAR ancient, aged, gray, timeworn

OPPOSITE young, new, fresh

primeval prye-**MEE**-vul *adjective*



MEANING belonging to the earliest ages of the world

MEMORY HOOK **PRIM-EVAL: the very FIRST AGE.** Deep in the jungle, Sami finds a valley where giant plants tower overhead and a dragon-sized lizard dozes, as if the world's first age had never ended; the place is **primeval**.

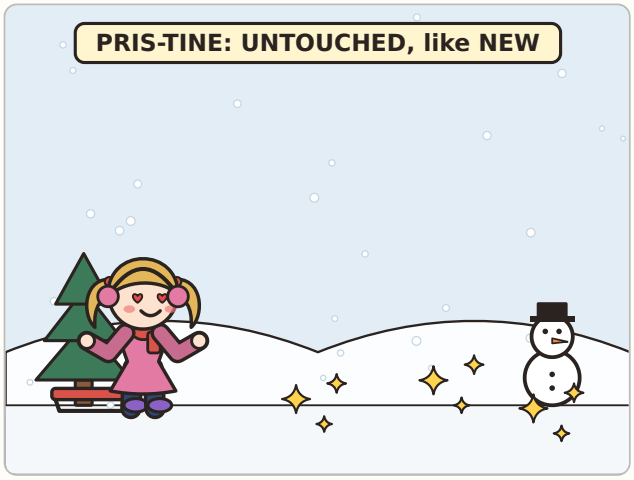
The explorers hiked through a **primeval** *forest of giant ferns and moss-covered trees.*

PARTS **prim** first + **ev** age

SIMILAR ancient, primordial, prehistoric, primal

OPPOSITE modern, recent

pristine pris-**TEEN** *adjective*



MEANING in its original condition; unspoiled

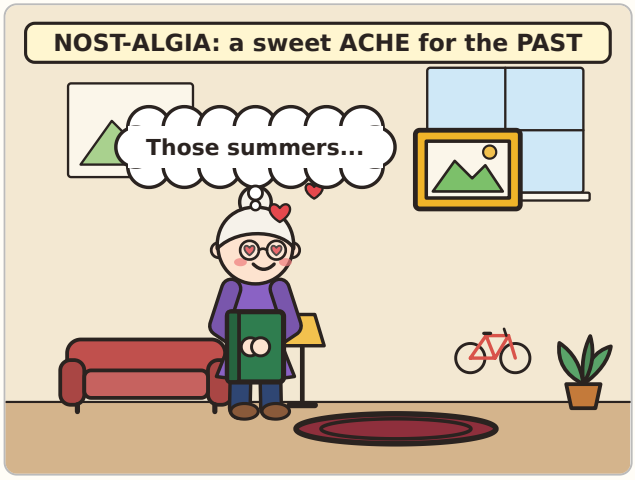
MEMORY HOOK **PRIS-TINE: fresh snow no one has touched.** Ivy steps outside at dawn and finds the field covered in smooth new snow, without a single footprint; she can hardly bear to walk on it, because it is **pristine**.

The old comic book was in **pristine** *condition, without a single crease.*

SIMILAR unspoiled, untouched, perfect, immaculate

OPPOSITE spoiled, damaged, polluted

nostalgia nuh-**STAL**-juh *noun*



MEANING a fond, wistful longing for the past

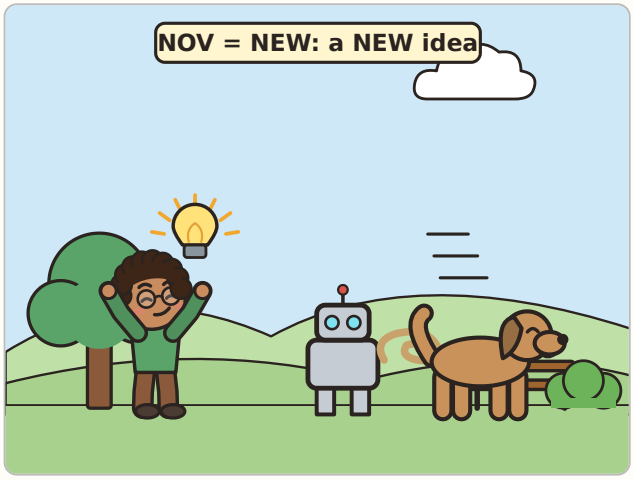
MEMORY HOOK **NOST-ALGIA: a sweet ACHE for the past.** Granny Mae turns the pages of her old photo album and smiles at her first bicycle and her childhood dog; the sweet ache she feels is **nostalgia**.

The smell of popcorn filled Grandpa with **nostalgia** *for the movie theater of his childhood.*

PARTS **nost** return home + **alg** pain, ache + **-ia** a state or condition

SIMILAR wistfulness, longing, homesickness, reminiscence

novel **NOV**-ul *adjective*



MEANING new and unusual

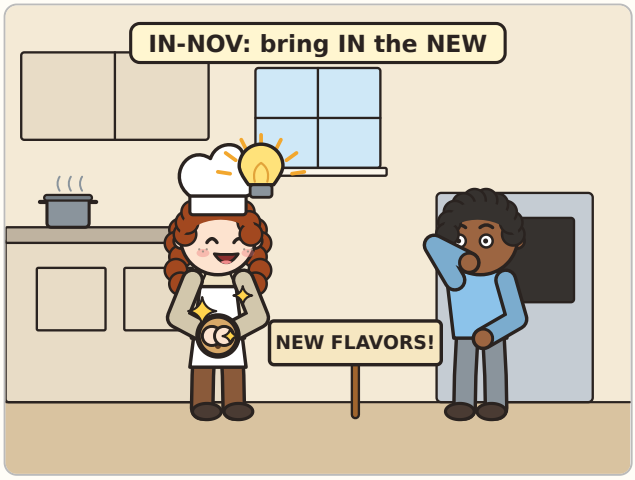
MEMORY HOOK **NOV = NEW: a brand-NEW idea.** Sami builds a little robot that walks the dog for him, leash and all; no one in town has seen anything like it. The idea is **novel**.

Using a kite to deliver the birthday card was a **novel** *idea.*

PARTS **nov** new

SIMILAR new, original, fresh, unusual
OPPOSITE old, familiar, conventional

innovative **IN**-uh-vay-tiv *adjective*



MEANING bringing in new ideas or ways of doing things

MEMORY HOOK **IN-NOV: bring IN the NEW.** Nell bakes cookies no one has ever tasted, pepper-honey and lemon-basil, and hangs a sign saying NEW FLAVORS; she is **innovative**.

The school's **innovative** *garden program teaches math through planting.*

PARTS **in-** in, into + **nov** new + **-ive** tending to, doing

SIMILAR inventive, creative, original, groundbreaking
OPPOSITE conventional, traditional, unoriginal

avant-garde ah-vahnt-**GARD** *adjective*



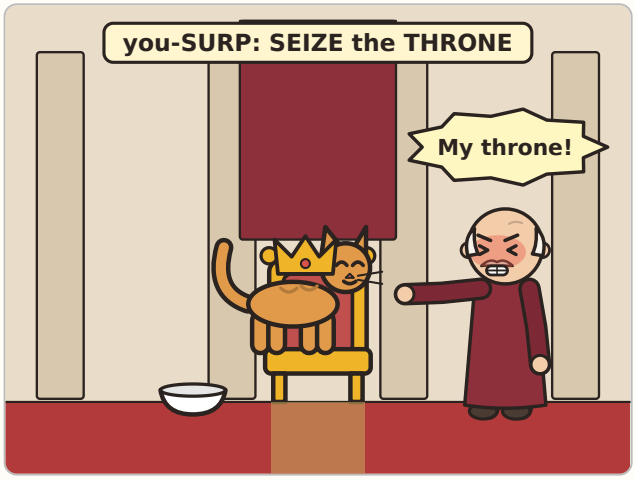
MEANING new and experimental, especially in the arts

MEMORY HOOK **AVANT (ahead) + GARDE (guard).** Nell paints with her feet, her elbows and a dripping mop, far ahead of what anyone else is trying; her art is **avant-garde**.

The museum's new wing shows **avant-garde** *paintings that look nothing like traditional art.*

SIMILAR experimental, cutting-edge, unconventional, groundbreaking
OPPOSITE traditional, conventional, old-fashioned

usurp yoo-**SURP** *verb*



MEANING to take a position or power without the right to it

MEMORY HOOK **you SLURP my soup, you SIT on my throne?.** While the king naps, the cat climbs onto his throne, puts on his crown and slurps his soup; it has no right to rule, but it **usurps** the throne.

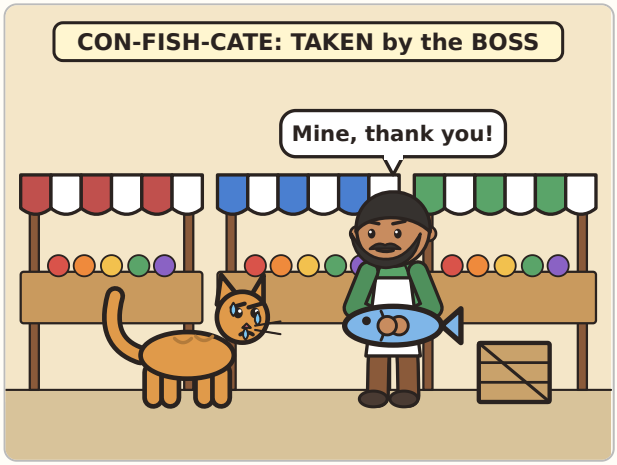
The scheming duke tried to **usurp** *the throne while the young queen was away.*

PARTS **us** use + **urp (rap)** seize

SIMILAR seize, take over, grab, arrogate

OPPOSITE abdicate, surrender

confiscate **KON**-fuh-skayt *verb*



MEANING to take something away by authority

MEMORY HOOK **CON-FISH-CATE: the CAT loses the FISH.** The fish seller catches the cat with a stolen fish and, as boss of the stall, takes it right back and locks it in the cooler; he **confiscates** it.

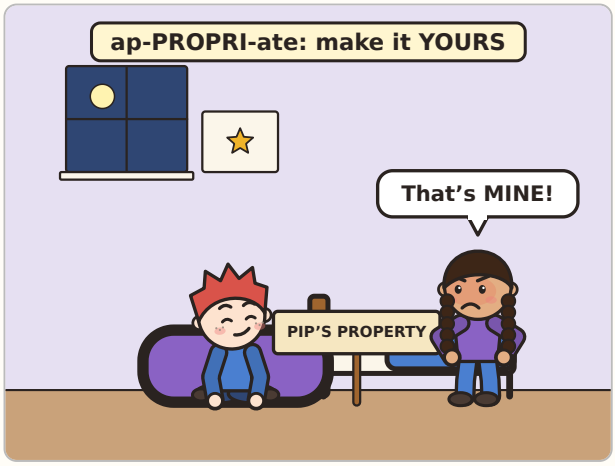
The teacher **confiscated** *the phones and kept them in a drawer until the end of class.*

PARTS **con-** together, with + **fisc** treasury (literally a basket) + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR seize, take away, impound, take

OPPOSITE return, give back, restore

appropriate uh-**PROH**-pree-ayt *verb*



MEANING to take something for one's own use, often without permission

MEMORY HOOK **ap-PROPRI-ate: make it your PROPERty.** Pip plops down on Lila's comfy beanbag, sticks a sign on it that says "PIP'S PROPERTY" and will not budge; he has **appropriated** it.

My little brother **appropriated** *my best pillow and refused to give it back.*

PARTS **ap- (ad-)** to + **propri** one's own (as in property) + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR seize, take, steal, grab

OPPOSITE return, surrender, give

commandeer kom-un-**DEER** *verb*



MEANING to take over something for official or urgent use

MEMORY HOOK **COMMAND HERE: this boat is needed!.** The flood captain points at the fisherman's rowboat and calls out, "I need this boat for the rescue, right here, right now!" She **commandeers** it.

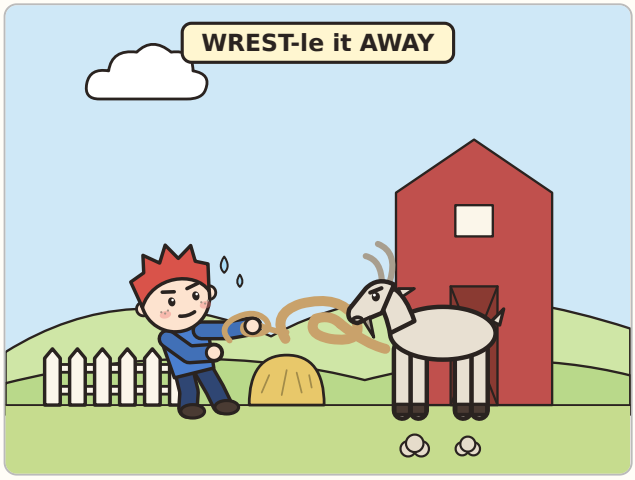
The firefighters **commandeered** *a neighbor's garden hose to soak the burning shed.*

PARTS **mand** order, command

SIMILAR seize, take over, requisition, grab

OPPOSITE release, return

wrest REST *verb*



MEANING to pull or take away by force or great effort

MEMORY HOOK **WREST-le it AWAY.** Pip and the goat both grab the same rope; after a long tug and twist, Pip wrestles it free. He **wrests** it from the goat.

Lila finally **wrested** *the stuck lid off the pickle jar.*

SIMILAR wrench, seize, pry, extract
OPPOSITE release, yield

relinquish rih-**LING**-kwish *verb*



MEANING to give up or let go of something

MEMORY HOOK **re-LINQU: LEAVE it behind, hand it OVER.** After forty years at sea, the old captain hands the ship's wheel to the new young captain and steps back; he **relinquishes** command.

The toddler refused to **relinquish** *the television remote.*

PARTS **re-** back, behind + **linqu** leave

SIMILAR give up, surrender, hand over, let go
OPPOSITE keep, retain, seize

renounce rih-**NOWNS** *verb*



MEANING to formally give up a claim, right or habit

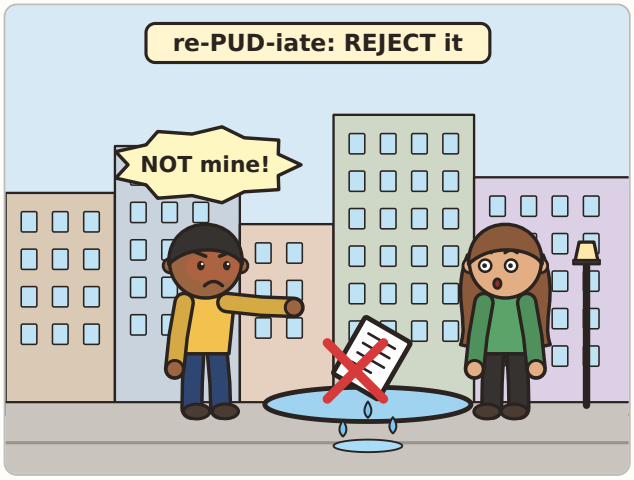
MEMORY HOOK **re-NOUNCE: ANNOUNCE you GIVE IT UP.** Standing on a chair at dinner, Grandpa Gus announces to the whole family, "I give up cookies forever!" He **renounces** sweets.

The prince **renounced** *his right to the throne so he could become a painter.*

PARTS **re-** back + **nounce** announce, report

SIMILAR give up, reject, abandon, forswear
OPPOSITE claim, keep, embrace

repudiate rih-**PYOO**-dee-ayt *verb*



MEANING to refuse to accept or be connected with

MEMORY HOOK **re-PUDDLE-ate: toss it in the PUDDLE.** Someone hands Dev a rude note signed with his name; he crumples it and tosses it into a puddle, shouting, "Not mine!" He **repudiates** it.

The scientist **repudiated** *her earlier claim after new tests proved it wrong.*

PARTS **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR reject, disown, deny, disavow
OPPOSITE accept, embrace, acknowledge

forfeit **FOR**-fit *verb*



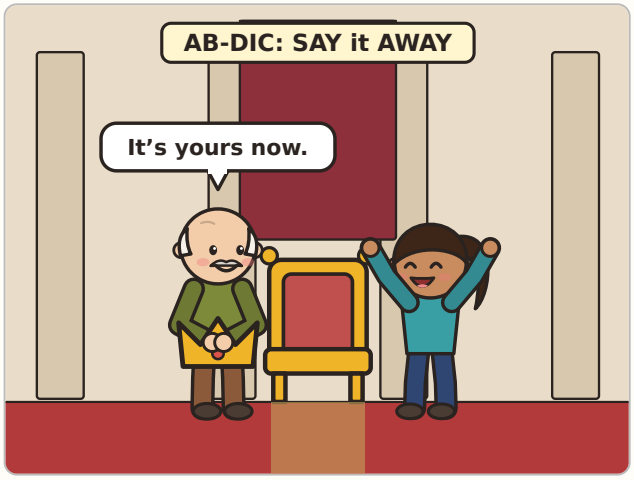
MEANING to lose something as a penalty

MEMORY HOOK **too FEW to play: FOR-FEIT.** Only three players show up for the big final, so the team must give up the game and the trophy without playing; they **forfeit**.

The team **forfeited** *the game when only six players showed up.*

SIMILAR lose, give up, surrender, sacrifice
OPPOSITE win, keep, gain

abdicate **AB**-dih-kayt *verb*



MEANING to give up a throne, an office or a responsibility

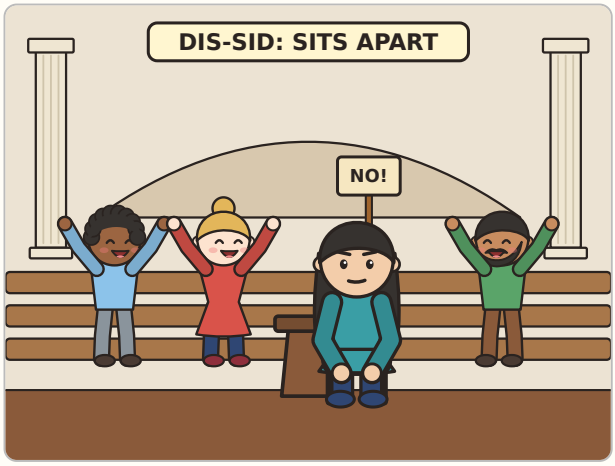
MEMORY HOOK **AB-DIC: SAY it AWAY: "No longer king!".** The tired old king lifts off his crown, sets it on his daughter's head and says, "It is yours now." He **abdicates**.

The old king **abdicated** *in favor of his daughter.*

PARTS **ab-** away + **dic** say, declare + **-ate** to make, to act on (in verbs)

SIMILAR resign, step down, give up, quit
OPPOSITE assume, take on, seize

dissident **DIS**-ih-dunt *noun*



MEANING a person who openly disagrees with an official policy or ruling group

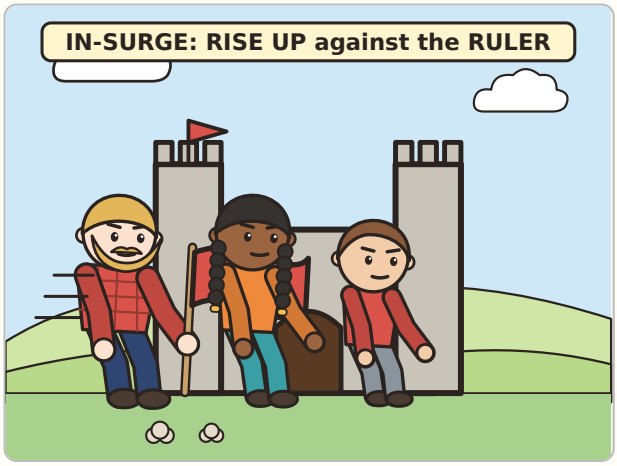
MEMORY HOOK **DIS-SID: SITS APART from the crowd.** When the whole hall stands to cheer the king's new tax, Lin stays in her seat with her arms crossed; she sits apart, a **dissident**.

The old kingdom jailed any **dissident** *who spoke out against the king's harsh taxes.*

PARTS **dis-** apart + **sid (sed)** sit + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR dissenter, protester, rebel, nonconformist
OPPOSITE supporter, loyalist, conformist

insurgent in-**SUR**-junt *noun*



MEANING a rebel who fights against a government or those in power

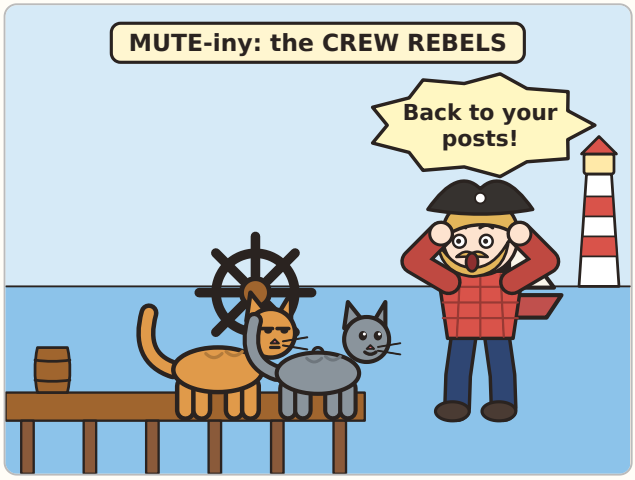
MEMORY HOOK **IN-SURGE: SURGE UP against the rulers.** In the old story, the hill folk surge up the slope toward the cruel baron's castle, waving their banner; each of them is an **insurgent**.

In the old tale, the **insurgents** *hid in the mountains and raided the baron's supply wagons.*

PARTS **in-** against, on + **surg** rise + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR rebel, revolutionary, guerrilla, mutineer
OPPOSITE loyalist

mutiny MYOO-tih-nee *noun*



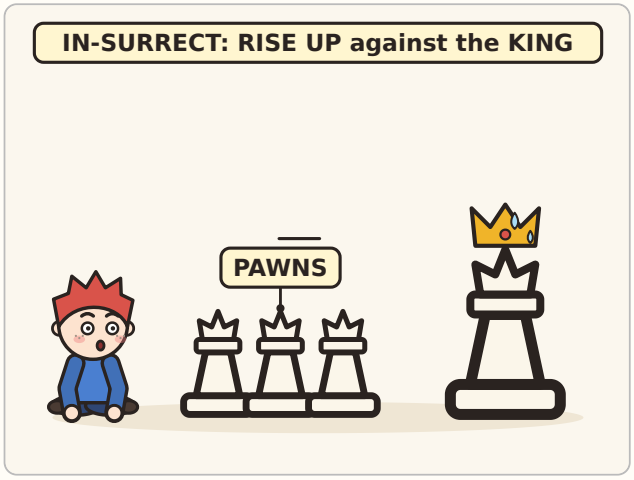
MEANING a rebellion, especially by sailors or soldiers against their officers

MEMORY HOOK **MUTE-iny: the crew won't stay MUTE.** On the fishing boat, the ship's cats, fed up with sardines, take over the wheel and steer for the cheese island while the captain splutters; it is a **mutiny**!

Tired of moldy biscuits, the sailors staged a **mutiny** *and locked the captain in his cabin.*

SIMILAR rebellion, revolt, uprising, insurgency
OPPOSITE obedience, loyalty

insurrection in-suh-REK-shun *noun*



MEANING a violent uprising against a government or authority

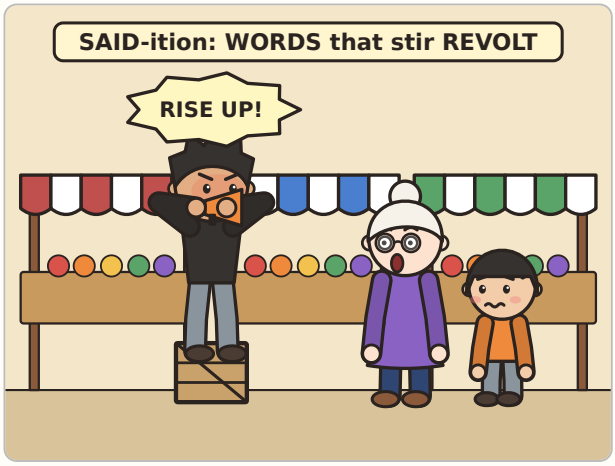
MEMORY HOOK **IN-SURRECT: the pawns RISE UP.** In Pip's dream, the little chess pawns rise up all at once and chase the king right off the board; it is an **insurrection**.

The governor sent troops to put down the **insurrection** *in the northern provinces.*

PARTS **in-** against, on + **surrect (surg)** rise + **-tion** the act or result of

SIMILAR uprising, rebellion, revolt, insurgency
OPPOSITE obedience, submission

sedition sih-DISH-un *noun*



MEANING speech or action that stirs people to rebel against a government

MEMORY HOOK **SAID-ition: words SAID to stir a revolt.** Standing on a crate in the market, Rex shouts for the crowd to rise up against the queen; words like that are **sedition**.

The printer was arrested for **sedition** *after publishing pamphlets urging people to overthrow the king.*

PARTS **sed- (se-)** apart + **it** go + **-ion (-tion)** the act or result of

SIMILAR incitement, agitation, subversion, rabble-rousing
OPPOSITE loyalty, allegiance

renegade REN-ih-gayd *noun*



MEANING a person who deserts a group or cause, or who breaks the rules

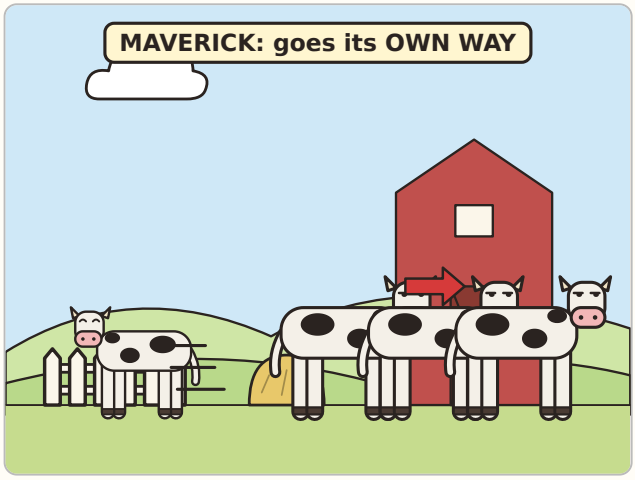
MEMORY HOOK **RENE-GADE: RAN from the GATE.** In the night, Sir Dev slips out through the castle gate and runs to join the outlaws in the woods; he is a **renegade**.

The **renegade** *knight left the king's army and joined the outlaws in the forest.*

PARTS **re-** back, again + **neg** deny

SIMILAR deserter, traitor, turncoat, outlaw
OPPOSITE loyalist, follower

maverick **MAV**-er-ik *noun*



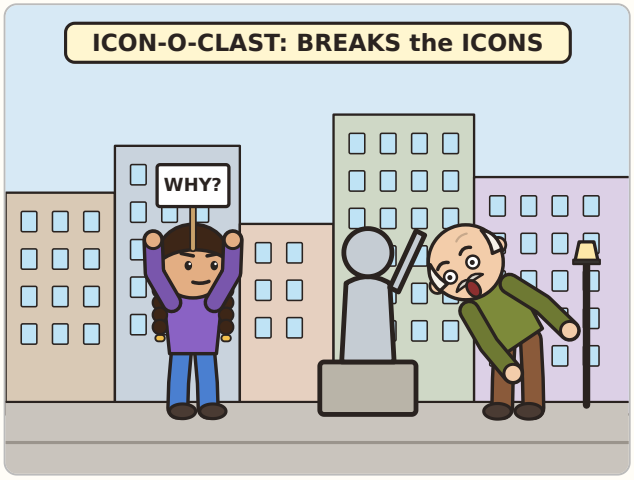
MEANING an independent person who does not go along with the group

MEMORY HOOK **the CALF that goes its OWN WAY.** Every cow in the herd plods toward the barn, but one young calf trots off the other way to explore the hill; it is a **maverick**.

*A **maverick** among bakers, Nell puts pickles in her chocolate cake.*

SIMILAR nonconformist, individualist, free spirit, rebel
OPPOSITE conformist, follower

iconoclast eye-**KON**-uh-klast *noun*



MEANING a person who attacks cherished beliefs or traditions

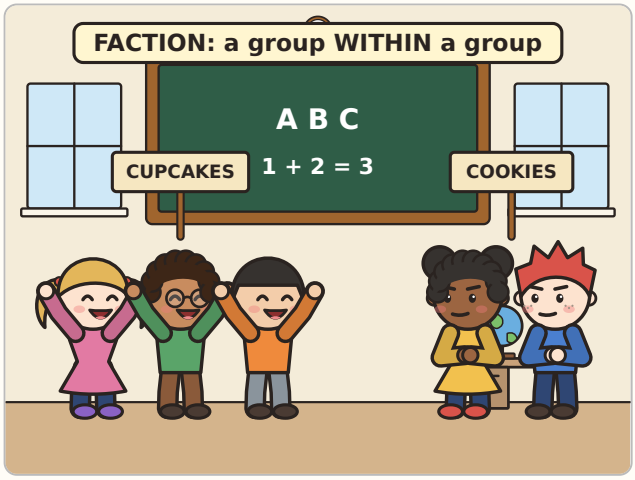
MEMORY HOOK **ICON-O-CLAST: breaks the town's ICONS.** While the whole town bows to the old statue, Lila holds up a sign asking why, and says the town's favorite traditions are silly; she is an **iconoclast**.

*The young chef was an **iconoclast** who served dessert first and breakfast for dinner.*

PARTS **icon** image + **clast** breaker

SIMILAR rebel, nonconformist, radical, dissenter
OPPOSITE conformist, traditionalist, follower

faction **FAK**-shun *noun*



MEANING a small group within a larger one, often at odds with the rest

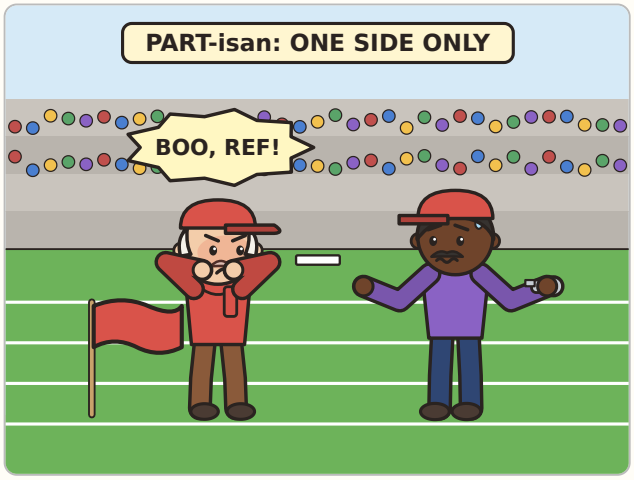
MEMORY HOOK **FACTION: a group that splits OFF.** At the bake-sale meeting, two kids march to their own corner, insisting on cookies while everyone else wants cupcakes; they are a **faction**.

*The chess club split into two **factions**: those who wanted a tournament and those who wanted pizza nights.*

PARTS **fact** do, make + **-tion** the act or result of

SIMILAR group, camp, bloc, splinter group

partisan **PAR**-tih-zun *adjective*



MEANING strongly supporting one side, often without fairness

MEMORY HOOK **PART-isan: on ONE PART (side) only.** Grandpa wears his team's colors from hat to socks, cheers every play for his side and boos every call against it; he is **partisan**.

*The **partisan** crowd booed every call that went against the home team.*

PARTS **part** part, side

SIMILAR one-sided, biased, prejudiced, factional
OPPOSITE impartial, neutral, nonpartisan

detrimental det-ruh-**MEN**-tul *adjective*



MEANING causing harm or damage

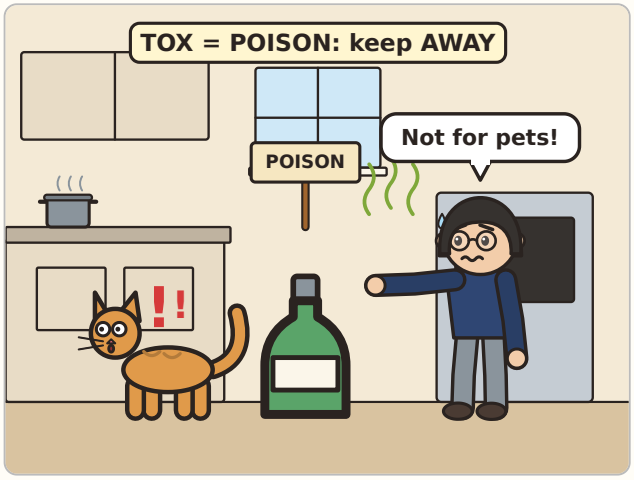
MEMORY HOOK **de-TRIM-ental: too much TRIM does HARM.** Pip trims Grandpa's little bush, then trims some more, and more, until only a bare stick is left; all that trimming is **detrimental** to the bush.

Staying up all night is **detrimental** *to your grades.*

PARTS **de-** away, off

SIMILAR harmful, damaging, injurious, destructive
OPPOSITE beneficial, helpful, salutary

toxic **TOK**-sik *adjective*



MEANING poisonous; harmful to living things

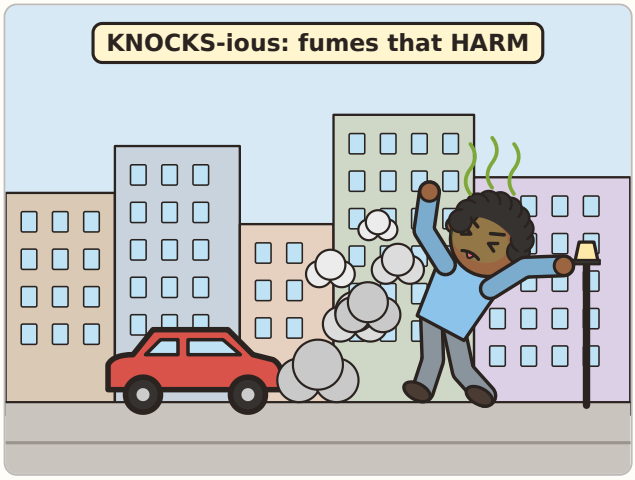
MEMORY HOOK **TOX = POISON: keep AWAY.** The bottle under the sink has a big warning label and a skull on it; what is inside is **toxic**, so the cat backs away.

Some common garden flowers are **toxic** *to cats.*

PARTS **tox** poison + **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR poisonous, harmful, noxious
OPPOSITE harmless, nontoxic, safe

noxious **NOK**-shus *adjective*



MEANING harmful, especially to health; also, very unpleasant

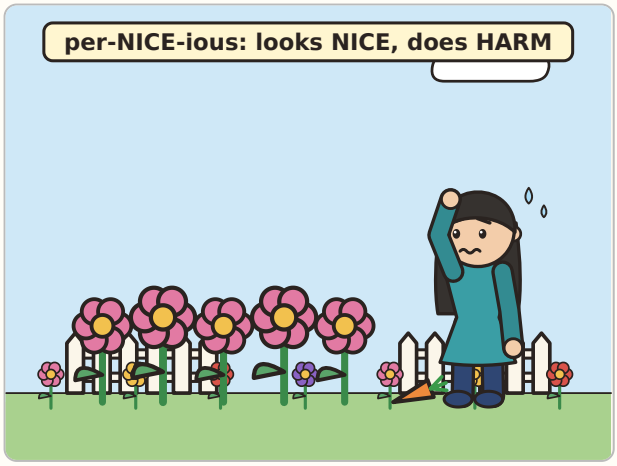
MEMORY HOOK **KNOCKS-ious: fumes that KNOCK you back.** The old truck coughs out a black cloud so foul that it nearly knocks the jogger off his feet; its fumes are **noxious**.

The **noxious** *fumes from the burning tires drove everyone indoors.*

PARTS **nox** harm + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR poisonous, harmful, foul, toxic
OPPOSITE harmless, wholesome, beneficial

pernicious per-**NISH**-us *adjective*



MEANING causing great harm, often slowly or in a way that is hard to see

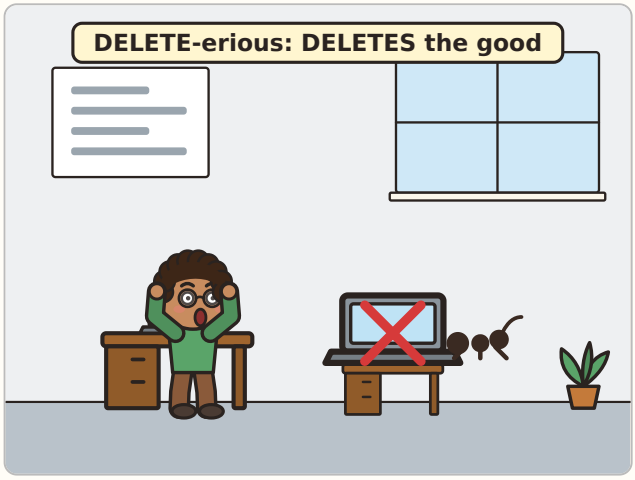
MEMORY HOOK **per-NICE-ious: looks NICE, does HARM.** The pretty pink flowers spreading through Lin's garden look nice, but week by week they choke out every bean and carrot; the weed is **pernicious**.

Gossip can have a **pernicious** *effect on a friendship.*

PARTS **per-** thoroughly + **nic (nec)** death, destruction + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR harmful, damaging, destructive, injurious
OPPOSITE harmless, benign, beneficial

deleterious del-ih-**TEER**-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING harmful, often in a way that is not obvious at first

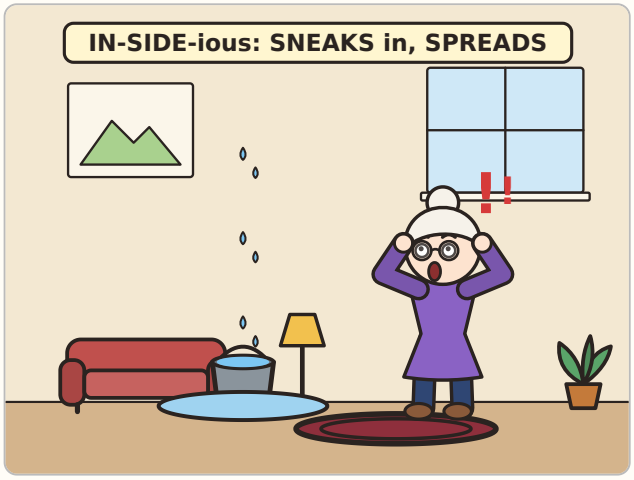
MEMORY HOOK **DELETE-erious: it DELETES the good.** A sneaky computer bug deletes one of Sami's files every night, until his whole science project is nearly gone; the bug is **deleterious**.

Too much sun can have **deleterious** *effects on your skin.*

PARTS **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR harmful, damaging, injurious, destructive
OPPOSITE beneficial, salutary, wholesome

insidious in-**SID**-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING spreading harm slowly and secretly

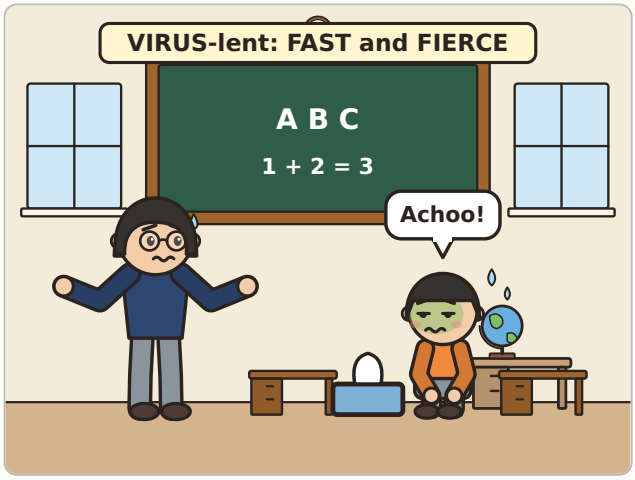
MEMORY HOOK **IN-SIDE-ious: harm that sneaks INSIDE.** A tiny leak drips inside the wall for months where no one can see it, until the ceiling sags; the damage is **insidious**.

Rust is **insidious***: it eats away at a bridge long before anyone sees the damage.*

PARTS **in-** in + **sid** sit (lie in wait) + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR stealthy, creeping, sneaky, treacherous
OPPOSITE obvious, open, harmless

virulent **VEER**-yuh-lunt *adjective*



MEANING extremely harmful or severe; also, bitterly hostile

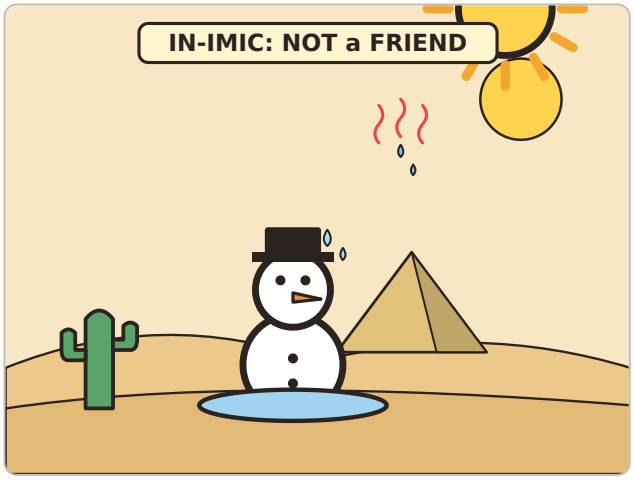
MEMORY HOOK **VIRUS-lent: a VIRUS at full strength.** This flu spreads so fast and hits so hard that by Friday only one student is left in the classroom; it is **virulent**.

A **virulent** *flu swept through the school, closing it for a week.*

PARTS **vir (virus)** poison, venom + **-ulent** full of

SIMILAR severe, deadly, venomous, vicious
OPPOSITE mild, harmless, benign

inimical ih-**NIM**-ih-kul *adjective*



MEANING harmful or unfriendly, like an enemy

MEMORY HOOK **IN-IMIC: NOT AMICable, NOT a friend.** The snowman who wandered into the desert finds the blazing sun no friend at all; the heat is **inimical** to him.

Cold, salty air is **inimical** *to most tropical plants.*

PARTS **in-** not + **im (am)** friend, love + **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR harmful, hostile, unfriendly, adverse
OPPOSITE friendly, favorable, beneficial

salutary **SAL**-yuh-tair-ee *adjective*



MEANING having a good effect, often after a hard lesson

MEMORY HOOK **SALUTE-ary: a lesson worth SALUTING.** After missing the bus once, Dev sets an alarm every night and never misses it again; he salutes the lesson, which was **salutary**.

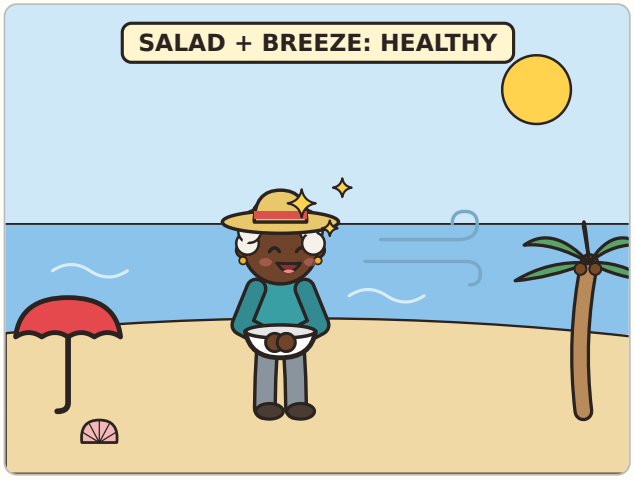
Losing the first game had a **salutary** *effect on the team: they practiced twice as hard.*

PARTS **salu (salus)** health, safety + **-ary** having to do with

SIMILAR beneficial, wholesome, healthful, helpful

OPPOSITE harmful, detrimental, deleterious

salubrious suh-**LOO**-bree-us *adjective*



MEANING good for one's health

MEMORY HOOK **SALAD + BREEZE: so HEALTHY.** Every day Nana Lou eats a fresh salad in the cool sea breeze; her seaside town is **salubrious**.

The village was known for its **salubrious** *climate, with clean air and mild summers.*

PARTS **salu (salus)** health + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR healthful, wholesome, healthy, beneficial

OPPOSITE unhealthy, noxious, insalubrious